

Olden Era Companion

The Complete Strategy Handbook for Heroes of Might and Magic: Olden Era

The Olden Era Companion Project

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How to Use This Book

Heroes of Might and Magic: Olden Era rewards two kinds of knowledge: knowing what the numbers are, and knowing what they mean. The wiki has the first kind. This book exists for the second — and it never asks you to take the second kind on faith, because the first is always printed right next to it.

The three-layer format

Every entry in this book — every spell, faction, skill, and artifact — follows the same shape:

1. **Reference.** What the thing does, in plain English, with the exact formulas and verified numbers from official sources. No analysis, no opinion. If the source data has a gap, the entry says so instead of inventing something.
2. **Analysis.** The math worked out: what the formula produces at real values, how it compares to its rivals, where it's strong, where it's weak, and the mistakes people actually make with it.
3. **Campaign Recommendation.** A verdict — star rating, best users, and when to pick it — written for single-player campaign play unless an entry says otherwise.

The reference army

Combat math in the spell chapters is anchored to one consistent example so every number is comparable across the whole book: a stack of **20 Onyx Dancers** — a real Dungeon Tier 3 ranged unit — with 18 HP each, ~120 damage per volley, 360 total stack HP, at **Spellpower 10**. When an entry says a spell “kills 7 dancers” or “saves a volley,” that’s the yardstick. Attack-vs-Defense modifiers are deliberately ignored in these examples (each point shifts damage ~5%; the full pipeline is in the Combat Mechanics appendix) so each spell’s own contribution stays visible. Relative comparisons are exact; your absolute in-game numbers will differ.

The rating key

Icon	Meaning	Scale
	Overall Power	1–5
	Beginner Friendly	1–5
	Campaign Strength	1–5
	Economy Value	1–5

Icon	Meaning	Scale
	Skill Ceiling	1–5
	Early / Mid / Late Game	three separate 1–5 scores
	Campaign Verdict	the entry’s bottom line

A note on Skill Ceiling: high is not praise and low is not an insult. A 1/5 means the thing works on autopilot; a 5/5 means its rating assumes you’ll pilot it well — and warns you what it costs if you don’t.

Sourcing, honestly

Mechanics, formulas, stats, and costs come from the official Hooded Horse wiki and first-party stat documentation, with the retrieval date stamped in every chapter’s footer and in each file’s `patch_verified` field. Everything else — ratings, worked examples, synergies, builds, verdicts — is this book’s original analysis and is *labeled as such*. Where sources conflict or a page couldn’t be verified, the entry flags it rather than papering over it; the `_audit.md` files in the source tree track every known gap.

One warning worth repeating from nearly every chapter: **the game is in Early Access**. Numbers move. Every entry carries its verification date; when a balance patch lands, trust the patch notes over any number here until the entry’s date catches up.

A suggested reading order

- **New to the game:** the Combat Mechanics appendix first (ten minutes that make everything else legible), then the Temple faction chapter (the most forgiving faction, fully statted), then the Daylight Magic school.
- **Picking a faction:** the six faction chapters end in comparable verdicts, and the Matchup Grid chapter shows how they collide.
- **Building a hero:** Skills chapter → your faction’s “recommended magic schools” section → the Artifacts build packages.
- **Stuck on a specific fight:** the magic chapters’ “In battle” sections are indexed to exactly that question — what a cast is actually worth against a real army.

The Book at a Glance

The table of contents that follows is generated from the chapters themselves; this page is the curated version — what each part is *for*, and how complete it currently is.

Part I — Factions (six chapters + the Matchup Grid)

One chapter per faction: identity, the faction-exclusive skill with verified mechanics, the unit roster with full stat tables, recommended magic schools cross-referenced to Part II’s confirmed hero pairings, hero picks, three builds, and a verdict. **Temple, Necropolis, Grove, Hive, and Dungeon carry complete verified stat tables; Schism carries its full roster tree and verified T5/T7 stats** (its remaining rows are the book’s one persistent sourcing gap — the official page resists retrieval). The Matchup Grid closes the part with all thirty pairings rated and the three structural rules they obey.

Part II — Magic (five schools, 83 spells)

The book’s deepest section, and the one whose format everything else inherits. Every spell: plain English, the exact formula worked at all four levels, an “In battle” example against the reference army, the Masterful version and its owning hero where one exists, and a strategy layer with a verdict. Eleven Masterful hero pairings are confirmed from official sources, two near-confirmed, nine tracked as open. The Neutral Magic chapter also documents the level-gate and points systems unique to that school.

Part III — Heroes, Skills, Artifacts, Creatures

- **Skills:** the full 30-skill taxonomy, the rank-and-subskill fork system, a complete worked Offense tree, and the synergy-clause build philosophy. The six faction skills live in their faction chapters; the four school skills in their magic chapters.
- **Artifacts:** the 14-slot system, rarities, upgrading, set mechanics with both verified flagship sets, slot-by-slot standouts, and four assembled build packages.
- **Creatures:** the neutral bestiary — 21 creatures across 8 tiers, acquisition rules, and how to fight (or recruit) the map’s own army, up to the Tier-8 Lich Dragon.
- **Heroes:** hero-class and per-hero coverage beyond the pairings already embedded in Parts I–II is the roadmap’s next major pass.

Appendices

Combat Mechanics — the verified damage pipeline, morale/luck math, the creature-type table (including exactly what feeds Necromancy), and the documented stacking ceilings. The ten most load-bearing pages in the book; everything else’s shorthand resolves here.

What “complete” means in Early Access

Every chapter footer carries a retrieval date, and every category’s source folder carries an `_audit.md` ledger of verified content versus known gaps. This book’s standing rule: **a tracked gap over an invented number, every time.** When the game leaves Early Access and the remaining wiki pages fill in, the audits are the checklist for the final edition.

Foundations — how Olden Era actually works

The chapters after this one assume you know what a “growth week” or a “Focus Charge” is. This one is where those assumptions are paid for. Everything here is grounded in the same verified sources as the rest of the book; where a foundational number hasn’t been sourced yet, the entry says so.

The four currencies of the game

- 1. Gold.** Buys everything. Baseline income comes from towns and mines; the verified reference points scattered through this book give the scale: a T1 unit costs 35–115g, a T7 upgrade 2,000–5,000g, the Skull of Milos artifact prints +1,000g/day and is considered Legendary-tier for it.
- 2. Rare resources.** Every faction’s Tier 7 is gated behind one: **Gems** (Temple’s Angels, Dungeon’s Dragons), **Mercury** (Necropolis’s Vampires), **Crystal** (Grove’s Phoenixes, Hive’s Queens). Verified pattern worth exploiting: each faction fields an economy-specialist hero for exactly its own bottleneck resource (Heretic Avis/Gems, Zam/Mercury, Mreowa/Crystals) — the game telling you what to hire a second hero for. A Marketplace converts between resources at a loss; the Schism build-order sourcing calls it the “conversion fallback,” which is the right frame — a safety net, not a plan.
- 3. Time.** The real currency. The game runs on a **weekly rhythm**: creature growth replenishes town dwellings every week (Skeletons at 30/week down to T7s at 1–2/week), Necromantic Energy refills weekly, and every economy effect in this book is priced per day. Movement points are the daily unit of time — which is why the Neutral Magic chapter rates the logistics suite (Town Portal, Second Wind, Relocation) so highly: they are literally time-generation spells.
- 4. Army.** The only currency you fight with, and the one the factions disagree about most: Temple preserves it, Necropolis grows it from enemies, Grove pays premium gold for it, Hive spends it, Schism conjures it per-battle, Dungeon concentrates it. Reading a faction = knowing which conversion between the four currencies it’s best at.

The hero sheet

Four combat attributes, verified across the skills and hero sourcing: - **Attack / Defense** — feed the army-wide damage pipeline (each point 5% per the combat appendix). - **Spellpower** — scales spell formulas (the magic chapters’ entire math axis) and durations. - **Knowledge** — the

mana-side attribute (it also feeds the Avatar's stats directly, per the Neutral chapter). Exact mana-per-Knowledge formula: not yet sourced — tracked. - Plus **Sight** (scouting radius; the range multiplier for several map spells) and **Movement** (the daily budget; Second Wind's verified 40–60 restore gives the scale of a meaningful fraction).

Level-ups grant a random attribute point plus a three-way skill choice (fully documented in the Skills chapter). The compounding picks — Pip's +1 attribute per 2 levels, spell specialists' effective Spellpower bonuses — are the verified reason two heroes of equal level can be a tier apart in practice.

How a battle flows

1. **Tactics phase.** Deploy within your placement zone — 3 lines by default, up to 5 with the Tactics skill, *minus* lines if the enemy out-Tactics you (the one directly adversarial skill).
2. **Rounds and turns.** Units act in Initiative order; Wait defers. Morale grants extra turns (+4%/point), Luck grants bonus-damage strikes (+6%/point), native terrain grants +1 Initiative — all verified in the combat appendix, which also carries the full damage pipeline.
3. **The hero acts too.** One spell per round (school-masters partially except themselves from the same-school lockout), plus **Heroic Strike** — the hero's personal attack, which an entire verified toolkit modifies (Old Lord Mandall's +damage specialty, Caduceus's mana refund, Two-faced Mask's kill-reset, Murmuring's Expert damage rider). Treat it as a small spell with no mana cost.
4. **Focus.** Creatures earn Focus Points by attacking and being hit; banked points power their active abilities. The verified levers live in the Skills (Battle March), Magic (Energize, Silence), and Faction (Murmuring) chapters. Modern Olden Era combat runs on abilities — the book's recurring claim, and why Silence at 5 mana rates 4/5.
5. **Counterattacks** are the hidden tax on melee — one per round by default, spent by the first attacker. Half the verified roster quirks in this book (Hydras' no-counter clause, Vampire Lord's Swift Strike, Dawn Hoplets, Long Reach as a mechanic) are ways of not paying it. Plan melee engagements around whose counter is spent.
6. **Sieges** change the math entirely: walls, towers, and a gate force attackers through kill zones. The verified siege toolkit: Earth's Rage (the dedicated structure-nuke), Blink/flyers (over the walls), Siegecraft (the skill). The Matchup Grid's advice stands — the fights that decide campaigns are usually at a gate.

The campaign arc (original analysis, grounded in the verified curves)

Week 1 is fight selection. Your army is small and losses are unaffordable; the verified intel tools (Read Minds, Groundsight, the map-spell suite) exist for this week. Every faction chapter's build-order guidance targets the same milestone: a functioning core by Week 2 (Arbitrators, Dread Knight chains, Lightweavers via Zenith).

Weeks 2–4 are the snowball window. Growth compounds: each week's recruits, each cleared mine, each leveled skill multiplies the next. This is where the clock-based matchups from the grid are decided — tempo factions must convert their early edge before the inevitability factions' curves cross theirs.

Week 5+ belongs to whoever converted best. T7s come online (rare-resource permitting),

set bonuses and school-masters hit full scaling, and single battles start deciding maps. The verified late-game power spikes — Judgement’s 900, Chain Lightning’s chains, Armageddon builds, the morale-stack ceiling — all live here.

The one rule underneath all of it: every system in this game converts into every other (gold→army→XP→skills→bigger fights→more gold), and the factions are just different exchange rates. Play the conversion, not the turn.

Open gaps (tracked)

Exact mana/Knowledge and XP-curve formulas; movement-point base values per hero type; AI behavior documentation (the original brief’s fourth foundations topic — no reliable sourcing exists yet for Early Access AI patterns, and this book won’t invent them); weekly event types (plague/double-growth weeks etc.) pending a dedicated fetch.

Sourcing note: every specific number above is cross-referenced from this book’s verified chapters (combat appendix, faction stat tables, skills, magic, heroes); the campaign-arc framing and the four-currencies model are original analysis. Gaps are enumerated rather than filled with folklore.

Dungeon

Overall Power: 5/5 · Beginner Friendly: 3/5 · Campaign Strength: 4/5 Economy Value: 3/5 · Skill Ceiling: 4/5 Early: 4/5 · Mid: 4/5 · Late: 5/5

Reference

(What the wiki says, translated into plain English — no opinions yet.)

- **Governing body:** The Triumvirate of Alvar — formerly an underground power, now operating as the backstage rulers of Jadame.
- **Identity / theme:** Dark elves, beasts, and dragons. The faction’s signature trait is *flexibility* — nearly every unit has two distinct attack types rather than one fixed role.
- **Faction skill — Triumvirate’s Strength:** every Dungeon hero starts with this skill, and no other class can learn it. Once per turn, before or during combat, the hero picks one of three stances that buffs the whole army for that fight. The stance stays active until you switch it, so it also functions as a between-battle mode toggle:
 - **Minotaur Stance** → boosts Attack
 - **Dark Elf Stance** → boosts Defense
 - **Dragon Stance** → boosts Spell Power
- **Native terrain:** Underground (subterranean maps).
- **Key resource dependency:** Gems. Dungeon’s Tier-VII creature dwelling (Cave Palace, home of Dragons) requires Gems on top of Gold, and hiring the Dragons themselves also costs Gems, not just Gold. Ore is a secondary early bottleneck for mid-tier dwellings.
- **Unit roster (T1–T7), with upgrade paths:**

Tier	Base unit	Upgrade A	Upgrade B
T1	<i>(scout/cheap unit)</i>		
T2	Infiltrator	Guile Infiltrator	Bleak Infiltrator
T3	Dancer	Onyx Dancer	Jasper Dancer / Aureate Dancer*
T4	Minotaur	Minotaur Lord	Minotaur Vanguard
T5	Medusa	Medusa Sculptor	Medusa Queen
T6	Hydra	Chthonic Hydra	Infernal Hydra
T7	Cave Dragon	Black Dragon	Ashen Dragon

**Community sourcing lists both Jasper and Aureate Dancer as upgrade names in different builds — verify against the current patch before treating this row as final; flagged for the next audit pass.*

- **Hero classes:** Dungeon fields both a Might class and a Magic class.
 - **Overlord (Might):** like all Might heroes, cannot learn Thaumaturgy — leans on tactics, brute force, and the stance system instead of spells.

Analysis

(Why it matters — this is the original content, not wiki restatement.)

Strengths

- **Best-in-game clear speed.** Onyx Dancers give Dungeon the fastest, most efficient early-game ranged clearing of any of the six factions — the single biggest reason it's widely rated the strongest faction at launch.
- **Dual-attack flexibility.** Because most units carry two attack types, Dungeon armies adapt to a wider range of enemy compositions than single-role rosters.
- **Stance system gives free, repeatable tactical flexibility** — you're never locked into one buff profile for the whole game the way a fixed passive would lock you.
- **Best late-game payoff in the game.** A Black Dragon stack backed by upgraded ranged units is considered one of the single strongest late-game army configurations across all factions.

Weaknesses

- Gem-gated Tier VII means the strongest unit in the roster is the most resource-fragile — a Gem-poor map materially delays your win condition.
- Early roster (Infiltrators) is fragile and easy to over-invest in if you're new to the faction; it looks like a core unit and isn't.
- Rewards map knowledge and resource-route planning more than factions with flatter power curves — part of why it's rated only middling on beginner-friendliness despite being top-tier in raw power.

Economic priorities

1. **Ore** first — gates several mid-tier dwellings and is the first hard bottleneck.
2. **Gems** second — becomes critical once you're building toward the Tier VII Dragon dwelling; claim Gem outposts as soon as the mid-game building path is secure.
3. Gold requirement for the Week 1 build is comparatively low, which is what makes the early rare-resource demands manageable if you scout for them deliberately.

Army composition

- **Early:** Onyx Dancers as the clearing core, a small Infiltrator stack only for cheap chip damage — not a real investment.
- **Mid:** Minotaurs added as the frontline screen (their job is to *absorb hits*, not to out-damage the ranged core — don't judge them by raw damage), Medusae added as a second ranged/control layer once mid-tier buildings are up.
- **Late:** Black Dragons as the win condition, layered behind upgraded ranged units (Toxic Troglodytes' long-range attack is worth keeping active specifically because it avoids provoking retaliation).

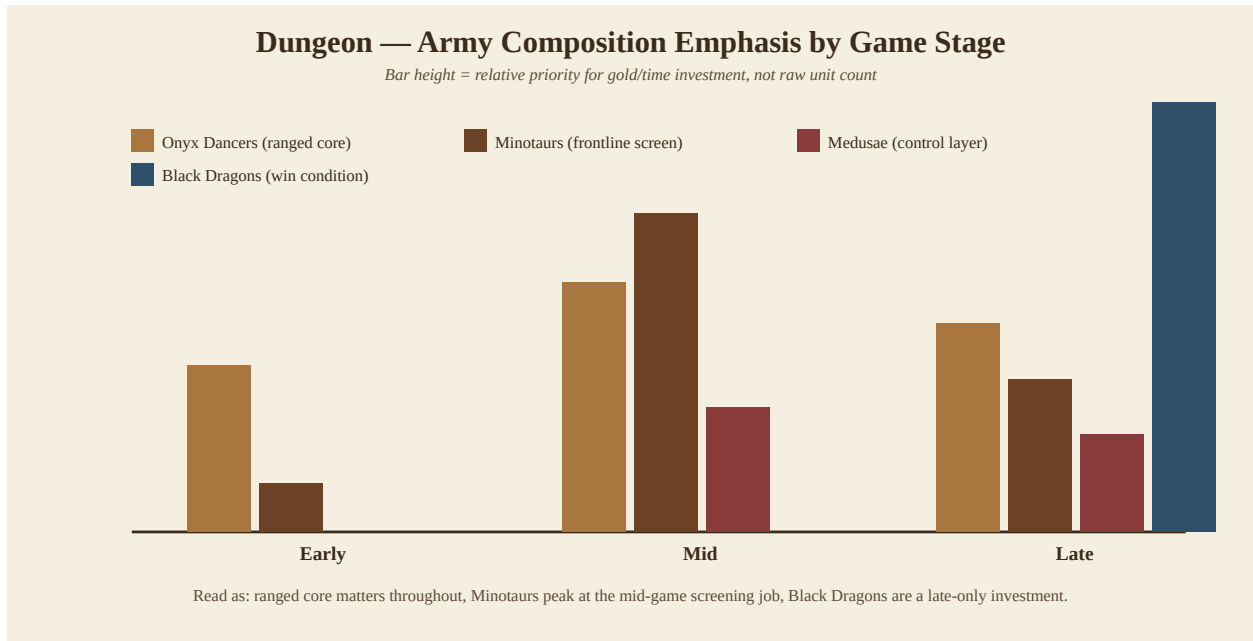


Figure 1: Dungeon army composition emphasis by game stage

Best hero archetypes

- **Overlord (Might):** stance-driven tactical play, front-loads Attack or Defense depending on matchup; no Thaumaturgy access, so army quality and stance timing carry the hero rather than spellcasting.
- *(Magic-class Dungeon hero entry pending audit — wiki coverage for the Dungeon spellcaster class was incomplete at time of writing; see `_audit.md`.)*

Abilities — the passive and Focus layer

How this works (verified from first-party documentation): every unit carries up to two kinds of special abilities. **Passives are always on** — auras, triggers, movement types, attack-type clauses. **Actives cost Focus Points**, which units accumulate by attacking and being attacked; bank enough and the ability fires. This layer is where Olden Era's combat depth actually lives — two stacks with identical stat lines can play completely differently — and it's what the Focus economy tools in this book (Murmuring, Energize, Battle March, Fancy Mask, Silence) exist to accelerate or deny.

Verified Dungeon abilities:

Unit	Ability	Type	Effect
Whole roster	Dual attack types	Passive (identity)	Every unit switches between two attack modes — the faction's defining versatility clause

Unit	Ability	Type	Effect
Hydra line	Sweeping Strike	Passive	Every attack damages the target and the two hexes beside it
Hydra line	No Counterattack	Passive	Sweeps are never punished — combined, a free three-hex cleave every swing
Medusa line	No Range Penalty	Passive	Full damage at any distance
Jasper Dancer	No Melee Penalty	Passive	The shooter core keeps damage in contact
Black Dragon	Spell Immunity	Passive	Immune to spells — the Armageddon-build enabler
Infiltrator line	Native Luck 1–2	Passive	The roster’s crit undercurrent

Focus priorities: Dungeon’s verified layer is passive-heavy by design — its “abilities” are permanent clauses, not banked charges, which is exactly why the chapter rates it the most forgiving *expert* faction: the toolkit can’t be Silenced off. The Focus game here runs through the **hero**: Triumvirate’s Strength stances (with the Flow subskill: +1 Focus Charge per stance pick) turn every round’s stance choice into ability fuel. Position Hydras so the sweep clips two targets minimum — a Hydra hitting one hex is leaving a third of its printed damage on the table. (Per-unit actives for the Dancer/Minotaur/Medusa lines: audit-tracked fetch.)

Recommended magic schools

(Filled from the completed magic-category chapters, 2026-07-03.)

Primary: Primal — for one legendary build and one great hero fit. The **Black Dragon + Armageddon** package (see the Primal chapter’s Armageddon entry,) is Dungeon’s signature magic play: your spell-immune T7 shrugs off the map-wide 500-per-stack blast that deletes everything else. Even before dragons, Primal’s damage suite fits Triumvirate’s Strength perfectly — swap to the Spellpower stance the round you cast Chain Lightning and the stance bonus lands exactly where it counts.

Secondary: Daylight, one spell — Arina’s Chosen. Dungeon owns its Masterful version: **Sister Deira (Warlock)** starts with “Mask of the Sun” (Masterful Arina’s Chosen: the deathward plus +1 action point, +1 effective SP per 3 hero levels — see the Daylight chapter). On a faction whose T7 costs Gems and whose elite stacks are genuinely irreplaceable, the game’s best stack-insurance spell in native hands is worth building a second hero around.

Tech notes: Nightshade’s Web protects the Onyx/Aureate Dancer core from melee divers (the Dancers’ melee attack is -50%, so anything that reaches them halves your damage); and remember

your own Black Dragons’ spell immunity blocks *your* buffs too — Armageddon builds fly clean, buff builds and dragons don’t mix.

Recommended magic-class hero

- **Sister Deira (Warlock):** Masterful Arina’s Chosen, per her official wiki page — the Dungeon spellcaster entry previously pending audit, now confirmed. (Tellaris the Betrayed is the faction’s other confirmed spell specialist per official patch notes; exact spell pending the hero-verification pass.)

Recommended secondary skills

(*STUB — pending Skills-category sweep; do not guess these from other factions’ skill trees.*)

Best artifacts

(*STUB — pending Artifacts-category sweep.*)

Counters & bad matchups

(*STUB — needs cross-faction matchup pass once all six faction chapters have a first draft; matchup claims aren’t reliable until every faction has been researched to the same depth.*)

Verified full roster (data-fill pass, 2026-07-03)

The official Dungeon Units table corrects and completes this chapter’s original walkthrough: the roster begins with a **Troglodyte** line the draft missed, shifting the true tier ladder to Troglodyte (T1), Infiltrator (T2), Dancer (T3), Minotaur (T4), Medusa (T5), Hydra (T6), Cave Dragon (T7). Unit analysis above stands; here is the verified stat table (native terrain: **Dirt**):

Tier	Unit	Cost	HP	Atk/Def	Dmg	Init	Spd	Notes
T1	Troglodyte	50g	8	2/3	1–3	4	4	Melee
T1	Infernal	60g	8	3/6	1–3	6	5	Melee
T1	Troglodyte							
T1	Toxic	60g	8	5/3	1–4	5	4	Melee
T1	Troglodyte							
T2	Infiltrator	115g	13	6/2	3–5	6	5	Luck 1
T2	Guile Infiltrator	150g	13	6/2	3–5	6	7	Luck 2
T2	Bleak	150g	13	6/3	3–5	9	6	Luck 2
T2	Infiltrator							
T3	Onyx	160g	18	8/8	5–7	4	2	Ranged
T3	Dancer							
T3	Jasper	220g	18	8/8	5–7	5	4	Ranged,
T3	Dancer							no
								melee
								penalty

Tier	Unit	Cost	HP	Atk/Def	Dmg	Init	Spd	Notes
T3	Aureate Dancer	220g	18	8/8	5–7	7	3	Ranged
T4	Minotaur	380g	40	11/11	12–14	5	5	Morale 1
T4	Minotaur Lord	530g	40	11/15	12–14	6	6	Morale 1
T4	Minotaur Van- guard	530g	40	15/11	14–16	5	6	Morale 2
T5	Medusa	500g	55	15/14	11–15	4	2	Ranged, no range penalty
T5	Medusa Sculptor	720g	55	20/17	15 fixed	5	4	Ranged, no range penalty
T5	Medusa Queen	720g	55	15/14	11–15	7	3	Ranged, no range penalty
T6	Hydra	1300g	130	24/22	25–28	8	4	Melee, no counter
T6	Chthonic Hydra	2000g	160	24/34	25–28	8	5	Melee, no counter
T6	Infernal Hydra	2000g	130	30/26	30–38	10	6	Melee, no counter
T7	Cave Dragon	3000g + 1 Gem	275	29/25	45–50	11	8	Melee
T7	Black Dragon	5000g + 2 Gem	350	29/31	60–65	14	9	Melee (+ spell immu- nity per its page)
T7	Ashen Dragon	5000g + 2 Gem	300	37/25	60–65	12	11	Melee

Two reads the numbers add to the chapter’s analysis: the whole roster runs on Luck/no-counter/penalty-free clauses rather than raw stat bloat — the “two attack types / versatility” identity in table form — and Black Dragon’s Initiative 14 ties Grove’s base Phoenix for the fastest-acting T7 body in the game, which is exactly what an Armageddon carrier wants.

Campaign Recommendation

First-week build order

Day	Action	Why
1	Build the Amphitheater (base Onyx Dancer dwelling); recruit everything available	Starts weekly unit growth immediately — the earlier this is up, the more Dancers you have by Week 2
2	Upgrade the town hall (Byzantine Palace) to Tier 2	Increases Gold and Law Point income; income compounds, so this is worth doing before combat buildings
3	Upgrade the town hall to Tier 3	Expensive, but the same compounding logic applies — later is strictly worse
4	Build the Labyrinth (Minotaur dwelling)	Unlocks your frontline screening unit before you need to fight anything that punishes a pure-ranged army
5–7	Flexible: Bank (if Gold-stable) / Marketplace (if Gems or Crystals are short) / Mage Guild (if your hero needs spells to clear safely)	Read your specific map's resource shortages rather than following a fixed script here

Target state entering Week 2: town hall fully upgraded, both core dwellings (Amphitheater + Labyrinth) active, enough rare resources banked to push toward the Amphitheater's Dancer upgrade and the mid-game building path.

The Three Builds

1. **Dancer Rush** — lean into the T1-3 ranged clear speed, prioritize Amphitheater upgrades over everything else, aim to out-tempo the opponent before Tier VI/VII armies exist on either side. Best on maps with easy early Gold and weak neutral guards.
2. **Ore-into-Gems Standard Build** — the default 90%-of-games plan above: Ore first for the mid-game spine, Gem outposts claimed as soon as they're safe to reach, Black Dragons as the explicit long-game target from Day 1 planning.
3. **Stance-Flex War Hero** — built around an Overlord who swaps stances turn-to-turn rather than committing to one; strongest in multiplayer/PvP-leaning campaign scenarios where you can't predict the next fight's shape and the flexibility outweighs a slightly slower power curve.

Common beginner mistakes

- Over-recruiting Infiltrators because they're cheap and available Day 1 — Gold spent here should almost always go to Minotaurs or Medusae once those buildings exist.

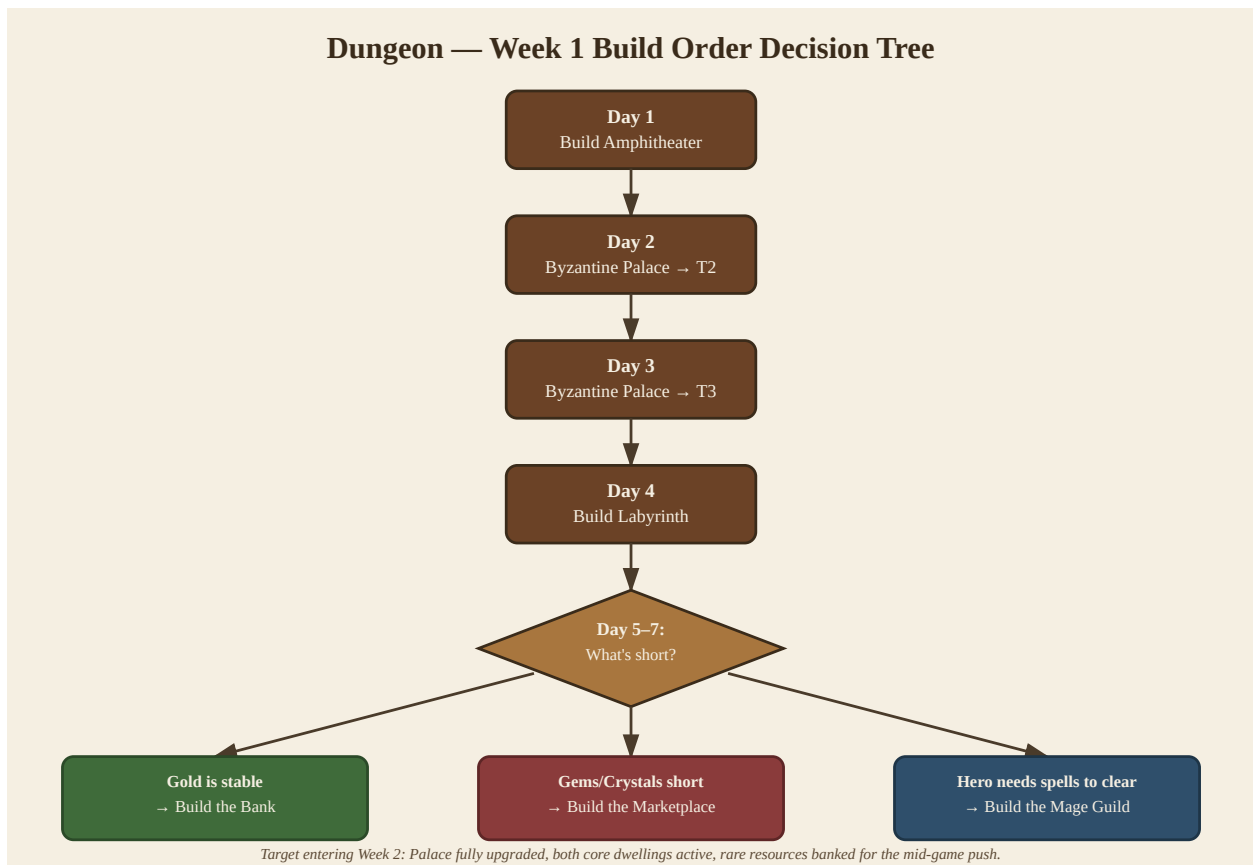


Figure 2: Dungeon Week 1 build order decision tree

- Treating Minotaurs as underwhelming because their damage looks low on paper — their job is holding the frontline so Dancers don't eat retaliation, not winning the damage race themselves.
- Ignoring Gem outposts until the Cave Palace is already queued, which pushes the Dragon timeline later than it needed to be.

Advanced tactics

- Route scouting explicitly around Gem nodes in the mid-game rather than general exploration — on Gem-poor maps, plan the Dragon timeline to slip and compensate with a heavier upgraded-ranged-unit late game instead of forcing the Dragon spike.
- Use the stance system as a mid-combat read, not just a pre-battle choice — switching from Dark Elf (Defense) to Minotaur (Attack) once a fight is clearly won can accelerate the kill and reduce turns taken, which matters for chained fights in the same day.

Campaign Verdict: (5/5)

Dungeon combines the fastest early clear speed in the game with what is widely considered the single best late-game army composition (upgraded ranged + Black Dragons), at the cost of a Gem dependency that punishes poor map knowledge and a fragile early roster that's easy to over-invest in as a new player. For campaign (single-player) play specifically, it's rated well-suited to Single Hero mode, which further plays to its clear-speed strength.

Related: Overlord (Hero Class) · Onyx Dancer · Minotaur · Black Dragon · Dungeon Laws · Dungeon Units — full roster

Sourcing note: built from the official Hooded Horse wiki (Dungeon, Dungeon Units, Overlord, Minotaur, Chthonic Hydra, Cave Dragon, Infiltrator, Guile Infiltrator, Bleak Infiltrator pages, retrieved 2026-07-03) plus cross-referenced third-party strategy coverage for the Analysis and Campaign Recommendation layers, which are original synthesis, not wiki content. Sections marked STUB are intentionally left unfilled rather than guessed — see `_audit.md` for what's still needed.

Grove — The Murmurwoods

Power: 4/5 · Beginner Friendly: 4/5 · Campaign: 4/5 · Economy: 3/5 · Skill Ceiling: 3/5 · Early 3/5 · Mid 4/5 · Late 5/5

In one sentence: The magic faction — elemental spirits that are each “a unique powerhouse,” the safest ranged roster in the game for newer players, and the deepest bench of *elemental-damage* hero specialists anywhere, at the price of the most expensive units.

Identity (per the official faction page): the Murmurwoods’ governing body is officially *Unknown*; elementals & magical creatures; keywords *Strong Spellcasters* and *Creature Abilities*. Community assessments consistently call it the safest, most beginner-friendly ranged roster — with “strong and expensive” as the official description of its rangers and druids, and that cost is the faction’s real constraint.

Faction skill: Murmuring

Known by default by all Wardens and Druids (Grove’s two hero classes), unavailable elsewhere.

What it does (official mechanics, verified): the hero **starts every battle with Focus Charges already banked** — 1 at Basic, 2 at Advanced, 3 at Expert. Focus is the resource creatures spend on their active abilities, so this skill means Grove’s ability-rich roster (and its hero) opens fights with its best tricks already loaded instead of grinding attacks to earn them.

Documented subskills: Mycelium Grounds (+10% dealt / -10% taken on Autumn terrain), Life Essence (+1 Focus Charge cap), Child of the Woods (+20 max mana); at Expert: Just One More Time (every Focus spend cuts all the hero’s spell cooldowns by 2 rounds), Burst of Energy (Focus spends add +15% per hero level to Heroic Strike damage), and Strong Connection (each Focus spend gives the hero +2 to all attributes until end of round).

Why it fits: the Expert tree turns Focus spending into a hero-stat engine — and note the direct synergy with Arcane’s Energize/Energy Explosion package (see that chapter): Grove is the one faction whose faction skill *feeds* the Focus-economy combo natively.

Unit roster (full stats, verified against the official wiki)

Native terrain: **Autumn**.

Tier 1: Faun → Faun Archer / Faun Warrior

Unit	Cost	HP	Atk/Def	Dmg	Init	Spd	Notes
Faun	115g	11	4/3	3–5	4	2	Ranged, no melee penalty
Faun Archer	150g	11	4/3	3–5	5	3	Ranged, NO penalties at all
Faun Warrior	150g	11	6/6	4–6	6	4	Melee

A T1 shooter with *no melee penalty even unupgraded* — the safest starter unit in the game, exactly as the faction’s reputation says. **Faun Archer** removes every ranged penalty (distance and melee) on a 150-gold unit, which is absurd; Faun Warrior exists for players who somehow want Grove without shooters.

Tier 2: Hoplet → Dawn Hoplet / Dusk Hoplet

Unit	Cost	HP	Atk/Def	Dmg	Morale/Luck	Init	Spd	Notes
Hoplet	150g	18	5/3	3–6	1/1	6	5	Melee
Dawn Hoplet	200g	18	7/3	3–6	1/2	6	6	Melee, no counter
Dusk Hoplet	200g	18	5/5	3–6	2/1	9	5	Melee

The only Grove line with native Morale and Luck — the faction’s “lucky” flavor made mechanical. **Dawn Hoplet** attacks without ever being counterattacked (a free Shackles built into a T2!); **Dusk Hoplet** at Initiative 9 is the early tempo screen.

Tier 3: Vine Iriyad → Fungal Iriyad / Crystal Iriyad

Unit	Cost	HP	Atk/Def	Dmg	Init	Spd
Vine Iriyad	235g	45	6/11	4–8	2	3
Fungal Iriyad	320g	45	6/11	4–8	3	4
Crystal Iriyad	320g	45	6/11	5–7	3	5

The wall: 45 HP at Tier 3 (compare the Onyx Dancer’s 18) with 11 Defense — nearly triple the durability of peer-tier units, moving at a glacier’s pace. This is the shield the Fauns and Naiads shoot from behind. Upgrade differences are marginal; take whichever resource curve suits and don’t overthink it.

Tier 4: Naiad → Vernal Naiad / Brumal Naiad

Unit	Cost	HP	Atk/Def	Dmg	Init	Spd	Notes
Naiad	380g	40	11/10	10–14	5	5	Ranged
Vernal Naiad	530g	40	11/14	14–18	7	6	Ranged
Brumal Naiad	530g	40	15/10	14–18	6	5	Ranged

The mid-game ranged core (the spring/winter fork the naming telegraphed). **Vernal** (spring): +4 Defense and Initiative 7 — survivability and tempo. **Brumal** (winter): +4 Attack — pure output. Vernal is the default; the Iriyad wall keeps Brumal safe enough if you prefer damage.

Tier 5: Herbomancer → Sporemancer / Murmurmancer

Unit	Cost	HP	Atk/Def	Dmg	Init	Spd	Notes
Herbomancer	640g	60	12/14	15–18	6	4	Long Reach
Sporemancer	910g	60	16/18	15–18	8	6	Long Reach
Murmurmancer	940g	60	12/14	18–18 fixed	8	5	Long Reach

The druids of the official faction blurb. Note **Murmurmancer's fixed 18–18 damage** — zero variance, named for the faction skill itself. **Sporemancer** is the stat pick (+4/+4); Murmurmancer the consistency pick.

Tier 6: Qilin → Thunder Qilin / Mist Qilin

Unit	Cost	HP	Atk/Def	Dmg	Luck	Init	Spd
Qilin	1300g	135	22/22	24–30	3	9	6
Thunder Qilin	2000g	135	22/22	30–36	3	11	8
Mist Qilin	2000g	135	24/24	27–36	3	13	7

Native Luck 3 on the whole line — these spirits crit constantly. **Mist Qilin at Initiative 13** acts before nearly everything in the game; **Thunder** hits harder per swing. Both are elite; the fork is tempo vs. throughput.

Tier 7: Phoenix → Flaming Phoenix / Energy Phoenix

Unit	Cost	HP	Atk/Def	Dmg	Init	Spd
Phoenix	2800g + 1 Crystal	200	28/26	45–65	14	7

Unit	Cost	HP	Atk/Def	Dmg	Init	Spd
Flaming Phoenix	4700g + 2 Crystal	300	34/26	45–65	16	9
Energy Phoenix	4700g + 2 Crystal	250	28/36	45–65	15	9

The fastest-acting T7 line in the game — base Phoenix’s Initiative 14 already beats every other faction’s *upgraded* T7, and Flaming Phoenix’s 16 is the highest Initiative printed on any unit in this book. Grove’s whole tempo problem (slow walls, Initiative-2 Iriyads) inverts at the top of the roster. Crystal is the rare-resource bottleneck. **Flaming** for the stats; **Energy** for the armor.

Abilities — the passive and Focus layer

How this works (verified from first-party documentation): every unit carries up to two kinds of special abilities. **Passives are always on** — auras, triggers, movement types, attack-type clauses. **Actives cost Focus Points**, which units accumulate by attacking and being attacked; bank enough and the ability fires. This layer is where Olden Era’s combat depth actually lives — two stacks with identical stat lines can play completely differently — and it’s what the Focus economy tools in this book (Murmuring, Energize, Battle March, Fancy Mask, Silence) exist to accelerate or deny.

Verified Grove abilities: this roster’s special layer is unusually *passive*-weighted — its clauses are printed on the attack types rather than banked in Focus bars:

Unit	Ability	Type	Effect
Faun	Ranged, no melee penalty	Passive	Full-strength shots even when engaged
Faun Archer	No penalties at all	Passive	Ignores distance falloff <i>and</i> melee penalty
Dawn Hoplet	No Counterattack	Passive	Its melee strikes are never punished
Murmurancer	Fixed 18–18 damage	Passive	Zero-variance volleys
Qilin line	Native Luck 3	Passive	Constant Lucky Strike pressure (+18% base chance)
Herbomancer line	Long Reach	Passive	Attacks over the front rank without provoking

The named *active* abilities of the Iriyad/Herbomancer/Phoenix lines (the wiki’s per-unit pages carry them) are the category’s remaining fetch — tracked in the audit. What’s already verified reshapes play:

Focus priorities: Grove is the faction where the *hero* is the Focus engine — Murmuring hands you 1–3 charges at battle start before any unit swings. Until the per-unit actives are documented,

the verified play is spending that head start through the Expert Murmuring subskills (cooldown refunds, Heroic Strike riders, +2 all attributes per spend) — the hero converts the faction’s Focus surplus even when units bank theirs.

Recommended magic schools (cross-referenced)

Primary: Primal — Grove owns this school at the hero level. Both of Primal’s confirmed Masterful specialists are Grove heroes: **Faleor (Masterful Fireball** — bigger area; the pick community guides call Grove’s best hero outright) and **Halon (Masterful Chain Lightning** — half damage loss per jump, pushing chain totals toward ~1,800). The logic is airtight for the faction’s problem profile: expensive units mean every fight should be won *before contact*, and turn-one multi-stack AoE is exactly that. Read those two entries in the Primal chapter first.

Primary co-pick: Arcane. Vatawna’s Masterful Mirror Copy (clones *enemy* stacks to fight for you) is Grove’s third confirmed Masterful hero — and Rewind Life is even more valuable here than elsewhere because of unit prices: reviving a wiped Grove stack refunds more gold than reviving anyone else’s.

The takeaway: Grove has *three confirmed Masterful heroes across two schools* — more offensive-magic specialist depth than any other faction — plus the longest spell-specialist patch-notes cohort in the game (Old Pilgrim, Aelinie, Glacia, Vim, Echolily, Sullie alongside the three above). If you want to play the game as a wizard with an army attached rather than the reverse, this is the faction.

Hero picks

- **Faleor (the default):** Masterful Fireball from level 1 solves the fragile-expensive-early-game problem by killing threats before they arrive. Best first pick.
- **Halon (the late-game ceiling):** Masterful Chain Lightning; the single highest sustained-nuke output in the game once leveled.
- **Vatawna (the trickster):** Masterful Mirror Copy targeting enemy stacks — steals the enemy’s best unit as a battle plan.
- **Aunt Daliar (the might route):** Warden (Grove’s Might class), Insight specialist — the pick for players running Grove’s army as the main act rather than the supporting cast.
- **Alluring Sh’a:** diplomacy specialist — converting neutral armies to your side sidesteps the faction’s gold-cost problem entirely, a quietly perfect thematic fit.

Three builds

1. **The Patient Forest (beginner):** Faun Archers + ranged core behind Hoplet screens; Faleor clearing approaches with Fireball. The “safest ranged roster” reputation, played straight.
2. **Stormcaller (mid/late):** Halon + maximum Spellpower investment; army exists to hold the line while Chain Lightning does the actual killing. Grove as a delivery system for one spell.
3. **The Mirrorwood (advanced):** Vatawna stealing enemy elites + Alluring Sh’a’s diplomacy feeding converted neutrals into the army — Grove’s gold problem solved by never paying for units

at all.

Matchups (vs. completed chapters)

Against **Dungeon:** a shooters-vs-shooters race where Dungeon's Initiative edge (Aureate Dancers) usually fires first — Grove's answer is Faleor deleting Dancer stacks in the approach. Against **Temple:** mirror-adjacent (both buff-and-shoot factions); Grove's AoE specialists punish Temple's tight defensive formations, while Temple's Wean-resistant... rather, Temple's *cleanse* suite (Inner Light) strips Grove's setup. Against **Necropolis:** your expensive-unit economy vs. their free one — end it early or don't. Full matchup grid: STUB.

Common mistakes

- Playing Grove like a might faction and bleeding gold on replacement units — the entire design points at spells-first play.
- Picking a generalist hero over Faleor/Halon/Vatawna and forfeiting the faction's defining advantage.
- Fighting attrition wars against Necropolis with the most expensive units in the game.
- Ignoring diplomacy tools that exist precisely to offset unit costs.

Verdict: (4/5)

The wizard's faction, and the best expression of magic-forward play in the game — three Masterful specialists across the two best offensive schools, on top of a safe ranged roster. One star withheld for the economy: everything Grove fields is priced like it's irreplaceable, and against fast tempo or free-growth factions, sometimes it is.

Sourcing note: faction identity from the official Factions page; roster tree from the official Units navigation; hero specializations from the magic chapters' confirmed pairings and official patch notes (retrieved 2026-07-03). Murmuring skill text and full unit stat tables are open gaps logged in the factions audit. Builds, ratings, and verdicts are original analysis.

Hive — The Order of the Fly

Power: 3/5 · Beginner Friendly: 2/5 · Campaign: 3/5 · Economy: 3/5 · Skill
Ceiling: 5/5 · Early 4/5 · Mid 3/5 · Late 3/5

In one sentence: The swarm-aggression faction — the Dragonfly King’s insect legions overwhelm through speed, numbers, and ability-driven units, rewarding players who attack constantly and punishing everyone who hesitates.

Identity (per the official faction page): Beelzebub’s Order of the Fly, commanded by the Dragonfly King, “bent on conquering Jadame” and “driven by swift and aggressive tactics.” Community tier assessments consistently place Hive among the factions “requiring much higher mechanical skill and specific conditions to reach full potential” — this is the expert’s aggression faction, not the beginner’s.

Faction skill: Summon Swarm

The Hive-exclusive skill (all Hive heroes start with some rank of it — e.g. Mila begins with Basic Summon Swarm per her official page).

What it does (official mechanics, verified): once per round, the hero **lays a clutch of eggs on the battlefield; at the start of the next round they hatch into a stack of Fire Larvae** whose total HP equals a percentage of the combined HP of all Hive Spawns in the hero’s army — **8% at Basic, 12% at Advanced, 16% at Expert** — with ability strength scaling with hero level. The eggs are attackable (destroyed after two hits), adding a mind-game: enemies must waste attacks on eggs or accept the hatch.

The math that matters: the summon scales with *your army’s total HP*, so it grows all game — a late-game army with 3,000 combined Hive HP hatches a 480-HP larva stack at Expert, *every round, forever*. Free bodies as a percentage of your bodies: the swarm that spawns swarms. This also confirms the roster’s structural tell — Fire Larva sits outside the upgrade system entirely because it’s the skill’s output, not a recruited unit.

Class note — the Herald (Hive’s Magic class): officially documented subclasses are **Progenitor** (+200% creature growth in all your cities — on the swarm faction, an obscene multiplier) and **Lord of Chaos** (Heroic Strike deals +2 damage per hero attribute point). Progenitor is the campaign-defining one: it’s the biggest growth multiplier printed anywhere in the game.

Unit roster (full stats, verified against the official wiki)

Native terrain: **Lava**.

The swarm unit: Fire Larva (no upgrades)

Unit	Cost	HP	Atk/Def	Dmg	Init	Spd
Fire Larva	100g	8	4/4	4–4 fixed	4	4

Officially listed at Tier IV with **no upgrade paths** — the roster’s structural confirmation of its swarm-fodder role (and of the Summon Swarm skill’s output). 8 HP for 100 gold is terrible value as an army unit and perfect value as ammunition: fixed 4 damage, a body on a hex, and nothing worth mourning.

Tier 1: Parasite → Warden Parasite / Ravager Parasite

Unit	Cost	HP	Atk/Def	Dmg	Init	Spd	Notes
Parasite	90g	7	3/3	2–4	4	4	Long Reach
Warden Parasite	110g	9	3/6	2–4	5	5	Long Reach
Ravager Parasite	110g	7	6/3	2–4	6	6	Long Reach

A Long Reach T1 — hits from a hex away without eating counterattacks, the aggression identity in miniature. **Ravager** (Init/Spd 6/6) for the tempo swarm; **Warden** to actually hold ground.

Tier 2: Locust → Overgrown Locust / Harvester Locust

Unit	Cost	HP	Atk/Def	Dmg	Init	Spd
Locust	130g	12	5/4	3–5	6	5
Overgrown Locust	170g	16	5/4	3–5	7	6
Harvester Locust	170g	12	7/4	4–5	7	7

Fast, cheap, numerous — the swarm’s rank and file. **Harvester** at Speed 7 crosses most battlefields turn one, which is the entire Hive gameplan in one stat.

Tier 3: Hornet → Chanter / Stinger

Unit	Cost	HP	Atk/Def	Dmg	Init	Spd
Hornet	255g	20	7/10	4–9	10	7
Chanter	350g	25	7/10	4–9	4	11
Stinger	350g	20	7/10	4–9	12	9

The core stack (hero Leira’s specialty line). Base Hornet already acts at Initiative 10; **Stinger** pushes to 12/9 — first-strike melee that reaches any backline turn one. **Chanter** is the oddity:

Initiative 4 but Speed 11, an ability-oriented support flyer that moves huge distances late in the round. Stinger is the aggression default.

Tier 4: Scorpion → Volcanic Scorpion / Spelaean Scorpion

Unit	Cost	HP	Atk/Def	Dmg	Morale/Luck	Init	Spd
Scorpion	280g	45	12/12	10–12	1/1	3	4
Volcanic Scorpion	390g	60	12/14	10–12	1/2	4	5
Spelaean Scorpion	390g	45	14/12	12–14	2/1	4	4

The swarm’s one true tank line — and the Morale/Luck carrier. Slow (Init 3–4) by design: it holds the line the fast units flow around. **Volcanic** (60 HP) is the anvil; **Spelaean** trades bulk for bite.

Tier 5: Reaver → Menacing Reaver / Maniacal Reaver

Unit	Cost	HP	Atk/Def	Dmg	Morale	Init	Spd
Reaver	770g	45	18/12	10–40	1	11	6
Menacing Reaver	1100g	45	18/18	20–30	3	12	7
Maniacal Reaver	1100g	45	18/12	10–40	2	12	6

The gambler’s unit: base damage range 10–40 is the widest variance in the game — a 20-stack swings anywhere from 200 to 800. **Menacing** narrows it to 20–30 (higher floor, Morale 3); **Maniacal** keeps the chaos. Pair Maniacal with max-damage effects (Kennelmaster-style marks, Masterful Blessing logic) and the variance becomes a weapon; otherwise Menacing is the adult choice.

Tier 6: Waurms → Devourer / Pyroboros

Unit	Cost	HP	Atk/Def	Dmg	Luck	Init	Spd	Notes
Waurms	1200g	120	20/20	21–23	1	8	8	Melee
Devourer	1900g	120	20/20	24–26	3	8	10	Melee
Pyroboros	1900g	120	20/20	21–23	2	9	8	Ranged, no melee penalty

Pyroboros is the roster’s plot twist: the melee swarm faction’s T6 upgrades into a full shooter with no melee penalty — a genuine ranged core piece hiding at the top of the tree. **Devourer** (Speed 10, Luck 3) is the pursuit predator for the classic all-in build.

Tier 7: Hive Queen → Hive Mother / Hive Huntress

Unit	Cost	HP	Atk/Def	Dmg	Init	Spd	Notes
Hive Queen	2100g + 1 Crystal	200	25/25	60–60 fixed	8	6	Melee
Hive Mother	3500g + 2 Crystal	275	25/25	60–60	13	6	Melee
Hive Huntress	3500g + 2 Crystal	250	25/25	70–70	8	9	Melee, no counter

Fixed damage across the whole line — the Queen always hits for exactly 60 (the patch-notes attention this line received makes sense; there’s no bad roll to soften her). **Hive Mother** (275 HP, Initiative 13) is the royal anchor; **Huntress** (70 fixed, never counterattacked, Speed 9) is a guided missile. Crystal-gated like Grove’s Phoenix.

Abilities — the passive and Focus layer

How this works (verified from first-party documentation): every unit carries up to two kinds of special abilities. **Passives are always on** — auras, triggers, movement types, attack-type clauses. **Actives cost Focus Points**, which units accumulate by attacking and being attacked; bank enough and the ability fires. This layer is where Olden Era’s combat depth actually lives — two stacks with identical stat lines can play completely differently — and it’s what the Focus economy tools in this book (Murmuring, Energize, Battle March, Fancy Mask, Silence) exist to accelerate or deny.

Verified Hive abilities:

Unit	Ability	Type	Effect
Parasite line	Long Reach	Passive	Hits the hex behind an adjacent hex — no counterattack, no movement
Pyroboros	Ranged, no melee penalty	Passive	The swarm’s surprise artillery keeps full damage in contact
Hive Huntress	No Counterattack	Passive	70-damage strikes that are never punished
Chanter	Support flyer profile	Passive	Speed 11 / Initiative 4 — a late-round, long-range ability carrier
Fire Larva	Expendable	—	The Summon Swarm output; exists to absorb hits and Focus-farm

The faction keyword is *Creature Abilities*, and the roster's named actives (Scorpion, Reaver, Wau-rms, Queen lines) are the audit's remaining per-unit fetch. Two verified mechanics already define the Focus game here:

Focus priorities: Hive both *generates* and *feeds on* Focus faster than anyone — Long Reach T1s trading safely builds charges, and every egg the enemy is forced to kill (two hits each) hands your survivors more. The verified loop: Summon Swarm eggs → enemy wastes attacks → your real stacks bank Focus → actives fire first. Pair with the Arcane Energize package (the faction chapter's standing recommendation) and round one opens with abilities already loaded. Fear enemy **Silence** above any damage spell — it switches this entire layer off.

Recommended magic schools (cross-referenced)

Primary: Daylight — one spell above all: Haste, because Hive owns its Masterful version. Mila (Herald) starts with Masterful Haste — army-wide speed, +1 effective Spellpower per 2 levels — on the faction whose official identity is “swift and aggressive tactics.” It's the single cleanest faction/spell fit in the game: every point of Speed converts directly into earlier contact, and earlier contact is the whole Hive thesis. (Mila also starts with Basic Daylight Magic, per her official page — the faction's magic class is genuinely built for this school.)

Primary co-pick: Arcane's Focus package. The faction keyword *Creature Abilities* + ability-driven units = Energize and Energy Explosion (see the Arcane chapter) are worth more here than to any other faction: front-loading Focus charges means your units' actives fire on round one, matching the tempo plan.

Situational: Nightshade's Silence is the *mirror-match terror* — an enemy silencing your ability-dependent army removes most of what makes it dangerous; know the threat even if you never cast it.

Hero picks

- **Mila (the flagship):** Masterful Haste on the speed faction. The obvious pick is also the correct one. Her lore (a Church deserter answered by the Dragonfly King) even makes her the thematic bridge from Temple's buff school to Hive's aggression.
- **Leira (the creature route):** Hornets specialist — the pick when you'd rather scale the core stack than the tempo.
- **Any Herald → Progenitor:** the +200% growth subclass is a campaign plan by itself: chase its five prerequisite skills and the swarm becomes a flood.
- **Niev:** magic-damage specialist (per official patch notes) for a more caster-forward Hive.

Three builds

1. The First Wave (tempo): Mila + Masterful Haste + Hornet core + Fire Larva screens. Contact on turn one, everywhere, always. The faction played as designed.

2. Progenitor's Flood (campaign): any Herald raced to the Progenitor subclass; +200% growth turns the numbers advantage into something no economy matches. Slower to come online;

unanswerable after.

3. Focus Storm (advanced): Energize/Energy Explosion package + ability-heavy units (Scorpions/Reavers) — every fight opens with a full ability salvo. The highest-skill expression of the roster.

Matchups (vs. completed chapters)

Against **Dungeon:** the tempo mirror — Aureate Dancer initiative vs. Masterful Haste; whoever lands the first real volley usually wins the war. Against **Temple:** their wall (Sun's Aegis/Radiant Armour) exists to blunt exactly your alpha strike; Wean their buffs or go around. Against **Necropolis:** win by week 4 or watch the snowball bury the swarm; also note their undead are Sleep-immune just like your Spawns — the control spells fizzle in both directions. Against **Grove:** race their casters — every round you give Faleor and Halon is a stack you lose. Full matchup grid: STUB.

Common mistakes

- Playing Hive patiently. The faction's mid/late curve (3/5) exists precisely because its early tempo (4/5) is the win condition — hesitation converts your best phase into your worst.
- Spending Fire Larvae like real units instead of screens — they're the faction's renewable resource; their job is dying usefully.
- Ignoring Focus economy on an ability-keyword faction.
- Underestimating enemy Silence in caster matchups.

Verdict: (3/5)

The highest skill ceiling in the game attached to a genuinely scary tempo plan — and the honest rating reflects that most players won't pilot it to its potential. In expert hands with Mila's Masterful Haste or a completed Progenitor arc, it plays a full tier above this score; on autopilot, a full tier below.

Sourcing note: faction identity from the official *Factions* page; Herald class and subclasses from the official *Herald* page; roster tree from the official *Units* navigation; Mila/Leira from official hero pages; Hive Queen adjustment from official patch notes (retrieved 2026-07-03). Summon Swarm full text and unit stat tables are open gaps logged in the *factions* audit. Builds, ratings, and verdicts are original analysis.

The Matchup Grid — every faction vs. every faction

How to read this: each cell is written from the **row faction's** perspective, grounded in the verified stat tables and skill mechanics in the six faction chapters and the spell data in the magic chapters. Matchups describe *structural* pressure — who must act, who profits from time — not guaranteed outcomes; pilots beat pairings. Ratings: **F** (favored), **E** (even), **U** (unfavored).

vs →	Temple	Necropolis	Grove	Hive	Schism	Dungeon
Temple	—	E	E	F	F	E
Necropolis	E	—	F	F	E	E
Grove	E	U	—	E	F	E
Hive	U	U	E	—	E	E
Schism	U	E	U	E	—	E
Dungeon	E	E	E	E	E	—

The nine matchup families (row vs. column)

Temple vs. Necropolis (E): buffs against inevitability. Temple's per-fight edge is real — Radiant Armour + Marksmen out-trade skeleton volleys — but Necromancy converts every fight *anywhere on the map* into Necropolis growth. Temple's win condition is tempo it doesn't naturally have; its equalizer is that four of its Clerics carry elite Masterful spells, and one 4-mana Fatal Decay (learnable cross-school) shuts off Vampirism in the fights that matter. The clock favors the dead; the battles favor the sun. Even.

Temple vs. Hive (F): the wall against the wave. Hive's entire gameplan — Stinger Initiative 12 alpha strikes, Larva screens — runs into the one roster built to receive it: Sun's Aegis 8-Def T1s, Guardian Griffins, Radiant Armour L4 (-35% army-wide). Every blunted first wave hands Righteousness stacks to the Temple hero. Hive must hit harder than Temple can armor, and the math (Hive's fragile HP pools vs. Temple's fixed-damage Lightweavers) says it usually can't.

Temple vs. Schism (F): Temple owns the two cleanest anti-Schism tools in the game — Heavenly Blades L4 (deletes summoned units on contact: Communion reinforcements, Starchildren, all of it) and a roster durable enough to survive the streak-fueled opening. Break one fight and Communion halves itself into irrelevance overnight.

Necropolis vs. Grove (F): free army against the most expensive army in the game. Every Grove stack Necropolis kills costs real gold to replace; every Necropolis stack Grove kills feeds

nothing (undead don't fear attrition) and returns via Rewind Death/Vampirism anyway. Grove's out is Faleor/Halon ending fights before the grind starts — possible, but the structural pressure is one-directional.

Necropolis vs. Hive (F): the immunity matchup. Hive's corpse economy meets a faction whose dead *don't feed Necromancy's enemies* — wait, reverse it: Hive Spawns DO feed Necromancy (verified type-interaction), meaning every dead swarm unit is a future Necropolis recruit, while Necropolis's Undead feed Hive's consumption abilities nothing they can't get elsewhere. Add Sleep-immunity symmetry (both sides' control fizzles) and the fight reduces to raw attrition — the one game Necropolis never loses.

Grove vs. Schism (F): Grove's Focus economy (Murmuring's free battle-start charges) comes online turn one, faster than Communion's streak-building, and Faleor's turn-one Masterful Fireball erases the fragile Schism early roster the moment it clusters around its summons. Schism's Envoy-Armageddon endgame is real, but Grove's Phoenix-Initiative endgame arrives first.

Hive vs. Temple / Necropolis (U, U): covered above from the other side — the swarm's two structural nightmares: the roster that armors through the alpha strike, and the roster that recruits the swarm's corpses.

Schism vs. Temple / Grove (U, U): the anti-summon problem in two flavors: Temple's Heavenly Blades and Grove's tempo casters. Schism's best games are against factions without a summon answer.

Dungeon vs. everyone (E across the board): the verified roster explains the row: no bad stats, no hard counters against it, and its identity (Luck lines, no-counter Hydras, penalty-free Medusas, the fastest T7 in the game carrying spell immunity) is *flexibility* — Dungeon always has a game plan, and never a free win. Its matchups are decided by the pilot's stance-skill timing and whether the Black Dragon/Armageddon package comes online before the opponent's own curve peaks. The one asymmetry worth naming: vs. Necropolis and Schism, Dungeon's tempo must beat their inevitability clocks — win by week 4–5 or the grinding factions grind.

Three cross-cutting rules the grid keeps repeating

1. **Sustain factions beat tempo factions that hesitate** — Necropolis and Schism convert time into army; against them, slow play is a resource transfer.
2. **Anti-summon tech warps three matchups** — Heavenly Blades L4 and Anti-Magic swing every Schism pairing and dent Hive's Larva game; check the enemy faction before skipping those entries.
3. **Type-immunity fine print decides mirror-adjacent fights** — Sleep's exclusion list (Undead, Hive Spawn, Embodiment, Construct) and Necromancy's reanimation table (Living/Hive Spawn/Magic Creature/Dragon feed it; Undead/Embodiment/Construct don't) are worth memorizing; half this grid's edges come from them.

Sourcing note: structural claims grounded in the verified faction stat tables, skill mechanics, and type-interaction rules documented in this book (all retrieved from official sources, 2026-07-03). The grid's ratings are original analysis and the least stable content in the book — re-check after every balance patch.

Necropolis — Shadowspire's Endless Dead

Power: 4/5 · Beginner Friendly: 4/5 · Campaign: 5/5 · Economy: 4/5 · Skill Ceiling: 3/5 · Early 3/5 · Mid 4/5 · Late 5/5

In one sentence: The attrition faction — every battle you win makes your army *bigger* through Necromancy, your units drain strength from enemies as they fight, and given enough time you simply cannot be out-grown.

Identity (per the official faction page): ruled by the Necromancers' Guild of Shadowspire; undead; keywords *Strong Debuffs & Curses* and *Improving army by raising the Dead*. Community consensus rates it the best late-game faction and, alongside Dungeon, one of the two easiest to win with — the snowball takes care of itself.

Faction skill: Necromancy

Known by all Necropolis hero classes (Death Knights and their magic counterparts), unavailable elsewhere.

What it does (official mechanics, verified): After winning a battle, **transforms 10/15/20% (by skill rank) of the strongest enemy stack into friendly Undead of the same tier**. This consumes Necromantic Energy, which stores up to 1,000–1,500 (by rank) and refills each week (or when the hero has no stack of that tier). Crucially, **Necromancy works on all creatures, not just the Undead** — every living enemy is future army. Documented subskills include: native-terrain bonus (+10% dealt / -10% taken on Deathland), +4 mana per battle victory, and a granted ability that heals a friendly Undead stack **and revives its fallen units**. The Necromancer class additionally spawns a temporary friendly Wight stack whenever an enemy stack dies in battle.

The companion tool — Necromancer Will (Neutral spell, 0 mana): toggles raising off, banking *Necromantic Energy* instead. This is the skill's hidden depth: raising junk-tier troops dilutes a refined army, so experienced players toggle off against low-value enemies and bank the energy for better conversions. See the Neutral Magic chapter's entry — it's rated 5/5 *for this faction specifically*.

Why it defines the faction: every other faction pays gold to grow; Necropolis grows by fighting. The correct Necropolis campaign is a deliberately *high-volume* one — take every fight the map offers, because each one is a recruitment event.

Unit roster (full stats, verified against the official wiki)

Native terrain: **Deathland**. All units are Undead creature-type.

Tier 1: Skeleton → Skeleton Warrior / Skeleton Archer

Unit	Cost	HP	Atk/Def	Dmg	Init	Spd	Growth	Notes
Skeleton	35g	6	4/1	1–3	4	3	30/wk	Melee
Skeleton Warrior	50g	6	6/3	2–3	6	3	30	Melee
Skeleton Archer	50g	6	4/1	1–3	4	3	30	Ranged

The cheapest units in the game (35g!) at the game's highest growth rate (30/week) — before Necromancy adds more. **Skeleton Archer is the faction-defining pick:** a ranged stack that grows every battle is the engine everything else protects.

Tier 2: Wight → Wraith / Phantasm

Unit	Cost	HP	Atk/Def	Dmg	Init	Spd	Notes
Wight	105g	9	2/0	2–4	6	3	Flying ; Memory Devourer I (20% dmg dealt → HP, can create temp units)
Wraith	140g	9	6/0	2–4	7	4	MD II (40%); Howl of the Banshee (forces enemy to random adjacent hex)

Unit	Cost	HP	Atk/Def	Dmg	Init	Spd	Notes
Phantasm	140g	9	6/4	2-4	7	4	MD I + Nightmares (stacking 1-pure-dmg curse on hit)

The sustain identity starts here: Wights convert damage into *extra temporary units*. **Wraith** for the displacement utility (shoving enemies off chokepoints); **Phantasm** for durability + curse chip.

Tier 3: Undead Pet → Barghest / Armored Hound

Unit	Cost	HP	Atk/Def	Dmg	Init	Spd	Notes
Undead Pet	120g	14	4/6	3-5	5	5	Melee Defense I (-30% melee taken)
Barghest	160g	14	8/6	3-5	8	6	+ Bone Crusher (steals 1 Def per strike, undispellable) + Call of the Pack (summons 20% of stack)
Armored Hound	160g	18	4/8	3-5	5	5	+ Protect the Fallen (+3 Def per friendly death) + Lacerated Wounds (stacking bleed)

Correction from the roster-tree draft: **Undead Pet is the T3 base**, upgrading into Barghest

or Armored Hound. The community hype around this line is earned — -30% melee taken on the whole line makes it the best cheap screen in the game. **Barghest** for tempo (Init 8, Spd 6, self-summoning); **Armored Hound** for the anvil.

Tier 4: Graverobber → Merchant of Death / Kennelmaster

Unit	Cost	HP	Atk/Def	Dmg	Init	Spd	Notes
Graverobber	260g	30	13/9	7–9	2	3	Long Reach; Dig Up Bones (summons 2 Skeletons per unit!)
Merchant of Death	360g	30	13/9	7–9	5	4	+ stacking poison on attacks + Ensnare Memories (summons Wights)
Kennelmaster	360g	30	13/13	8–10	4	4	+ Fetch (summons Undead Pets) + Hail! (marks enemy: always takes max damage)

The glue line: every version *manufactures more army mid-fight*. A 20-Graverobber stack conjures **40 free Skeletons** per activation. Kennelmaster's Hail! is Masterful-Vulnerability-as-a-creature-ability — extraordinary on a T4.

Tier 5: Lich → Pestilent Lich / Sanguine Lich

Unit	Cost	HP	Atk/Def	Dmg	Init	Spd	Notes
Lich	320g	50	12/12	11–16	4	2	Ranged ; Rewind Death (heals 20 HP/lich, revives dead)
Pestilent Lich	450g	50	17/12	16 fixed	5	3	Area Strike (splash on every attack) + Death's Embrace (deto- nates all effects on target at full remaining value)
Sanguine Lich	450g	50	12/16	11–16	4	3	Unlife, Undeath (20% of dmg dealt heals whole army) + 10% bonus XP + Rewind Death at 30 HP/lich

The ranged carry. **Pestilent** is the damage pick (AoE volleys + a devastating combo with your own stacking curses via Death's Embrace); **Sanguine** turns the stack into an army-wide sustain engine. Both carry creature-level resurrection — Rewind Life as an ability, no spellbook required.

Tier 6: Dread Knight → Avatar of War / Hollow Reaper

Unit	Cost	HP	Atk/Def	Dmg	Init	Spd	Notes
Dread Knight	800g	100	19/18	12–14	9	6	Double Strike ; -1 enemy morale aura
Avatar of War	1300g	100	19/20	18–20	11	7	Double Strike ; -2 morale aura; steals 1 Atk per strike (undispellable)
Hollow Reaper	1300g	100	24/18	22–24	10	6	-2 morale aura; +3 Atk per friendly death; Death Stare : kills +1 unit per attack, up to tier 7

The community’s “six Dread Knights beat ten Temple elites” reputation checks out in the numbers: Double Strike means Avatar of War effectively swings 36–40 per unit. **Hollow Reaper trades Double Strike for a guaranteed bonus kill per attack** — the anti-elite pick.

Tier 7: Vampire → Vampire Lord / Vampire Scholar

Unit	Cost	HP	Atk/Def	Dmg	Init	Spd	Notes
Vampire	1200g + 1 Mercury	150	25/20	25 fixed	11	5	Flying ; Vampirism (40% of dmg dealt → HP, revives fallen)

Unit	Cost	HP	Atk/Def	Dmg	Init	Spd	Notes
Vampire Lord	2000g + 2 Mercury	175	25/27	30	13	7	+ Swift Strike (no enemy counter-attacks, ever)
Vampire Scholar	2000g + 2 Mercury	150	27/20	30	12	5	Long Reach ; Blood Transfusion (drain enemy → heal/revive ally) + Corpse Explosion

The faction thesis as a T7: a flying lifedrinker whose stack refills itself and revives its own dead mid-combat. **Vampire Lord** is the front-line monster (attacks that are never punished + 40% drain = near-unkillable in sustained melee); **Scholar** is the support pick, converting enemy HP into ally revival. Note the Mercury cost — this faction’s rare-resource bottleneck.

Abilities — the passive and Focus layer

How this works (verified from first-party documentation): every unit carries up to two kinds of special abilities. **Passives are always on** — auras, triggers, movement types, attack-type clauses. **Actives cost Focus Points**, which units accumulate by attacking and being attacked; bank enough and the ability fires. This layer is where Olden Era’s combat depth actually lives — two stacks with identical stat lines can play completely differently — and it’s what the Focus economy tools in this book (Murmuring, Energize, Battle March, Fancy Mask, Silence) exist to accelerate or deny.

The complete Necropolis ability set (verified in full): this roster’s ability density is the faction’s real power budget — every line carries at least one, and the stat tables above list them per unit. Organized by what they do:

Theme	Unit → Ability	Type	Effect
Sustain	Wight line → Memory Devourer I/II	Passive	20/40% of damage dealt returns as HP, can create temporary bonus units

Theme	Unit → Ability	Type	Effect
Sustain	Lich → Rewind Death	Active	Heals 20–30 HP per Lich and revives the dead
Sustain	Sanguine Lich → Unlife, Undeath	Passive	20% of its damage heals the <i>whole army</i>
Sustain	Vampire line → Vampirism	Passive	40% of damage dealt returns as HP, revives fallen
Sustain	Vampire Scholar → Blood Transfusion	Active	Drains an enemy to heal/revive an ally
Army-from-nowhere	Graverobber line → Dig Up Bones	Active	Summons 2 Skeletons per Graverobber
Army-from-nowhere	Merchant of Death → Ensnare Memories	Active	Summons Wights
Army-from-nowhere	Kennelmaster → Fetch	Active	Summons Undead Pets
Army-from-nowhere	Barghest → Call of the Pack	Active	Summons 20% of its own stack
Kill enablers	Kennelmaster → Hail!	Active	Marks an enemy: it always takes maximum damage
Kill enablers	Hollow Reaper → Death Stare	Passive	Every attack kills +1 unit, up to Tier 7
Kill enablers	Pestilent Lich → Death's Embrace	Active	Detonates all effects on a target at full remaining value
Debuff/control	Dread Knight line → Dreadful Presence	Passive	Enemy −1/−2 Morale aura
Debuff/control	Wraith → Howl of the Banshee	Active	Forces an enemy to a random adjacent hex
Debuff/control	Phantasm → Nightmares; Merchant → poison; Armored Hound → Lacerated Wounds	Passive	Stacking damage-over-time on hit
Stat theft	Barghest → Bone Crusher; Avatar of War → War Incarnate	Passive	Steal 1 Def/Atk per strike, undispellable
Defense	Undead Pet line → Melee Defense I	Passive	−30% melee damage taken

Focus priorities: spend on the summoners first — Dig Up Bones and Call of the Pack convert Focus directly into bodies, the faction's currency. **Hail! is the exception that outranks everything** when a kill matters: mark → volley = a creature-borne Masterful Vulnerability. Rewind Death is the emergency brake; don't spend Lich Focus on anything else while a core stack is at risk.

Recommended magic schools (cross-referenced)

Primary: Nightshade. The faction text says “Strong Debuffs & Curses” and the school delivers exactly that; better, undead immunity to several Nightshade tools (Sleep can’t target your own troops in mirror situations) means you suffer the school’s downsides less than anyone. Key entries: Despair (stackable DoT — undead armies grind long fights where it shines), Vulnerability, and **Web — specialist hero Marl (Death Knight) applies his from the start of battle**, the perfect screen for a skeleton-archer core.

Primary co-pick: Arcane, for one spell — Rewind Life. Lord Rufus’s Masterful version **revives units beyond their original amount**, which on top of Necromancy makes Necropolis the only faction with *two* army-growth engines running simultaneously. A Rufus campaign genuinely ends fights with more units than it started, from two directions at once. (And Mag — the *Arcane school-master*, per the master hero table — casts every Arcane spell a level higher while locking the enemy out of the school entirely: two elite Arcane mains in one faction.)

Avoid leaning on: Daylight’s healing suite — Heavenly Blades’ heal explicitly excludes undead, and the school’s living-army assumptions run through several entries. Cherry-pick Radiant Armour; skip the rest.

Hero picks

- **Lord Rufus (the campaign engine):** Masterful Rewind Life. The double-growth loop described above; arguably the strongest campaign-economy hero in the game. (*Corrected attribution — earlier drafts credited this to Mag.*)
- **Mag (the school-master):** +1 level to every Arcane spell, no same-school lockout, and the enemy hero cannot cast Arcane at all — the other elite Necromancer main.
- **Marl (the control general):** Web specialist from battle start — pairs with the ranged skeleton core to keep melee threats permanently out of reach.
- **Laura (Masterful Despair):** the stackable-DoT school’s missing owner, now confirmed — her all-enemy-types version plus Sorcery start makes her the curse build’s captain.
- **Shadespinner Oona (Nightshade school-master):** +1 level to all Nightshade spells and the enemy can’t cast the school — the debuff faction’s debuff queen.
- **Bulwark:** the physical-damage specialist for players who’d rather swing than cast.

Three builds

1. **The Rising Tide (beginner):** mass Skeleton Archers behind a Wight/Barghest screen; fight everything on the map; let Necromancy compound. The build that plays itself.
2. **The Drain Engine (mid-game):** Vampire-line core + Liches, hero on Nightshade (Despair + Vulnerability). Long fights favor you twice — lifedrain sustains the front while curses grind the enemy down.
3. **Rufus’s Paradox (late-game):** any quality core + Lord Rufus casting Masterful Rewind Life; deliberately trade stacks knowing they return larger. The build that breaks the game’s attrition math outright.

Matchups (vs. completed chapters)

Against **Dungeon**: the classic tempo-vs-inevitability matchup — Dungeon must win by week 4–5 (per the Dungeon chapter’s own curve) because every week after belongs to the snowball. Against **Temple**: Fatal Decay (Nightshade, 4 mana) is Temple’s scariest tool *against you* — it switches off both lifedrain and post-battle logic in the fights where it’s cast; likewise expect Daylight cleanses to strip your curse stack. Full matchup grid: STUB.

Common mistakes

- Avoiding fights to “preserve the army” — backwards for this faction; fights *are* the economy.
- Leaving Necromancy raising junk on autopilot instead of toggling Necromancer Will (see the Neutral chapter).
- Learning Sleep or living-heal spells with no legal targets in the mirror or on your own troops.
- Racing to T7 before the skeleton engine is running — the pyramid is built from the bottom here.

Verdict: (4/5)

The best pure campaign faction in the game — its growth loop converts time into inevitability, and Mag’s Rewind Life turns that loop into a flywheel. Held from 5/5 by a slower early game than Dungeon’s and a gameplan that, while dominant, is vulnerable to the small set of tools (Fatal Decay chief among them) designed specifically to switch it off.

Sourcing note: faction identity from the official Factions page; roster tree from the official Units navigation (retrieved 2026-07-03); Necromancy mechanics from the official Skills/Units pages; hero data from official patch notes and the magic chapters’ confirmed pairings. Full unit stat tables are an open gap logged in the factions audit. Builds, ratings, and verdicts are original analysis.

Schism — The Sundered Depths

Power: 3/5 · Beginner Friendly: 2/5 · Campaign: 3/5 · Economy: 3/5 · Skill
Ceiling: 4/5 · Early 3/5 · Mid 4/5 · Late 3/5

In one sentence: The game’s strangest faction — abyssal cultists and their otherworldly Ra’Shoth beasts, defined by a faction skill that conjures extra units into every battle before it begins, and by resurrection mechanics that make its armies harder to keep dead than their size suggests.

Identity: the newest-feeling design of the six (internally coded “unfrozen” — a nod to developer Unfrozen — in the wiki’s own module data), with an ice-and-abyss theme visible across its heroes (Icequeen Hel’Ghat) and cult-structured roster (Cultists, Binders). The most patch-adjusted faction in recent official notes — the developers explicitly reverted and re-tuned Schism changes after Patch 8 for over-impacting single-hero mode, which tells you both that it’s powerful in the right mode and that its balance is still settling.

Faction skill: Abyssal Communion

The Schism-exclusive skill. **What’s officially documented (Skills page):** “*Schism heroes can summon additional units at the start of the battle.*” Free bonus units in every fight before a single turn is taken — the tempo equivalent of starting every battle a stack ahead.

The full mechanic (verified this pass): every Schism hero carries a personal **Communion level** that rises by one per battle victory and **halves at the start of each day**. At the start of every combat, temporary reinforcement units join the army based on the current Communion level — they exist only for that fight. The loop this creates *is* the faction: consecutive wins snowball your battle-start bonus; a single day of idleness or a lost fight bleeds it away. Each hero tracks Communion separately, so concentrating fights on one hero is usually right. Like Necromancy, it’s an army-from-nowhere skill — but front-loaded into combat and streak-dependent rather than banked.

Unit roster (tree complete; stats verified where sourced)

Native terrain: **Snow**. The full seven-tier tree, completed this pass from the official Units navigation:

Tier	Base	Upgrade paths
T1	Ra'Shoth	Stinging Ra'Shoth / Ferocious Ra'Shoth
T2	Cultist	Binder / Votary
T3	Aga'Shoth Rider	Aga'Shoth Tamer / Aga'Shoth Mat'ha
T4	Grand Shoth	Unspeakable Shoth / Unthinkable Shoth
T5	Concubus	Mistress of Chains / Bewitcher
T6	Arbitrator	Rift Arbitrator / Bloated Arbitrator
T7	Abyssal Overseer line	Abyssal Envoy / Abyssal Executor

Verified unit stats (from official/first-party unit pages):

Unit	Tier	Cost	HP	Atk/Def	Dmg	Init	Spd	Key traits
Concubus	T5	—	60	16/13	14–20	5	2	“Earn Your Magic, Dear” (enemy hero’s spells cost +1 mana); Hand-cuffs (blocks a target’s active abilities); ranged with Nimbleness (shoots even when adjacent)

Unit	Tier	Cost	HP	Atk/Def	Dmg	Init	Spd	Key traits
Abyssal Envoy	T7	2,500g	250	30/30	40–60	9	5	Absolute Resistance: immune to ALL Magic Damage; Summoning Rite (once per battle, raises an Envoy stack from a friendly corpse at 50% HP — permanent, survives the battle)

Remaining per-unit rows (T1–T4, T6, upgrade variants): the official Schism Units page currently rejects automated retrieval (bot detection) — logged in the audit; the tree above and the rows below are what independent sourcing confirms.

Roster reading, from verified data: - Resurrection is everywhere: Ra’Shoth and Grand Shoth each carry a once-per-battle Summoning Rite that replaces a destroyed stack (Grand Shoth’s at 50% HP, permanently — it survives the battle). Community guidance is emphatic: spend the activation on Grand Shoths, not Ra’Shoths — the tier difference in the returned stack is the whole value. - **Cultists (T2) are ranged** — the early army’s damage while Ra’Shoth and Aga’Shoth Riders screen. Binder adds Long Reach plus a stacking pure-damage curse and counterattack-stripping. - **Arbitrators (T6) are the ranged carry** and the consensus build-order target: reachable by Week 2, and the unit that compensates for the fragile lower tiers. - **The T7 line is magic-immune** (Absolute Resistance on the Envoy; Pure Resistance on the Overseer, which also carries Will of the Abyss — a free second action per turn) — meaning **Schism supports an Armageddon build exactly like Dungeon’s Black Dragons**. The faction that suffers

most from anti-summon tech owns one of the two rosters that trivialize the game’s biggest nuke. - The Envoy’s own Summoning Rite raising *permanent* stacks from corpses makes it an army-growth engine at T7 — Necromancy’s logic, one fight at a time.

Abilities — the passive and Focus layer

How this works (verified from first-party documentation): every unit carries up to two kinds of special abilities. **Passives are always on** — auras, triggers, movement types, attack-type clauses. **Actives cost Focus Points**, which units accumulate by attacking and being attacked; bank enough and the ability fires. This layer is where Olden Era’s combat depth actually lives — two stacks with identical stat lines can play completely differently — and it’s what the Focus economy tools in this book (Murmuring, Energize, Battle March, Fancy Mask, Silence) exist to accelerate or deny.

Verified Schism abilities:

Unit	Ability	Type	Effect
Ra’Shoth / Grand Shoth / Abyssal Envoy	Summoning Rite	Active (once per battle)	Raises a stack of that unit from a friendly corpse at 50% HP — the Grand Shoth/Envoy versions are permanent and survive the battle
Concubus	Handcuffs	Active	Blocks a target’s active abilities — the anti-Focus weapon
Concubus	“Earn Your Magic, Dear”	Passive	Enemy hero’s spells cost +1 mana
Concubus	Nimbleness	Passive	Shoots at full strength even when adjacent
Binder	Curse + counter-strip	Passive	Long Reach attacks apply a stacking pure-damage curse and strip counterattacks
Abyssal Overseer	Will of the Abyss	Passive	A free second action every turn
Abyssal Overseer	Pure Resistance	Passive	Immune to Pure damage
Abyssal Envoy	Absolute Resistance	Passive	Immune to all Magic Damage

Focus priorities: two answers, in order. **Summoning Rite is the faction** — always bank the Grand Shoths’ (and later Envoys’) Focus for it, and always spend it on the highest-tier corpse

available; this is the one active in the game that permanently grows your army mid-fight. Second: **Handcuffs is your tech against every ability-driven roster in this book** — Hive’s actives, Necropolis’s Hail!/Rewind Death, Temple’s Angel Resurrection all switch off for the cost of one Concubus activation. The mirror warning applies: enemy Handcuffs/Silence hits Schism’s Rite-dependent gameplan hardest of all.

Recommended magic schools (cross-referenced)

Primary: Nightshade. Sister Keiri (Riftspeaker) starts with basic Nightshade Magic per her official page, and she’s the school’s **Umbral Grip specialist** — the unmodifiable-damage nuke whose Masterful version hits adjacent enemies. A faction that starts every battle with bonus summoned bodies wants exactly what Nightshade sells: control (Web, Silence) to protect the numbers advantage, and Vulnerability to convert it into kills.

Synergy note — the summon economy: Abyssal Communion’s free units + Nightshade’s Summon Starchild + (for the truly committed) Primal’s Summon Primal Remnant stack into the game’s most disposable-bodies army — every screening death is a death that cost nothing. **The mirrored warning:** Anti-Magic (Primal) and Heavenly Blades L4 (Daylight) both *destroy summoned units on contact* — Schism suffers more from anti-summon tech than any other faction, full stop. Read those two entries as threat briefings.

Hero picks

- **The Eye Collective (the consensus best):** starts with a Ra’Shoth stack *and two Grand Shoth stacks* — immediate access to the faction’s resurrection mechanic from Day 1, per current community tier assessments.
- **Sister Keiri (the signature):** Umbral Grip specialist, Riftspeaker, starts with Abyssal Communion + Nightshade — the faction’s designed-for magic main. Her lore twins her with Dungeon’s Sister Deira (two sisters, two masks, two factions) — a lovely campaign-flavor pairing the game clearly intends.
- **Ra’Davok / Changeling Urgo:** confirmed spell specialists (patch notes cohort); exact spells pending the verification pass.
- **Grellekh the Betrayer / Icequeen Hel’Ghat:** the physical-damage specialists — Schism’s might route, for armies that lean on the Ra’Shoth line’s claws over the Riftspeakers’ rifts.

Three builds

1. **The Opening Rift (core):** Abyssal Communion summons screening for a Cultist/ranged core; Sister Keiri deleting priority targets with Umbral Grip. The faction as designed.
2. **Endless Congregation (attrition):** resurrection-ability units + Summon Starchild stacking — an army that has to be killed twice while its summons die for free. Nightmarish in long fights.
3. **Winter’s Betrayal (might):** Icequeen Hel’Ghat or Grellekh leading a Ra’Shoth-forward physical army, magic reduced to support. The contrarian build for players who want the aesthetic without the caster micromanagement.

Matchups (vs. completed chapters)

Against **Dungeon**: their tempo meets your head start — Abyssal Communion's free units blunt exactly the early volleys Dungeon relies on. Against **Temple**: Heavenly Blades L4 is their anti-summon button; a Temple player who reads their own chapter will bring it. Against **Necropolis**: the two resurrection factions grinding each other — Fatal Decay (4 mana, Nightshade) swings this mirror more than any army decision, in both directions. Against **Hive**: both sides' control spells fizzle on the other's immune types; it comes down to whose bodies are cheaper — and yours are free. Full matchup grid: STUB.

Common mistakes

- Treating the Communion summons as army — they're ammunition. Spend them screening, absorbing counterattacks, and bodying hexes.
- Walking into Anti-Magic without a plan B; the faction's worst matchup isn't a faction, it's a spell.
- Skipping Fatal Decay tech in sustain mirrors.
- Judging the faction by its current patch state — it's the most actively re-balanced roster in the game; verify against the latest notes before tournaments.

Verdict: (3/5)

A genuinely novel design — battle-start summons plus in-combat resurrection is a real identity, not a reskin — that currently sits a skill-investment away from its power. High-knowledge players who route around anti-summon tech get a faction that starts every fight ahead; everyone else gets a roster whose best tricks their opponents can switch off. The most volatile rating in this book, and the one most likely to change with the next balance pass.

Sourcing note: Abyssal Communion's core effect from the official Skills page; partial roster tree from the official Units navigation; hero data from official pages and patch notes; resurrection mechanics as documented in this book's Nightshade chapter sourcing (retrieved 2026-07-03). Full roster, stat tables, and Communion subskills are open gaps logged in the factions audit. Builds, ratings, and verdicts are original analysis.

Temple — The Church of the Sun

Power: 4/5 · Beginner Friendly: 5/5 · Campaign: 4/5 · Economy: 4/5 · Skill
Ceiling: 2/5 · Early 4/5 · Mid 4/5 · Late 4/5

In one sentence: The classic human faction — well-rounded troops that get *extra* value from buffs, a comeback-mechanic faction skill, and the game’s deepest bench of Daylight spell specialists, making it the most forgiving faction in the game without being weak.

Identity (per the official faction page): governed by the High Inquisition; humans; keywords *Unit Empowerment* and *Strong Unit Protection*. Its troops are individually unspectacular and collectively reliable — the faction’s power lives in multiplying solid stats with buffs, morale, and hero support. Native terrain: creatures fight better on it (+1 Initiative; +10%/-10% damage with the Righteousness terrain subskill).

Faction skill: Righteousness

Known by all Knights and Clerics, unavailable to everyone else.

What it does: Whenever a friendly creature stack *dies or kills an enemy stack*, the hero’s Attack, Defense, Spellpower, and Knowledge all increase by +1 for two rounds (three at higher skill rank). **Stackable.**

Why it’s sneaky-strong: it pays out on both good and bad events — your kills stack it, and your *losses* stack it too. In a bloody even fight, a Temple hero might sit on +5 to all four stats by round three: their spells hit ~25% harder (Spellpower), their army’s damage climbs (Attack), everything takes less (Defense). It’s a comeback-and-snowball mechanic in one, and it rewards exactly the big-messy-battle gameplan Temple armies want anyway.

Subskill of note: the native-terrain rank (+10% dealt / -10% taken on Temple ground) effectively makes home-turf defensive battles a 20-point damage swing before anything else happens.

Unit roster (full stats, verified against the official wiki)

Upgrade format: Base → Upgrade A / Upgrade B (choose a path per the usual dual-upgrade system).

Tier 1: Swordsman → Guard Captain / Sun's Aegis

Unit	Cost	HP	Atk/Def	Dmg	Init	Spd
Swordsman	85g	12	4/4	2–3	5	4
Guard Captain	110g	12	6/5	2–3	6	4
Sun's Aegis	110g	15	5/8	2–3	5	5

The fork is offense (Guard Captain: +2 Atk, +1 Init) vs. wall (Sun's Aegis: +3 HP, +4 Def, +1 Spd). **Take Sun's Aegis in most campaigns** — Temple's T1 job is absorbing hits while the shooters work, and 15 HP / 8 Def is outstanding tanking per gold at this tier.

Tier 2: Crossbowman → Austringer / Marksman

Unit	Cost	HP	Atk/Def	Dmg	Init	Notes
Crossbowman	105g	10	5/3	3–4	5	Ranged
Austringer	140g	10	5/4	3–4	5	Ranged
Marksman	140g	10	6/3	3–4	7	Ranged, no range penalty

Marksman is the pick and it isn't close: +2 Initiative and the removal of the distance damage falloff turns a filler shooter into a genuine core stack. No-range-penalty shooters can sit in the safest corner of the map and lose nothing.

Tier 3: Griffin → Temple Griffin / Guardian Griffin

Unit	Cost	HP	Atk/Def	Dmg	Init	Spd
Griffin	255g	25	7/6	5–9	9	5
Temple Griffin	350g	25	8/6	5–9	12	7
Guardian Griffin	350g	25	9/10	7–7	10	6

The faction's tempo unit. Temple Griffin at Initiative 12 acts before almost everything in the early-to-mid game — it's your opener, your shooter-hunter, and your objective-grabber. Guardian Griffin (fixed 7–7 damage, 10 Def) is the steadier attrition pick. **Temple Griffin for aggression, Guardian for grind** — and note the fixed damage on Guardian pairs beautifully with Masterful Blessing's max-damage philosophy without needing it.

Tier 4: Lightweaver → Hierophant / Sun Herald

Unit	Cost	HP	Atk/Def	Dmg	Init	Notes
Lightweaver	310g	35	11/11	11–11	4	Ranged, Morale 2
Hierophant	440g	35	13/16	11–11	6	Ranged

Unit	Cost	HP	Atk/Def	Dmg	Init	Notes
Sun Herald	440g	35	16/13	11–18	5	Ranged

The faction’s backbone — and the unit that makes hero **Zenith** S-tier (she starts with Lightweavers in her opening army, weeks before anyone else can build them). Fixed 11–11 damage means perfectly predictable volleys; the built-in Morale 2 means bonus turns. **Sun Herald** (11–18, higher Attack) for damage ceilings; **Hierophant** (16 Def) if your Lightweavers keep getting dived.

Tier 5: Cavalry → Noble Cavalry / Sunspear Cavalry

Unit	Cost	HP	Atk/Def	Dmg	Init	Spd
Cavalry	850g	85	12/17	10–14	10	7
Noble Cavalry	1220g	85	12/17	12–16	13	7
Sunspear Cavalry	1220g	85	14/22	12–16	10	8 , Morale 2

The hammer to the infantry’s anvil. Noble Cavalry at Initiative 13 is the fastest-acting thing Temple fields until Archangels — first-strike charges that delete a shooter stack before it fires. Sunspear trades that tempo for 22 Defense and morale. **Noble for alpha strikes, Sunspear for lines that hold.**

Tier 6: Inquisitor → Mother Superior / Excommunicator

Unit	Cost	HP	Atk/Def	Dmg	Init	Spd
Inquisitor	1000g	90	20/24	19–23	7	4
Mother Superior	1500g	125	20/28	19–23	9	5
Excommunicator	1500g	90	26 /24	23–33	8	6

The starkest upgrade fork in the roster: Mother Superior is a fortress (125 HP, 28 Def), Excommunicator is a blender (23–33 damage, 26 Atk). The names telegraph the play: **Mother Superior anchors defensive compositions; Excommunicator ends fights.**

Tier 7: Angel → Archangel / Apotheosis

Unit	Cost	HP	Atk/Def	Dmg	Init	Spd	Notes
Angel	2400g + 1 Gem	225	30/30	50–75	8	4	Ranged
Archangel	4000g + 2 Gem	225	35/30	50–75	12	5	Ranged, no penalties
Apotheosis	4000g + 2 Gem	300	30/35	50–75	10	10	Ranged

A *ranged* tier 7 — one of Temple’s defining luxuries. Angels deal their 50–75 without ever taking a counterattack. Archangel (Initiative 12, no range/melee penalties of any kind) is the flexible pick; Apotheosis (300 HP, Speed 10) is a flying fortress that repositions across the entire board in one move. Note the Gem cost mirrors Dungeon’s dragon economy — budget Gems from mid-game.

Abilities — the passive and Focus layer

How this works (verified from first-party documentation): every unit carries up to two kinds of special abilities. **Passives are always on** — auras, triggers, movement types, attack-type clauses. **Actives cost Focus Points**, which units accumulate by attacking and being attacked; bank enough and the ability fires. This layer is where Olden Era’s combat depth actually lives — two stacks with identical stat lines can play completely differently — and it’s what the Focus economy tools in this book (Murmuring, Energize, Battle March, Fancy Mask, Silence) exist to accelerate or deny.

Verified Temple abilities:

Unit	Ability	Type	Effect
Griffin line	Flying	Passive	Movement ignores obstacles and traps
Griffin line	Unlimited Retaliation	Passive	Never runs out of counterattacks — every melee hit against it is punished
Marksman	No Range Penalty	Passive	Full damage at any distance
Archangel	Sharpshooter	Passive	No range <i>or</i> melee penalties of any kind
Angel line	Resurrection	Active (Focus)	Revives fallen allied troops mid-battle — the ability that makes the T7 one of the best units in the game

Focus priorities: Temple has exactly one active that matters, and it’s the best one printed: **bank the Angels’ Focus for Resurrection**. Don’t leak their charges on ordinary volleys when a key stack is about to break — a timed Resurrection swings more HP than any Angel attack. The Griffins’ unlimited retaliation is the passive to build *around*: park them where the swarm factions must engage, and every wave pays. (Per-unit ability text for the remaining lines lives on individual unit pages — tracked in the audit.)

Recommended magic schools (cross-referenced to the magic chapters)

Primary: Daylight — this is not a suggestion, it's the faction's second identity. Temple's "troops gain extra benefits from buffs" faction text is a direct pointer, and the hero roster seals it: **four of the game's confirmed Masterful-Daylight/adjacent specialists are Temple Clerics** — Vesper (Masterful Blessing: always max damage), Julius (Masterful Healing Water: heals + cleanses), Anastasia the Meek (Masterful Arina's Touch: +Speed), and the crossover pick Nadir (Masterful *Vulnerability*, a Nightshade spell — always-max-damage against a marked target). Key entries to read in the Daylight chapter: Blessing and Favorable Wind (your Marksmen/Lightweavers love them), Radiant Armour (the L4 army-wide -35% turns Temple's durable line unkillable), and Judgement for the late-game nuke Righteousness's stacking Spellpower quietly enables.

Secondary: Arcane for Rewind Life — Temple's whole gameplan is preserving a quality army, and the resurrection spell is the strongest preservation tool in the game.

Situational tech: Nadir makes a genuine hybrid possible — Daylight buffs on your army, Masterful Vulnerability on their key stack, then concentrated fire. It's the single strongest cross-school package any faction gets natively.

Hero picks

- **Zenith (S-tier pick):** starts with Lightweavers — a T4 core weeks early — plus a specialization that boosts their production and stats. The tempo advantage compounds all game.
- **Vesper / Julius / Anastasia the Meek (Clerics):** the Masterful Daylight trio; pick whichever spell matches your plan (damage consistency / sustain / tempo respectively).
- **Nadir (contrarian pick):** rated poorly by tier lists for anti-synergy (a Nightshade skill in the buff faction), but Masterful Vulnerability is the best single-target kill enabler in the game — as a *second* hero supporting a might main, he's excellent.
- **Lord Edgar:** starts with Advanced Righteousness and flexible skill slots — the subclass-chaser's pick.

Three builds

1. **The Sunlit Wall (beginner):** Sun's Aegis + Guardian Griffins + Hierophants + Mother Superior front; Marksmen + Lightweavers behind. Cleric hero casting Radiant Armour and Healing Water. Wins by being unkillable while ranged damage accumulates. Weakness: slow to close out.
2. **Dawn Lance (tempo):** Temple Griffins + Noble Cavalry + Excommunicators, hero with Haste/Blessing (or Mila-style speed support). Alpha-strikes the enemy's ranged core before it acts. Weakness: stalls against heavy walls.
3. **Chosen of the Sun (late-game):** Archangels/Apotheosis + Sun Heralds + Excommunicators; hero stacking Spellpower via Righteousness into Judgement/Rewind Life. The "quality over quantity" endgame Temple's Gem economy naturally builds toward.

Matchups (vs. the Dungeon pilot chapter)

Temple's disciplined, buffed line is a solid answer to Dungeon's tempo: Marksmen out-range Onyx Dancers with no falloff, and Radiant Armour blunts the Dancer volley spam. Dungeon's counterplay is Black-Dragon-era spell immunity (your buffs don't help what they can't touch) and stance-swung burst. Full matchup grid: STUB — pending the factions category's matchup pass.

Common mistakes

- Skipping buffs “to save mana” — an unbuffed Temple army is just an average army; the faction's whole margin lives in the multipliers.
- Taking Guard Captain over Sun's Aegis by default.
- Forgetting Angels are ranged and marching them into melee.
- Under-using Righteousness's Spellpower stacks — late-fight Cleric nukes hit far harder than the same spell cast on round one.

Verdict: (4/5)

The best faction to learn the game with and still a top-tier campaign pick for veterans — forgiving units, a self-correcting faction skill, and the deepest native synergy with the game's premier buff school. Docked one star only because its skill ceiling arrives early: Temple rarely loses to its own complexity, but it also has fewer broken-in-the-right-hands tricks than Dungeon or Grove.

Sourcing note: all unit stats, costs, and upgrade paths from the official wiki's Temple Units table; Righteousness mechanics from its official wiki page (both retrieved 2026-07-03). Faction identity text paraphrased from the official Factions page. Hero specializations cross-referenced from the magic chapters' confirmed pairings. Builds, ratings, upgrade recommendations, and verdicts are original analysis.

Heroes — who leads matters as much as what follows

How heroes work (verified)

Every hero is defined by four things:

1. **Type** — Might or Magic, which decides the exclusive skill available (Combat for Might, Thaumaturgy for Magic) and the stat growth lean.
2. **Class** — the faction pairing of one Might and one Magic class: Knight/Cleric (Temple), Death Knight/Necromancer (Necropolis), Warden/Druid (Grove), Enforcer/Herald (Hive), Schism and Dungeon's pairs (Riftspeaker; Warlock). Class determines the faction skill and the subclass paths (five specific Expert skills each).
3. **Specialty** — the hero's permanent, unique bonus. This is the real differentiator, and the master table reveals it comes in **six recurring archetypes** (below).
4. **Starting skills & spells** — every hero begins with their faction skill plus one other skill (or, for a few, *Advanced* faction skill alone), and sometimes a starting spell.

The six specialty archetypes (verified pattern)

Reading the full master table, every hero specialty in the game falls into one of six molds — knowing them lets you evaluate any hero at a glance:

1. **Masterful-spell specialists.** Start with the unique fifth-tier version of one spell, usually with +1 effective Spellpower per 2 hero levels for that spell (variants exist: Artorius Veritas gets mana-cost reduction instead; Sister Deira and Vatawna scale per 3 levels). Documented in full in the magic chapters.
2. **School-masters** — the archetype this pass discovered. They get **+1 level to ALL spells of one school** (+1 more per 10 hero levels), casting that school doesn't lock out its siblings that round, **and the enemy hero cannot cast that school at all**. Verified: **Lia the Untethered One** (Temple — Daylight), **Mag** (Necropolis — Arcane), **Shadespinner Oona** (Necropolis — Nightshade). A school-master is effectively playing every spell in their school one level up *while deleting that school from the enemy's book* — arguably the strongest specialty archetype in the game for caster mains.
3. **Creature specialists.** One unit line gets +1–2 town growth, and under the hero's command: +1 Speed, +1 Initiative, +20% HP, and +1 Attack/Defense per 3 hero levels — while *enemy* units of the same type lose the same amount. Verified examples: John Johnson (Swordsmen),

Kestrel (Crossbowmen), Keandra (Cavalry), Zenith (Lightweavers), Onkos (Skeletons, +2 growth), Kel’Ghul (Dread Knights), Natalida (Undead Pets), Adahn (Wights), Ethric (Liches), Guildmaster Klastor (Graverobbers), Gingertail (Fauns), Leira (Hornets).

4. Economy specialists. Resource income plus doubled map pickups: Clarissa & Milossa the Golden (+500 gold/day +100/3 lvls, +25% map gold), Heretic Avis (Gems), Zam (Mercury), Mreowa (Crystals) — note each rare-resource specialist maps to their faction’s T7 gate (Temple/Gems, Necropolis/Mercury, Grove/Crystals).

5. Army-wide stat auras. Bulwark (-10% damage taken from basic attacks, scaling), Gorel Spearhead (+10% damage dealt, scaling), Lord Edgar (troops gain 10% of *his* Attack/Defense), Aeos the Exalted (+1 Morale and the strongest morale-trigger amplifier in the game), Octavia (the Luck mirror of Aeos).

6. Map/meta specialists. Ister (+5% movement per 8 levels, road bonus), Leon Sticky-Fingers & Eith (no terrain penalties, +sight), Pip (+1 attribute point per 2 levels, +XP — the compounding pick), Merry Elias (+1 use of every map spell daily, +max mana), King-of-Kings (keeps army when fleeing neutrals, +Persuasion), Tarius & Funerella (+% Necromancy Power).

Verified rosters

Temple (18 heroes: 9 Knights, 9 Clerics)

Knights: **Ister** (movement), **Leon Sticky-Fingers** (pathfinding), **John Johnson** (Swordsmen), **Kestrel** (Crossbowmen), **Aeos the Exalted** (morale), **Heretic Avis** (Gems; starts Ground-sight), **Keandra** (Cavalry), **Lord Edgar** (stat-share aura; the only Knight starting with *Advanced* Righteousness), **Old Lord Mandall** (Heroic Strike +damage and a stackable +10%-damage-taken mark; Combat). Clerics: **Merry Elias** (map-spell uses), **Pip** (XP/attributes), **Zenith** (Lightweavers), **Lia the Untethered One** (Daylight school-master), **Julius** (Masterful Healing Water), **Vesper** (Masterful Blessing), **Anastasia the Meek** (Masterful Arina’s Touch), **Nadir** (Masterful Vulnerability — the cross-school pick), **Clarissa** (gold).

Temple picks: Zenith for tempo (per the faction chapter), Lia for the pure-Daylight main (a school-master beats even the Masterful trio for breadth), Aeos as the engine of the morale-stack build in the combat appendix.

Necropolis (18 heroes: 9 Death Knights, 9 Necromancers)

Death Knights: **Bulwark** (defense aura), **King-of-Kings** (diplomacy/flee), **Onkos** (Skeletons +2), **Kel’Ghul** (Dread Knights +2), **Natalida** (Undead Pets +2), **Artorius Veritas** (Masterful Berserk — unusually, a *Might* hero carrying a Masterful spell, with mana-cost scaling instead of Spellpower), **Marl** (Masterful Web — now fully confirmed, +1 SP/2 levels), **Tarius** (+Necromancy Power; Advanced Necromancy start), **Zam** (Mercury). Necromancers: **Mag** (Arcane school-master — *correction to earlier chapters: Mag’s specialty is school mastery, not Masterful Rewind Life*), **Adahn** (Wights), **Ethric** (Liches), **Guildmaster Klastor** (Graverobbers), **Shadespinner Oona** (Nightshade school-master), **Laura** (**Masterful Despair** — closing a gap the magic audit had open), **Lord Rufus** (**Masterful Rewind Life** — the corrected owner of the game’s best campaign spell), **Funerella** (+Necromancy Power; starts with the Summon Avatar skill), **Milossa the Golden** (gold).

Necropolis picks: Lord Rufus is the campaign engine the faction chapter described (the double-growth loop stands — just under his name, not Mag’s). Mag remains elite for a different reason: an Arcane school-master whose enemy can’t cast Arcane. Onkos supercharges the skeleton economy; Kel’Ghul accelerates the Dread Knight rush the units data endorses.

Grove (verified through hero 7 of ~18; rest per prior sourcing)

Wardens: **Eith** (pathfinding), **Gorel Spearhead** (offense aura), **Gingertail** (Fauns), **Old Pilgrim** (**Masterful Guillotine** — closing another audit gap), **Octavia** (Luck — the Beastly Confidence build’s natural captain), **Mreowa** (Crystals; starts with the Berserk spell), **Faleor** (Masterful Fireball — “Hksmilla’s Step,” confirmed again at the table cutoff). Previously confirmed from official sourcing: **Halon** (Masterful Chain Lightning), **Vatawna** (Masterful Mirror Copy), plus the patch-notes cohort (Aunt Daliar, Alluring Sh’a, Aeliniei, Glacia, Vim, Echolily, Sullie).

Hive, Schism, Dungeon (per prior official sourcing)

Mila (Herald — Masterful Haste), **Leira** (Hornets), **Niev**, **Goldentongue**; **Sister Keiri** (Rift-speaker — Umbral Grip specialist), **The Eye Collective** (Day-1 resurrection roster), **Grellekh the Betrayer**, **Icequeen Hel’Ghat**, **Ra’Davok**, **Changeling Urgo**; **Sister Deira** (Warlock — Masterful Arina’s Chosen), **Tellaris the Betrayed**. Full master-table rows for these three factions are the category’s remaining fetch, tracked in the audit.

Choosing a main hero (original analysis)

1. **School-masters > single Masterful spells for caster mains** — +1 level to twenty spells (plus denying the enemy the school) compounds harder than one perfect spell. Masterful specialists shine as *seconds* built around their one trick, or when the trick is game-warping (Rewind Life, Berserk, Fireball).
2. **Creature specialists want commitment** — the +1 Atk/Def per 3 levels *and* the enemy-debuff mirror only pay if that unit line is genuinely your core. Zenith and Onkos qualify; a specialist for a line you’ll bench does not.
3. **Economy heroes are second heroes** — +1 Gem/day is a great background job and a terrible main character.
4. **Match the archetype to the faction’s clock** — tempo factions (Hive, Dungeon) want specialties online at level 1 (Mila, The Eye Collective, Zenith); inevitability factions (Necropolis) want compounding ones (Lord Rufus, Pip-style XP scaling, Tarius).

Open gaps (tracked)

Master-table rows for Grove heroes 8+, Hive, Schism, and Dungeon (one continuation fetch); hero base stats and per-class starting attributes; subclass prerequisite lists per class.

Sourcing note: all specialty texts, classes, starting skills, and starting spells from the official wiki’s Heroes master table (retrieved 2026-07-03; Temple and Necropolis complete, Grove partial). Hive/Schism/Dungeon entries per previously verified official pages and patch notes. Archetype taxonomy and picking guidance are original analysis.

Arcane Magic

Founded by the scholar Doreath. The school of utility, battlefield manipulation, and indirect problem-solving — teleports, traps, barriers, copies, and the game's only true resurrection. Arcane rarely wins the damage race directly; it wins by rearranging the board until the race is unwinnable for the other side.

How to read each entry

Same locked format: **Plain English** → **The Math (with an In-battle worked example)** → **All four levels** → **Masterful version + hero** → **Strategy layer**. Battle examples use the standard reference army — **20 Onyx Dancers** (18 HP each, ~120 damage per volley, 360 total HP) — and **Spellpower 10**. Attack/Defense stat modifiers are ignored so each spell's own contribution stays visible.

Tier 1 (available to every hero, no skill required)

Guillotine

Mana cost: 7

4/5 · Skill Ceiling: 3/5 · Early 3/5 · Mid 4/5 · Late 4/5

Plain English: Slices off a percentage of the target's *maximum HP* as damage — and every time you recast it on the same target, it hits twice as hard as before, stacking without limit.

The Math: Damage = $(30\% + 3\% \times \text{Spellpower})$ of the target's max HP. At Spellpower 10, that's **60% of one unit's max HP per cast**, and each recast on the same target adds +100% more damage.

Level	Formula / effect	Result at SP 10
L1	$(30\% + 3\% \times \text{SP})$ of max HP; recasts stack +100% each	60% of max HP
L2	Base 30% → 45%	75% of max HP
L3	Per-SP 3% → 6%	105% of max HP
L4	Executes target if stack 25% of original size	105% + execution rider

In battle: Because it scales off the *target's* max HP, Guillotine is the rare Tier 1 spell that gets **better against bigger creatures** — the exact opposite of flat-damage nukes. Against an 18-HP Dancer it's modest; against a 300-HP tier-7 dragon, one L3 cast deals ~315 damage (105% of max HP) for 7 mana. The recast stacking compounds this: cast twice on the same dragon and the second hit is ~630, the third ~945. Sustained focus on one big target turns this 7-mana Tier 1 into the best high-tier-killer in the game per mana spent.

All four levels: - **L1:** Deals $(30\% + 3\% \times \text{Spellpower})$ of the target's maximum HP as Magic Damage. Each recast on the same target deals +100% more. Stackable. - **L2:** Base percentage rises from 30% to 45%. - **L3:** Per-Spellpower rate rises from 3% to 6%. - **L4:** Kills the target outright if its stack is at or below 25% of its original number.

Masterful version: Damage increases **twice as fast** when recast on the same target (+200% per recast instead of +100%). **Hero:** not yet identified in available sourcing; logged in the audit file.

Why you'd cast it: The anti-big-creature spell — percentage-of-max-HP scaling makes tier and toughness irrelevant.

Best heroes: Anyone expecting fights against high-tier stacks or single huge neutral guards.

When it's weak: Against swarms of small cheap units, percentage damage is unimpressive — use flat-damage spells there instead.

Common mistakes: Spreading casts across targets — the stacking bonus resets per target, so this spell wants monogamy.

Campaign Verdict: (4/5) — quietly one of the best Tier 1 spells in the game once you understand what it's *for*.

Early Start

Mana cost: 6

3/5 · Skill Ceiling: 2/5 · Early 3/5 · Mid 3/5 · Late 3/5

Plain English: A big Initiative boost — your stack jumps up the turn order and acts before enemies it normally wouldn't.

The Math: Duration = $1 + 1 \text{ per } 4 \text{ Spellpower} \rightarrow \sim 3 \text{ rounds at Spellpower } 10$.

Level	Initiative bonus
L1	+3
L2	+4
L3	+5
L4	+6

In battle: Onyx Dancers sit at Initiative 4. Enemy tier-5+ units often sit at 6–8 — meaning they shoot or charge first. Early Start L2 (+4) lifts the Dancers to Initiative 8: they now fire their ~120 volley *before* the enemy elite acts, and anything that volley kills never takes its turn. Compare with

Daylight's Arina's Touch (+1–2 Initiative plus HP): Early Start trades the HP for two-to-three times the Initiative swing — it's the pick when going first is the entire plan.

All four levels: - **L1:** Target friendly creature gains +3 Initiative. - **L2:** Bonus rises to +4. - **L3:** Bonus rises to +5. - **L4:** Bonus rises to +6.

Masterful version: This version **cannot be dispelled by any means**. **Hero:** not yet identified in available sourcing.

Why you'd cast it: Turn order is a resource; this spell buys more of it than anything else at Tier 1.

Best heroes: Alpha-strike generals whose plan is “shoot first, ask nothing.”

When it's weak: Once your army already outspeeds the enemy, extra Initiative is wasted stats.

Common mistakes: Casting it on your slowest unit “to fix it” — put it on your best damage dealer to *maximize* what acting first is worth.

Campaign Verdict: (3/5) — a clean, honest tempo tool.

Energize

Mana cost: 11

3/5 · Skill Ceiling: 3/5 · Early 2/5 · Mid 3/5 · Late 4/5

Plain English: Instantly grants Focus Charges — the resource your creatures spend to use their special abilities — skipping the slow build-up they'd normally need.

The Math: No Spellpower scaling; pure resource conversion. The L2 mana discount changes its economy significantly:

Level	Focus Charges granted	Mana
L1	1	11
L2	1	8
L3	2	8
L4	3	8

In battle: Like Daylight's Song of Power, this spell's value is whatever ability it unlocks early. Concrete framing: if your creature's Focus ability is worth ~150 damage or an equivalent effect, L4 hands you up to three activations' worth of fuel for 8 mana — abilities on demand instead of abilities on schedule. It's the engine spell for ability-centric armies (Hive especially), and near-worthless for rosters that barely use Focus. Check your own army before learning it, not the enemy's.

All four levels: - **L1:** Immediately generates 1 Focus Charge. - **L2:** Mana cost drops from 11 to 8. - **L3:** Charges granted rise from 1 to 2. - **L4:** Charges granted rise from 2 to 3.

Masterful version: None documented.

Why you'd cast it: Front-loads your creatures' most powerful actions into the rounds that decide the fight.

Best heroes: Generals of Focus-hungry rosters.

When it's weak: On armies whose abilities are passive or cheap — the charges have nowhere good to go.

Common mistakes: Treating it as a generic buff — it's fuel, and fuel is only worth what the engine does with it.

Campaign Verdict: (3/5) — roster-dependent, but on the right army it's a fight-winning economy trick.

Optical Illusion

Mana cost: 8

3/5 · Skill Ceiling: 2/5 · Early 3/5 · Mid 3/5 · Late 3/5

Plain English: Makes a friendly stack much harder to hurt with arrows and other ranged attacks — the shooters can barely find it.

The Math: Duration = 1 + 1 per 4 Spellpower → ~3 rounds at Spellpower 10.

Level	Ranged damage reduction
L1	-25%
L2	-50%
L3	-50%, also covers Long Reach damage
L4	-50%, all friendly creatures

In battle: An enemy 20-Dancer stack shoots your frontline for ~120 a volley. Under L2 Optical Illusion, the same volley lands for ~60 — **halving their entire ranged game against the protected stack**, saving ~3 units of yours per enemy volley. At L4 the whole army gets it, which functionally deletes half the enemy's ranged output for the duration. It's the defensive mirror of Nightshade's Twilight: Twilight turns their shooters off; this makes your army stop caring.

All four levels: - **L1:** Target friendly creature takes -25% Ranged Damage. - **L2:** Reduction deepens to -50%. - **L3:** Also applies to Long Reach damage. - **L4:** Now affects all friendly creatures.

Masterful version: None documented.

Why you'd cast it: The cheapest counter to ranged-core enemies in the game — and ranged cores are everywhere in the current balance.

Best heroes: Melee-army generals who must cross open ground under fire.

When it's weak: Zero value against melee armies.

Common mistakes: Casting after crossing the field instead of before — the protection matters during the approach, not after contact.

Campaign Verdict: (3/5) — matchup tech that's very frequently the right matchup.

Tier 2 (available to all heroes)

Reinforcements

Mana cost: 18

2/5 · Skill Ceiling: 2/5 · Early 2/5 · Mid 3/5 · Late 2/5

Plain English: A map spell — lets your hero remotely “visit” an external creature dwelling you control (to recruit from it) without walking there.

The Math: Range = radius multiplier × hero’s Sight. Once per day (twice at L4). No combat use.

Level	Radius multiplier	Uses/day
L1	2× Sight	1
L2	3× Sight	1
L3	4× Sight	1
L4	4× Sight	2

All four levels: - **L1:** Remotely interact with any controlled external dwelling within $2 \times$ Sight squares. Once per day. - **L2:** Radius multiplier rises to $3\times$. - **L3:** Radius multiplier rises to $4\times$. - **L4:** Usable twice per day.

Masterful version: None documented.

Why you’d cast it: Recruiting from captured dwellings without spending movement — movement saved is map tempo gained.

Best heroes: Main heroes on large maps dotted with captured dwellings.

When it’s weak: On small maps or dwelling-poor starts it’s a dead pick.

Common mistakes: Valuing it before you actually control dwellings — it does nothing for dwellings you haven’t captured.

Campaign Verdict: (2/5) — real but narrow logistics value.

Energy Explosion

Mana cost: 8

3/5 · Skill Ceiling: 4/5 · Early 2/5 · Mid 3/5 · Late 4/5

Plain English: Detonates your accumulated Focus Charges as an area blast — the more charges you’ve banked, the bigger the boom.

The Math: Damage = rate × Focus Charges, hitting all creatures in a 1-hex radius. No Spellpower scaling — this spell scales with your *Focus economy* instead.

Level	Damage per Focus Charge
L1	30
L2	40
L3	55
L4	75

In battle: With 4 banked charges, L4 deals 300 area damage — nearly wiping a 360-HP Dancer-class stack *and* splashing everything adjacent, for 8 mana. The catch is the same as the payoff: your charges are the ammunition, so this spell competes with your creatures' own abilities for the same resource. Pair it with Energize (above) and Arcane suddenly has a self-contained damage engine: 8 mana buys 3 charges, 8 more detonates them for 225.

All four levels: - **L1:** Deals 30 Magic Damage per Focus Charge to all creatures in a 1-hex radius. - **L2:** Rate rises to 40 per charge. - **L3:** Rate rises to 55 per charge. - **L4:** Rate rises to 75 per charge.

Masterful version: None documented.

Why you'd cast it: Converts a stockpiled resource into burst area damage on your timing.

Best heroes: Focus-economy builds; pairs natively with Energize.

When it's weak: With an empty Focus bank it deals nothing — this is a payoff card that needs a setup.

Common mistakes: Detonating early with 1–2 charges out of impatience; the per-charge rate rewards saving up.

Campaign Verdict: **(3/5)** — a genuine combo engine for players willing to build around it.

Blink

Mana cost: 10

4/5 · Skill Ceiling: 4/5 · Early 3/5 · Mid 4/5 · Late 4/5

Plain English: Teleports one of your stacks across the battlefield instantly — no walking, no terrain, no interception.

The Math: Pure range scaling:

Level	Teleport range
L1	4 hexes
L2	6 hexes
L3	9 hexes
L4	13 hexes

In battle: Your 20 Dancers are melee-locked by an enemy stack (remember: their ranged attack halves in melee, ~60 instead of ~120). Blink them 4+ hexes away and they're shooting at full power

again — **+60 damage per volley recovered** for 10 mana. Offensively, it's the reverse: Blink a slow bruiser 13 hexes into the enemy backline and their shooters are the ones melee-locked now. The skill ceiling comes from how many problems repositioning quietly solves: escaping Taunt range, dodging Firewall hexes, jumping castle walls in sieges.

All four levels: - **L1:** Teleports a target friendly creature up to 4 hexes. - **L2:** Range rises to 6 hexes. - **L3:** Range rises to 9 hexes. - **L4:** Range rises to 13 hexes.

Masterful version: This version can target **enemy creatures** — forcibly teleporting *their* stack wherever you want it. **Hero:** not yet identified in available sourcing. (Note the ceiling on that: dragging an enemy shooter into your melee, or their tank away from what it protects, is a control effect most Tier 4+ spells can't match.)

Why you'd cast it: Position is the hidden stat of every battle; Blink is direct control over it.

Best heroes: Tactically fluent players; near-wasted on autopilot.

When it's weak: In stale, static fights where nobody's position matters — rare, but they exist.

Common mistakes: Using it as a panic escape only — proactive offensive Blinks (delivering a hitter, unlocking a shooter) are usually worth more.

Campaign Verdict: (4/5) — the school's identity in one spell; its Masterful version may be the strongest unlisted-hero effect in the game.

Carapace

Mana cost: 14

4/5 · Skill Ceiling: 2/5 · Early 3/5 · Mid 4/5 · Late 4/5

Plain English: Wraps a friendly stack in a barrier that completely nullifies the next hit it takes — not reduces, *nullifies*.

The Math: Duration = 1 + 1 per 5 Spellpower → 3 rounds at Spellpower 10. The blocked amount equals whatever the enemy swings — which is the trick.

Level	Effect	Mana
L1	Blocks the next instance of damage	14
L2	Same	11
L3	Base duration 1 → 2 rounds	11
L4	Blocks damage twice	11

In battle: The barrier is worth exactly what it eats. Block a 120 enemy volley and you saved ~7 Dancers; block a tier-7 dragon's 400-damage swing and one 11-mana cast just absorbed more damage than Radiant Armour saves across an entire fight. That's the play pattern: Carapace before the *biggest single hit* you can see coming, never before chip damage. At L4 (two blocks), putting it on a Taunting tank lets the tank eat the enemy's two hardest hits for free — the best defensive two-card combo in Arcane.

All four levels: - **L1:** Shields the target with a barrier that blocks the next instance of damage. - **L2:** Mana cost drops from 14 to 11. - **L3:** Base duration rises from 1 to 2 rounds. - **L4:** The barrier blocks damage twice.

Masterful version: The target also becomes **immune to negative effects and dispel**. **Hero:** not yet identified in available sourcing.

Why you'd cast it: The most efficient answer to big single hits in the game — flat immunity, scaled by the enemy's own strength.

Best heroes: Anyone facing giant single attackers or alpha-strike enemies.

When it's weak: Against many small attacks — one blocked 30-damage poke wastes the whole cast.

Common mistakes: Casting it into chip damage. Save it for the hit that matters.

Campaign Verdict: (4/5) — deceptively simple, brutally efficient when timed right.

Tier 3 (requires Basic Arcane Magic)

Assemble!

Mana cost: 12

3/5 · Skill Ceiling: 3/5 · Early 2/5 · Mid 4/5 · Late 3/5

Plain English: A map spell — your hero remotely “meets” another of your heroes at a distance, letting you swap troops and items without either walking to the other.

The Math: Range = multiplier × Sight; once per day base.

Level	Radius multiplier	Uses/day
L1	1× Sight	1
L2	2× Sight	1
L3	2× Sight	2
L4	3× Sight	2

All four levels: - **L1:** Remotely interact with any allied hero within 1 × Sight squares. Once per day. - **L2:** Multiplier rises to 2×. - **L3:** Usable twice per day. - **L4:** Multiplier rises to 3×.

Masterful version: None documented.

Why you'd cast it: This is hero-chaining without the chain — a courier hero can hand fresh troops to your main from squares away, which on big maps saves entire days of marching.

Best heroes: Multi-hero economies; the backbone spell of an advanced reinforcement pipeline.

When it's weak: Single-hero play modes make it literally uncastable value.

Common mistakes: Overlooking it entirely — its tooltip reads like admin, but the tempo it buys in mid-game reinforcement is real.

Campaign Verdict: (3/5) — a logistics multiplier that rates higher the more heroes you run.

Temporal Spheres

Mana cost: 9

3/5 · Skill Ceiling: 4/5 · Early 2/5 · Mid 3/5 · Late 4/5

Plain English: Plants invisible mines on the battlefield. A ground unit that steps on one takes an explosion scaled to *its own* max HP, splashing its neighbors too.

The Math: Trap damage = $(100\% + 5\% \times \text{Spellpower})$ of one unit's max HP — at Spellpower 10, **150% of a unit's max HP** per trap, as Pure Damage. Duration = 1 + 1 per 5 Spellpower (3 rounds).

Level	Traps	Damage (at SP 10)
L1	2	150% of one unit's max HP
L2	2	250%
L3	3	250%
L4	3	450%

In battle: Against approaching Dancer-class units (18 HP), an L2 trap deals 45 Pure Damage — 2–3 units per trigger, plus splash. But like Guillotine, the percentage scaling means traps get scarier against big creatures: an L4 trap under a 300-HP tier-7's path deals **1,350 Pure Damage** — instantly lethal to most single high-tier units. The skill expression is prediction: traps only trigger on hexes the enemy actually walks through, so they're a bet on reading movement paths. Combine with Web or Crystal Crown-style obstacles to *force* the path you mined.

All four levels: - **L1:** Place up to 2 invisible traps on free hexes; each triggers on a ground creature, dealing $(100\% + 5\% \times \text{Spellpower})$ of one unit's max HP as Pure Damage to it and adjacent creatures. - **L2:** Percentage rises from 100% to 200% base. - **L3:** Traps rise from 2 to 3. - **L4:** Percentage rises from 200% to 400% base.

Masterful version: None documented.

Why you'd cast it: Area denial plus percentage damage — a mined battlefield fights for you.

Best heroes: Defensive players and path-readers; excellent in sieges and chokepoints.

When it's weak: Against flyers and teleporters who never touch the ground.

Common mistakes: Mining random hexes instead of the *only* path to your shooters.

Campaign Verdict: (3/5) — high ceiling, honest prerequisite: you must be able to predict movement.

Shackles

Mana cost: 9

3/5 · Skill Ceiling: 2/5 · Early 3/5 · Mid 3/5 · Late 3/5

Plain English: Chains an enemy stack so it can't counterattack at all — your melee hits it for free.

The Math: Duration = 1 + 1 per 6 Spellpower → ~2 rounds at Spellpower 10.

Level	Effect	Base duration
L1	Target cannot counterattack	1 round
L2	Same	2 rounds
L3	+ dispels "Riposte"	2 rounds
L4	+ affects enemies adjacent to target	2 rounds

In battle: Functionally the Tier 3 big sibling of Daylight's Weakening Ray: attacking a Dancer-class stack in melee normally costs you a ~120 counterattack (6–7 of your own units). Shackled, that cost is zero — for two full rounds, against the target *and* (at L4) its neighbors. The L3 Riposte-dispel matters in caster duels: an enemy running the Daylight defensive-turtle package (Riposte + Vengeance) loses half of it to one 9-mana cast.

All four levels: - **L1:** Target enemy creature cannot counterattack. - **L2:** Base duration rises from 1 to 2 rounds. - **L3:** Also dispels "Riposte." - **L4:** Also affects enemy creatures adjacent to the target.

Masterful version: None documented.

Why you'd cast it: Free melee engagements on demand — the enabling spell for aggressive melee armies.

Best heroes: Melee-core generals; the counterattack tax is their biggest hidden cost.

When it's weak: Against ranged enemies who never counterattack anyway.

Common mistakes: Casting after your units have already traded — it's a *before-the-charge* spell.

Campaign Verdict: (3/5) — unglamorous, consistently useful for the armies it serves.

Impending Fate

Mana cost: 13

3/5 · Skill Ceiling: 2/5 · Early 2/5 · Mid 3/5 · Late 3/5

Plain English: Damages *every* enemy stack at once, with each stack taking damage proportional to its creature tier — the fancier the unit, the harder it's hit.

The Math: Damage = rate × the stack's creature tier, per stack. No Spellpower scaling.

Level	Damage per tier	Example: vs. a T3 / T7 stack
L1	20	60 / 140
L2	25	75 / 175
L3	35	105 / 245
L4	35, as Pure Damage	105 / 245, ignoring defenses

In battle: Against a typical six-stack enemy army (tiers 1–7 represented), one L3 cast lands ~500–700 total damage spread across the whole board for 13 mana — with the *biggest* chunks landing on their *best* units. Against a T7 stack specifically, 245 Pure Damage at L4 is close to Umbral Grip damage, delivered as a side effect of hitting everything else too. It won’t kill anything outright, but as a softening pass before Coup de Grâce-style finishers or a general army-wide attrition tool, the mana efficiency is quietly excellent.

All four levels: - **L1:** All enemy stacks take 20 Magic Damage per their creature tier. - **L2:** Rate rises to 25 per tier. - **L3:** Rate rises to 35 per tier. - **L4:** The damage becomes Pure Damage.

Masterful version: None documented.

Why you’d cast it: Whole-board chip damage that automatically prioritizes the enemy’s most valuable stacks.

Best heroes: Attrition casters and anyone setting up threshold-execution finishers.

When it’s weak: Against low-tier swarm armies, the per-tier scaling bottoms out.

Common mistakes: Expecting it to kill — it’s a softener, and it’s excellent at exactly that.

Campaign Verdict: (3/5) — the best “hit everything” button below Tier 5.

Tier 4 (requires Advanced Arcane Magic)

Mirror Copy

Mana cost: 24

4/5 · Skill Ceiling: 4/5 · Early 1/5 · Mid 3/5 · Late 4/5

Plain English: Conjures a duplicate of one of your stacks. The copy is fragile and hits soft — but it’s a whole extra stack, and every hit it absorbs is one your real army doesn’t.

The Math: The copy’s penalties shrink dramatically with level — that’s where all the scaling lives. Duration = 1 + 1 per 7 Spellpower (~2 rounds at Spellpower 10).

Level	Copy’s damage dealt	Copy’s damage taken
L1	-75%	+300%
L2	-67%	+200%
L3	-50%	+100%
L4	-30%	+50%

In battle: Copy your 20 Dancers at L1 and the clone volleys for a feeble ~30 — but it still *looks* like a threat, still soaks a targeted attack, still bodies a hex. At L4, the same copy volleys ~84 and takes only +50% damage: it’s now roughly two-thirds of a real second Dancer stack, from one cast. Compare with Nightshade’s Shadow Army (+40% units inside the real stack): Shadow Army strengthens one stack; Mirror Copy creates a second *position* on the board — a second flank, a second Taunt target, a second thing the enemy must answer.

All four levels: - **L1:** Summons a copy of a target friendly creature dealing -75% and taking +300% damage; it can’t use special abilities. - **L2:** Penalties ease to -67% dealt / +200% taken. - **L3:** Penalties ease to -50% / +100%. - **L4:** Penalties ease to -30% / +50%.

Masterful version: This version can target **enemy creatures** — cloning *their* best stack to fight for you. **Hero: Vatawna** (Grove) starts with Masterful Mirror Copy as her specialization (“Murmuring Copy”), with +1 effective Spellpower for this spell per 3 hero levels — confirmed against hero sourcing.

Why you’d cast it: A second body on the board is a second problem for the enemy — and Vatawna’s version steals *their* answer to it.

Best heroes: Vatawna, definitively; otherwise late-game Arcane specialists who’ve leveled the spell past its miserable L1 stats.

When it’s weak: At L1, honestly — the -75%/+300% copy is nearly decorative. This spell *needs* levels.

Common mistakes: Judging it by its L1 numbers and never coming back.

Campaign Verdict: (4/5) — the widest L1-to-L4 power gap of any spell in the book; plan around the leveled version.

Rewind Life

Mana cost: 17

5/5 · Skill Ceiling: 2/5 · Early 2/5 · Mid 4/5 · Late 5/5

Plain English: The game’s true resurrection — heals a friendly stack *and brings its dead back to life*, permanently. What Healing Water can’t do, this does.

The Math: Restoration = 50 + (rate × Spellpower):

Level	Formula	Result at SP 10
L1	50 + 20×SP	250 HP (revives dead)
L2	100 + 20×SP	300 HP
L3	100 + 25×SP	350 HP
L4	100 + 35×SP	450 HP

In battle: The number that changes everything: dead units count. L1’s 250 HP revives **13–14 fallen Dancers (18 HP each)** — units that were *gone*, worth 160 gold apiece, walking again for 17 mana. Frame it economically: one L1 cast is worth ~2,200 gold of un-lost army. At L4 (450

HP), a single cast resurrects an entire wiped 20-stack with room to spare. This is the single biggest reason campaign players learn Arcane: fights stop costing you units, which means every fight you win makes you *stronger* instead of merely less weak.

All four levels: - **L1:** Restores $50 + (20 \times \text{Spellpower})$ HP to a target friendly creature. Can revive fallen units. - **L2:** Base restoration rises from 50 to 100. - **L3:** Per-Spellpower rate rises from 20 to 25. - **L4:** Per-Spellpower rate rises from 25 to 35.

Masterful version: This version can revive units **beyond their original amount** — the stack can come out of the fight *bigger* than it went in. **Hero: Lord Rufus** (Necromancer, Necropolis) starts with Masterful Rewind Life as his specialization (“Wistful Nostalgia”), with +1 effective Spellpower for this spell per 2 hero levels — confirmed against the official master hero table, which *corrected* this book’s earlier attribution to Mag (Mag’s actual specialty is Arcane school-mastery: +1 level to all Arcane spells, and the enemy hero cannot cast Arcane — a different, equally elite reason to pick him). The Rufus pairing is thematically perfect and mechanically absurd: a Necropolis hero whose signature spell farms *growth* out of battles.

Why you’d cast it: Zero-loss play is the strongest campaign strategy in the genre; this is its cornerstone spell.

Best heroes: Everyone who can learn it; Lord Rufus turns it into an army printer — and Mag (the Arcane school-master) casts it a level higher than anyone without the Masterful version.

When it’s weak: Genuinely almost never — 17 mana is cheap for what it does at every stage it’s available.

Common mistakes: Casting mid-fight on a lightly-wounded stack instead of end-of-fight on the most-dead one — revival value is maximized when there are the most dead to revive.

Campaign Verdict: (5/5) — the best campaign spell in the Arcane school, and a top-three spell in the game for single-player.

Spatial Snare

Mana cost: 10

3/5 · Skill Ceiling: 4/5 · Early 2/5 · Mid 3/5 · Late 3/5

Plain English: Invisible tripwires — a unit that *moves through* one is stopped dead, loses the rest of this turn, and loses its next turn too. Doesn’t trigger if the trapped hex was the unit’s final destination.

The Math: No damage — the currency is stolen turns. Duration = $1 + 1$ per 7 Spellpower (~2 rounds at Spellpower 10).

Level	Traps	Mana
L1	2	10
L2	2	5
L3	3	5
L4	4	5

In battle: One triggered snare costs the enemy a stack's current turn *and* its next — against a Dancer-class stack, that's ~240 damage (two volleys) that never happens, for 5 mana at L2. Four snares at L4 can theoretically delete eight enemy stack-turns. The fine print is the skill test: the trap only fires on *pass-through*, not arrival — so it punishes units charging past toward your backline, and does nothing to cautious short moves. Best laid on the long lanes toward your shooters, exactly where fast enemy stacks must sprint.

All four levels: - **L1:** Place up to 2 invisible traps on free hexes; a ground creature moving *through* one halts, ends its turn, and loses its next turn. Doesn't trigger on final-destination hexes. - **L2:** Mana cost drops from 10 to 5. - **L3:** Traps rise to 3. - **L4:** Traps rise to 4.

Masterful version: None documented.

Why you'd cast it: The cheapest turn-theft in the game — one trigger out-values most direct damage at this price.

Best heroes: The same path-readers who love Temporal Spheres; the two mine sets stack beautifully.

When it's weak: Flyers, teleporters, and slow careful movers all sidestep the trigger condition.

Common mistakes: Trapping the hex the enemy will *stop* on — the one placement that never fires.

Campaign Verdict: (3/5) — a chess player's spell; the rating climbs with the player.

Tier 5 (requires Expert Arcane Magic)

Black Hole

Mana cost: 30

4/5 · Skill Ceiling: 3/5 · Early 1/5 · Mid 2/5 · Late 5/5

Plain English: Tears open a vortex that damages everything in a wide area — and drags the stragglers *toward the center*, bunching the enemy up.

The Math: Damage = base + 15–20 × Spellpower, over a 2-hex-radius area (a five-hex-wide zone):

Level	Formula	Result at SP 10
L1	80 + 15×SP	230 to everything in the zone
L2	120 + 15×SP	270
L3	200 + 15×SP	350
L4	200 + 20×SP	400

In battle: Catch three enemy stacks in the zone at L3 and one cast deals ~1,050 total damage — nearly triple what Judgement's single-target 500 delivers, for 5 fewer mana. And the pull is a second spell hiding inside the first: dragging scattered enemies into a tight cluster is the *setup* for

Berserk, Fireball, Circle of Winter, or your own melee sweep. Cast Black Hole, then punish the pile it made.

All four levels: - **L1:** Deals $80 + (15 \times \text{Spellpower})$ Magic Damage to all creatures on the target hex and up to 2 hexes away; pulls the furthest targets toward the center. - **L2:** Base damage rises from 80 to 120. - **L3:** Base damage rises from 120 to 200. - **L4:** Per-Spellpower rate rises from 15 to 20.

Masterful version: None documented.

Why you'd cast it: The biggest area damage in Arcane, with built-in crowd control that feeds every clustering combo you own.

Best heroes: Late-game Arcane nukers; anyone running Berserk/Fireball follow-ups.

When it's weak: Against spread formations that keep only one stack in any 2-hex zone.

Common mistakes: Treating the pull as flavor — the repositioning is often worth more than the damage.

Campaign Verdict: (4/5) — a nuke and a combo-enabler in one slot.

Doreath's Tide

Mana cost: 23

3/5 · Skill Ceiling: 3/5 · Early 1/5 · Mid 2/5 · Late 4/5

Plain English: Tilts the whole battle's tempo at once — your entire army speeds up while the entire enemy army slows down.

The Math: ± 1 Speed and Initiative to every creature on each side. Duration = $1 + 1$ per 8 Spellpower (~2 rounds at Spellpower 10).

Level	Effect	Mana
L1	Allies +1 Spd/Init, enemies -1 Spd/Init	23
L2	Base duration $1 \rightarrow 2$	23
L3	Same	19
L4	+ strips movement debuffs from allies and movement buffs from enemies	19

In battle: A ± 1 swing looks small until you count it army-wide: six of your stacks acting slightly earlier while six of theirs act slightly later routinely flips two or three head-to-head initiative contests per round — each flip meaning one of your volleys (~120) lands before theirs instead of after. The L4 cleanse clause is the sleeper: it's a one-cast answer to an enemy's entire Haste/Web investment, in both directions simultaneously.

All four levels: - **L1:** All friendly creatures gain 1 Speed and Initiative; all enemies lose 1 of each. - **L2:** Base duration rises from 1 to 2 rounds. - **L3:** Mana cost drops from 23 to 19. - **L4:** Dispel movement-restricting effects from allies and movement-enhancing effects from enemies.

Masterful version: None documented.

Why you'd cast it: Whole-battle tempo control in one button — the macro version of every speed spell in the book.

Best heroes: Large-army generals where the per-stack swing multiplies widest.

When it's weak: Small skirmishes where ± 1 across three stacks moves nothing.

Common mistakes: Undervaluing the L4 double-cleanse — against speed-manipulation casters it's the whole reason to cast.

Campaign Verdict: (3/5) — subtle, scaling, and better the bigger the battle.

Reality Distortion

Mana cost: 21

4/5 · Skill Ceiling: 5/5 · Early 1/5 · Mid 2/5 · Late 4/5

Plain English: The strangest spell in the game: the target takes *no damage at all* right now — instead, everything it would have taken this round is delivered next round, all at once, as unblockable Pure Damage. A damage time-machine.

The Math: Duration = 1 + 1 per 8 Spellpower (~2 rounds). The deferred damage is reduced by a percentage at higher levels — which is where it turns from a delay into genuine mitigation:

Level	Deferred damage reduction	Base duration
L1	0% (full damage, one round late)	1
L2	-21%	1
L3	-21%	3
L4	-41%	3

In battle: Cast on your own stack: this round's incoming ~240 (two enemy volleys) simply doesn't land — your Dancers fight the whole round at full 20-unit strength, dealing full damage, and only pay (a 41%-discounted 142 at L4) next round. You've bought a full-strength round *and* mitigated a third of the bill. Cast on an *enemy* stack the logic inverts deviously: they take nothing now, so your army can pile unlimited damage into them this round — and next round the entire accumulated total lands at once as Pure Damage, past every defense they have. The 5/5 skill ceiling is earned: both modes are strong, and choosing the wrong one actively helps your opponent.

All four levels: - **L1:** Target takes no damage from any source; at the start of each round it takes all damage from the previous round as Pure Damage. - **L2:** Deferred damage is reduced by 21%. - **L3:** Base duration rises from 1 to 3 rounds. - **L4:** Reduction deepens from 21% to 41%.

Masterful version: None documented.

Why you'd cast it: Time-shifting damage breaks the normal math of trading — in either direction, in expert hands.

Best heroes: The most experienced casters you know. Genuinely.

When it's weak: In simple fights, it's an expensive way to complicate something you were already winning.

Common mistakes: Forgetting the bill comes due — a “protected” stack that ends the duration at low HP can be one-shot by its own deferred total.

Campaign Verdict: (4/5) — the highest-skill spell in this book; a full star of its rating lives behind that ceiling.

Confirmed Masterful spell / hero pairings (this school)

Spell	Masterful effect	Hero	Status
Mirror Copy	Can target enemy creatures	Vatawna (Grove)	Confirmed
Rewind Life	Revives units beyond original amount	Lord Rufus (Necropolis, Necromancer)	Confirmed (corrected from Mag — Mag is the Arcane school-master)
Guillotine	Recast damage stacks twice as fast	Old Pilgrim (Grove, Warden)	Confirmed (“Natural Selection”)
Early Start	Cannot be dispelled	<i>unknown</i>	Hero not identified
Blink	Can target enemy creatures	<i>unknown</i>	Hero not identified
Carapace	Target immune to negative effects & dispel	<i>unknown</i>	Hero not identified

Synergy notes

- **Energize → Energy Explosion:** Arcane’s self-contained damage engine — 16 mana total for a 225-damage area blast on demand.
- **Black Hole → anything area:** the pull manufactures the clusters that Fireball, Berserk, and Circle of Winter want to punish.
- **Web/obstacles → Temporal Spheres/Spatial Snare:** movement control plus movement punishment; force the lane, then mine it.
- **Taunt (Daylight) → Carapace L4:** the tank draws the enemy’s two biggest hits, the barrier eats both for free.
- **Rewind Life as the campaign keystone:** every school’s aggressive spells get better when your losses are reversible — this one spell changes how recklessly you can afford to fight.

Common beginner mistakes (school-wide)

- Judging leveling-dependent spells (Mirror Copy above all) by their L1 stats.
- Using Blink only defensively — its offensive deliveries are usually worth more.
- Detonating Energy Explosion with a near-empty Focus bank.
- Forgetting Reality Distortion's deferred bill exists.
- Skipping Rewind Life because “healing is boring” — it is the single most campaign-warping spell in this school.

Sourcing note: all mechanics, mana costs, formulas, per-level effects, and Masterful texts taken directly from the official wiki's Arcane Spells table (retrieved 2026-07-03). Vatawna→Mirror Copy, Lord Rufus→Rewind Life (corrected from Mag via the official master hero table), and Old Pilgrim→Guillotine confirmed against official hero sourcing; Early Start, Blink, and Carapace owners remain open gaps, logged in the audit. All worked math, battle examples (reference stack: 20 Onyx Dancers), ratings, synergies, and verdicts are original analysis.

Daylight Magic

Founded by the scholar Arina. Focuses on bestowing positive effects on allied creatures and punishing enemies for attacking them — the game’s “buff” school, though a couple of spells are straight-up damage tools.

How to read each entry

1. **Plain English** — what the spell does, no jargon.
2. **The Math** — the exact formula, with worked numbers at every level so you can see the scaling itself, not just the base case.
3. **All four levels**, spelled out in full — not deltas.
4. **Masterful version** — a fifth, strongest tier that isn’t leveled into. It’s granted permanently to one specific unique hero as their personal specialization. Sourced directly from the official wiki’s **Heroes** page and each hero’s own page.
5. **Strategy layer** — why you’d cast it, best heroes/factions, when it’s weak, common mistakes, verdict. Original analysis.

On “Spellpower”: most formulas scale with your hero’s Spellpower stat, which grows through levels, artifacts, and skills. Every worked example below uses **Spellpower 10** as a fixed reference point so the numbers are comparable spell-to-spell — swap in your own hero’s Spellpower to get your real numbers. Where a spell has a Masterful version, note that the specialist hero who owns it also gets a personal **effective Spellpower bonus specifically for that spell** (e.g. “+1 effective Spellpower for every 2 hero levels”) — this stacks on top of their normal Spellpower stat and is *why* their Masterful cast hits harder than the same spell cast by anyone else, even before accounting for the Masterful effect itself.

On the battle examples: every combat spell’s math section ends with an **In battle** line showing the spell’s real impact on an actual fight. To keep these comparable, they all use the same reference army: a stack of **20 Onyx Dancers** (a real Dungeon Tier 3 ranged unit: 18 HP each, 5–7 damage each). Twenty of them deal 100–140 damage per attack — call it **120 on an average swing**. One simplification to be aware of: real damage is further modified by the attacker’s Attack stat vs. the defender’s Defense stat, which these examples ignore so the spell’s own contribution stays visible. The *relative* gain from each spell is accurate; your absolute numbers in-game will differ.

Tier 1 (available to every hero, no skill required)

Blessing

Mana cost: 8

3/5 · Skill Ceiling: 1/5 · Early 4/5 · Mid 2/5 · Late 1/5

Plain English: Makes one friendly stack hit harder with its regular attacks for a few rounds.

The Math: Damage bonus is a flat percentage on basic attacks. Duration = 1 + 1 round per 2 Spellpower. Worked at Spellpower 10:

Level	Damage bonus	Duration at SP 10
L1	+10%	1 + (10÷2) = 6 rounds
L2	+15%	6 rounds
L3	+15% (now hits your whole army)	6 rounds
L4	+25%	6 rounds

In battle: Your 20 Onyx Dancers swing for ~120 damage unbuffed. With Blessing L1 (+10%), the same swing deals ~132 — **+12 damage per attack**. At L4 (+25%), it's ~150 — **+30 per attack**, and over the full 6-round duration that's up to +180 total damage from one 8-mana cast. The Masterful version works differently: instead of a percentage, it locks every swing at the maximum roll — the 20-dancer stack always deals 140 instead of averaging 120, a guaranteed **+20 per attack** with zero variance, which matters most when you need to guarantee a kill this turn.

All four levels: - **L1:** Target friendly creature deals +10% damage with basic attacks. - **L2:** Bonus rises to +15%. - **L3:** Now affects **all friendly creatures** at once (still +15% each). - **L4:** Bonus rises to +25%, still hitting your whole army.

Masterful version: Target always deals its **maximum possible damage** — removes damage-roll randomness entirely. **Hero: Vesper** (Cleric, Temple) starts with Masterful Blessing as her personal specialization. Casting it, her effective Spellpower for this spell is increased by +1 for every 2 hero levels — so at hero level 10, she's effectively casting Blessing at +5 Spellpower above her stat line.

Why you'd cast it: Cheapest damage buff in the game — cast on your hardest-hitting stack before a fight you expect to win comfortably.

Best heroes: Any early-game hero; Vesper specifically removes damage variance entirely, which matters for reliably one-rounding weak neutrals.

When it's weak: Late game, where 10–25% of one stack's damage is a rounding error against Tier VI–VII creatures.

Common mistakes: Casting on a support stack instead of your actual damage dealer.

Campaign Verdict: (3/5) — a reliable early-game workhorse that fades as army damage output dwarfs an 8-mana buff.

Haste

Mana cost: 9

4/5 · Skill Ceiling: 2/5 · Early 4/5 · Mid 4/5 · Late 3/5

Plain English: Makes a friendly stack faster, so it acts earlier in the round and can cross more of the battlefield before attacking.

The Math: Duration = 1 + 1 round per 2 Spellpower (same as Blessing: 6 rounds at Spellpower 10). The Speed bonus itself scales with spell level, not Spellpower:

Level	Speed bonus	Extra effect
L1	+2 Speed	—
L2	+3 Speed	—
L3	+3 Speed	dispels Web debuff on target
L4	+4 Speed	keeps Web-dispel

In battle: The Onyx Dancer’s base Speed is 2 — one of the slower stats on the roster. Haste L1 doubles it to 4; L4 takes it to 6, **triple its normal movement range**. In practice that’s the difference between a melee-mode Dancer stack needing two full turns to reach an enemy shooter (eating a round of free ranged fire on the way) and reaching it turn one. For a spell whose value is positional rather than numerical, the math to check is simple: enemy distance in hexes vs. your Speed — if Haste closes that gap a full turn earlier, it just saved you one round of incoming damage, which for our reference stack means ~120+ damage prevented.

All four levels: - **L1:** +2 Speed to target friendly creature. - **L2:** Speed bonus rises to +3. - **L3:** Still +3 Speed, and now also dispels the Web debuff on the target if present. - **L4:** Speed bonus rises to +4, keeping the Web-dispel.

Masterful version: Affects **all friendly creatures**, not just one. **Hero: Mila** (Herald, Hive) starts with Masterful Haste as her personal specialization (“Wingflap”). Her effective Spellpower for this spell increases by +1 for every 2 hero levels — at hero level 10 that’s +5 effective Spellpower on top of her stat line, on a spell that already hits her whole army.

Why you’d cast it: Speed determines turn order and how far a melee stack can move-and-attack — Haste can mean reaching the enemy backline this round instead of eating a free round of ranged fire first.

Best heroes: Might-leaning heroes running melee-heavy armies; Mila specifically if you want the full-army version from Turn 1.

When it’s weak: Armies already faster than the enemy don’t need it.

Common mistakes: Casting reactively instead of pre-combat when scouting already told you your Speed disadvantage.

Campaign Verdict: (4/5) — one of the best Tier 1 spells for melee-forward compositions, and build-defining if you’re playing Mila.

From a Bird's Eye

Mana cost: 10

2/5 · Skill Ceiling: 1/5 · Early 3/5 · Mid 2/5 · Late 1/5

Plain English: A map-reading spell, not a combat spell — lifts fog of war so you can see terrain and, at higher levels, enemy positions.

The Math: No Spellpower scaling — each level unlocks a flatly better version. The only number that moves is the spell's own mana cost.

Level	Effect	Mana cost
L1	Reveals area borders through fog of war	10
L2	Same reveal	6 (discounted)
L3	+ reveals all enemy hero locations	6
L4	+ reveals all city locations	6

All four levels: - **L1:** Reveals the borders of all areas, including fogged ones. - **L2:** Same effect; mana cost drops from 10 to 6. - **L3:** Also reveals the location of all enemy heroes on the map. - **L4:** Also reveals the location of all cities on the map.

Masterful version: None documented in current sourcing. **Hero:** Clarissa (Cleric, Temple) starts with this spell in her spellbook as part of her “Wealthy” specialization, but her specialty bonus is Gold income, not a Masterful upgrade to this specific spell — so treat her as a hero who *has* the spell early, not as its Masterful owner.

Why you'd cast it: Early-game map intelligence — knowing where rival heroes are lets you avoid bad fights or time an attack on an under-defended town.

Best heroes: Scouting-oriented secondary heroes rather than your main combat hero.

When it's weak: Once you've scouted manually, this becomes a redundant mana sink.

Common mistakes: Treating it as a combat spell — zero battle application.

Campaign Verdict: (2/5) — genuinely useful once, especially at L3/L4, but low priority for a main war hero.

Healing Water

Mana cost: 6

4/5 · Skill Ceiling: 2/5 · Early 4/5 · Mid 4/5 · Late 3/5

Plain English: Heals HP onto a friendly stack. Can't revive units that have already died — only tops up a stack that's still alive but wounded.

The Math: $\text{Heal} = 25 + (\text{rate} \times \text{Spellpower})$. The rate itself doubles at L2, which is a much bigger jump than the flat +5 the formula shape suggests. Worked at Spellpower 10:

Level	Formula	Result at SP 10
L1	$25 + 5 \times \text{SP}$	$25 + 50 = \mathbf{75 \text{ HP}}$
L2	$25 + 10 \times \text{SP}$	$25 + 100 = \mathbf{125 \text{ HP}}$
L3	Same as L2, but triggers again next round	250 HP total across 2 rounds
L4	Same, hits all friendly creatures	$125 \text{ HP} \times \text{army size}$, twice

In battle: Each Onyx Dancer has 18 HP, so the L1 heal (75 HP at Spellpower 10) restores just over **4 dancers' worth of health** to a wounded stack — for 6 mana. At L2 (125 HP), that's nearly **7 dancers' worth**, and L3's double-trigger makes it ~14 across two rounds. Framed against the enemy: if the opposing army deals ~120 damage per round to your Dancer stack, an L2 Healing Water undoes about a full round of their damage output for one of the cheapest casts in the game. That exchange rate — 6 mana to erase a round of enemy work — is the whole reason this spell stays relevant deep into the mid-game.

All four levels: - **L1:** Restores $25 + (5 \times \text{Spellpower})$ HP to one friendly creature. Does not revive fully-dead units. - **L2:** Healing rate improves to $25 + (10 \times \text{Spellpower})$ HP. - **L3:** The heal triggers a second time automatically at the start of the next round. - **L4:** Now affects all friendly creatures at once (each still healing twice, per L3).

Masterful version: Dispers **all negative effects** from friendly creatures in addition to healing. **Hero: Julius** (Cleric, Temple) starts with Masterful Healing Water as his personal specialization ("Compassionate Healer"). His effective Spellpower for this spell increases by +1 for every 2 hero levels — at hero level 10, that's +5 effective Spellpower, meaning his L1-equivalent heal is already worth $25 + 5 \times 15 = 100$ HP before any other investment.

Why you'd cast it: Cheapest sustain in the game at 6 mana — keeping a frontline stack alive another round often matters more than any single damage spell.

Best heroes: Any hero fighting attrition-style neutrals; Julius specifically for the built-in cleanse.

When it's weak: Against burst damage that kills a stack outright — can't heal what's already fully dead.

Common mistakes: Waiting until a stack is critically low instead of healing proactively.

Campaign Verdict: (4/5) — stays useful well into the mid-game specifically because it's so cheap.

Tier 2 (available to all heroes)

Favorable Wind

Mana cost: 12

3/5 · Skill Ceiling: 2/5 · Early 2/5 · Mid 4/5 · Late 3/5

Plain English: The ranged-army version of Blessing — boosts a stack’s damage, but only for Ranged and Long Reach attacks.

The Math: No Spellpower scaling on the bonus itself; duration = 1 + 1 round per 3 Spellpower (about 4 rounds at Spellpower 10).

Level	Damage bonus
L1	+15%
L2	+20%
L3	+30%
L4	+40%

In battle: Onyx Dancers are exactly the kind of unit this spell exists for — they’re ranged. The 20-dancer stack’s ~120-damage volley becomes ~138 at L1 (+18), and ~168 at L4 (**+48 per volley**). Compare that directly against Blessing on the same stack: Favorable Wind L1 (+15%) already beats Blessing L1 (+10%), and its L4 (+40%) beats Blessing’s L4 (+25%) by a wide margin — the catch being it does nothing at all if the Dancers get forced into melee. Same stack, same fight: which of the two buffs is better depends entirely on whether you can keep the enemy at range.

All four levels: - **L1:** +15% damage with Ranged and Long Reach attacks. - **L2:** Bonus rises to +20%. - **L3:** Bonus rises to +30%. - **L4:** Bonus rises to +40%.

Masterful version: None documented in current sourcing.

Why you’d cast it: Cast on your primary ranged damage dealer before a fight where you expect to control the range advantage.

Best heroes: Heroes running ranged-core compositions.

When it’s weak: Useless on melee-only armies.

Common mistakes: Confusing with Blessing and casting on a melee unit.

Campaign Verdict: (3/5) — excellent on the right army, dead weight on the wrong one.

Weakening Ray

Mana cost: 10

3/5 · Skill Ceiling: 2/5 · Early 3/5 · Mid 3/5 · Late 2/5

Plain English: Strips a target enemy’s ability to counterattack you back when you hit it.

The Math: No Spellpower scaling; each level is categorically stronger rather than numerically bigger.

Level	Effect	Mana cost
L1	Removes 1 counterattack charge	10
L2	Same	7 (discounted)
L3	Removes all counterattack charges	7

Level	Effect	Mana cost
L4	Affects all enemy creatures	7

In battle: Suppose the enemy has a 20-strong stack of similar stat-weight to our Onyx Dancers. Attacking it in melee normally means eating a ~120-damage counterattack — enough to kill ~6–7 of your own 18-HP dancers. Weakening Ray L1 deletes that counter entirely: the same attack now costs you **zero units** instead of a third of a stack’s worth of casualties. The math to run before casting: (expected counterattack damage ÷ your unit’s HP) = units saved per cast. When that number exceeds 3–4 units, the 10 mana has clearly paid for itself.

All four levels: - **L1:** Removes 1 counterattack charge from the target enemy. - **L2:** Same effect; mana cost drops from 10 to 7. - **L3:** Removes all counterattack charges from the target. - **L4:** Now affects all enemy creatures at once.

Masterful version: None documented in current sourcing.

Why you’d cast it: Before attacking a dangerous counter-attacker with a fragile stack.

Best heroes: Might heroes planning an aggressive melee opener.

When it’s weak: Against enemies with few or no counterattacks.

Common mistakes: Casting reactively after already eating a counterattack.

Campaign Verdict: (3/5) — a solid tactical spell, more valuable in specific bad matchups than as a default pick.

Shorten Shadow

Mana cost: 10

3/5 · Skill Ceiling: 2/5 · Early 3/5 · Mid 3/5 · Late 2/5

Plain English: Weakens an enemy stack’s Attack and Defense, and the weakening gets worse the longer it’s left on them.

The Math: Base -2/-2, duration = 1 + 1 round per 3 Spellpower (~4 rounds at Spellpower 10). L2 changes *how* the penalty behaves rather than its starting size: it now compounds each round instead of staying flat, so a target left debuffed for the full 4 rounds ends up far worse off than -2/-2 by the end.

In battle: Attack and Defense each shift damage by roughly 5% per point (attacker’s Attack raises it, defender’s Defense lowers it). So -2 Attack on an enemy stack that hits like our 20 Onyx Dancers (~120 damage) shaves ~10% off — they now deal ~108, **saving you ~12 damage per enemy swing**. Simultaneously, -2 Defense means your own attacks into that stack land ~10% harder: your 120-damage volley effectively becomes ~132. One 10-mana cast is quietly swinging every exchange with that stack by ~24 damage in your favor — and at L2, the swing grows every round it stays on.

All four levels: - **L1:** -2 Attack and -2 Defense to the target enemy. - **L2:** The reduction now increases every round the effect persists, instead of staying flat. - **L3:** Also dispels the enemy spell “Enlarge Shadow” if present. - **L4:** Now affects all enemy creatures at once.

Masterful version: None documented in current sourcing.

Why you’d cast it: A genuine debuff from the “buff school” — cast on the enemy’s biggest threat to soften both damage and survivability.

Best heroes: Any hero facing one dominant enemy stack.

When it’s weak: Diluted value against balanced enemy rosters.

Common mistakes: Not holding this in reserve against Nightshade opponents specifically, for the L3 dispel.

Campaign Verdict: (3/5) — a sharp counter-pick, situationally excellent.

Inner Light

Mana cost: 9

2/5 · Skill Ceiling: 2/5 · Early 2/5 · Mid 3/5 · Late 2/5

Plain English: Shortens how long negative effects (debuffs) stick around on a friendly stack.

The Math: Reduction = base + (1 round per 3 Spellpower). Worked at Spellpower 10:

Level	Formula	Result at SP 10
L1	2 + (SP÷3)	2 + 3 = 5 rounds cleared
L2	3 + (SP÷3)	3 + 3 = 6 rounds cleared
L3	Same as L2, + adjacent creatures	6 rounds, wider radius
L4	Same, + all friendly creatures	6 rounds, whole army

In battle: Suppose the enemy lands Shorten Shadow’s L2 version on your 20-Dancer stack — a compounding -2/-2 Attack/Defense debuff that costs you roughly 12+ damage per volley and worsens every round. Inner Light L1 clears 5 rounds of its duration at Spellpower 10, which for most debuffs means **ending it on the spot** — recovering that ~12+ damage per volley for the rest of the fight, for 9 mana. The math to run mid-fight: (damage the debuff is costing you per round) × (rounds remaining) vs. one cast at 9 mana. Against stacked multi-debuff opponents, one cast clearing several effects at once is routinely worth 50+ damage in restored output.

All four levels: - **L1:** Reduces the duration of negative effects on the target by 2 + (1 per 3 Spellpower) rounds. - **L2:** Base portion rises from 2 to 3. - **L3:** Also affects friendly creatures adjacent to the target. - **L4:** Now affects all friendly creatures at once.

Masterful version: None documented in current sourcing.

Why you’d cast it: A cleanse-adjacent tool against heavy debuff opponents (Nightshade or Schism-style factions).

Best heroes: Support-oriented heroes fighting debuff-heavy compositions.

When it's weak: Against enemies with few debuffs, does nothing useful.

Common mistakes: Learning it as a default pick rather than a matchup-specific counter.

Campaign Verdict: (2/5) — narrow but sharp; a strong sideboard pick.

Tier 3 (requires Basic Daylight Magic)

Taunt

Mana cost: 16

4/5 · Skill Ceiling: 3/5 · Early 1/5 · Mid 4/5 · Late 4/5

Plain English: Forces nearby enemies to attack one specific friendly stack instead of picking their own targets.

The Math: Radius starts at 2 hexes. Duration = base + (1 round per 4 Spellpower), but every instance of damage taken shortens the remaining duration by 1 round — so a fragile tank burns through the effect fast regardless of the formula.

Level	Radius	Base duration (before SP bonus, before damage-shortening)
L1	2 hexes	1 round
L2	3 hexes	1 round
L3	3 hexes	2 rounds
L4	4 hexes	2 rounds

At Spellpower 10, L1's duration works out to $1 + (10 \div 4) = \sim \mathbf{3 \text{ rounds}}$ before any damage is taken — each hit against the taunting unit then subtracts a round from that.

In battle: Your 20 Onyx Dancers (18 HP each = 360 total HP) are the stack the enemy *wants* to kill. Taunt on your Minotaur screen redirects ~ 120 damage per enemy attack away from the Dancers and onto the tank. Two redirected attacks = ~ 240 damage that would have killed **13 of your 20 Dancers** (nearly wiping the stack's damage output) instead landing on a unit built to absorb it. The check before casting: does your tank have enough HP to eat 2–3 rounds of focused attacks? If yes, Taunt just converted your most fragile stack's worst-case round into a zero-loss round.

All four levels: - **L1:** All enemies within 2 hexes of the target are forced to attack it. Each instance of damage taken shortens the effect by 1 round. - **L2:** Radius grows from 2 to 3 hexes. - **L3:** Base duration improves from 1 to 2 rounds. - **L4:** Radius grows again, from 3 to 4 hexes.

Masterful version: None documented in current sourcing.

Why you'd cast it: Protect a fragile high-value stack by forcing enemy attention onto a tanky frontline unit instead.

Best heroes: Any hero running a “screen + damage core” army.

When it's weak: If the taunting unit is too fragile to survive being focused.

Common mistakes: Casting on a unit that dies too fast to hold the taunt.

Campaign Verdict: (4/5) — one of the best control tools in the Daylight kit once unlocked.

Arina's Touch

Mana cost: 17

3/5 · Skill Ceiling: 2/5 · Early 1/5 · Mid 3/5 · Late 3/5

Plain English: A stat-stacking buff — makes a friendly stack act earlier in the round and gives it bonus max HP.

The Math: Duration = 1 + 1 round per 4 Spellpower (~3 rounds at Spellpower 10). HP bonus is a flat percentage of the target's own max HP.

Level	Initiative bonus	HP bonus
L1	+1	+10%
L2	+1	+20%
L3	+1 (now whole army)	+20%
L4	+2	+20%

In battle: On the 20-Dancer stack (360 total HP), the L2 HP bonus adds +20% — **+72 effective HP, four extra dancers' worth of durability** — while the Initiative bonus pushes the stack up the turn order. Initiative math is where this spell quietly wins fights: Onyx Dancers have Initiative 4; if the enemy's key stack sits at 5, your Dancers normally shoot *second*. +1 Initiative ties it, +2 (L4) beats it — meaning your 120-damage volley lands **before** theirs, and whatever you kill never gets to swing at all. The HP is the visible bonus; acting first is the one that changes outcomes.

All four levels: - **L1:** Target gains +1 Initiative and +10% maximum HP. - **L2:** HP bonus rises from 10% to 20%. - **L3:** Now affects all friendly creatures at once. - **L4:** Initiative bonus doubles, from +1 to +2.

Masterful version: Increases the target's Speed by +1 (or +2 at spell Level 4), on top of the standard +10% HP. **Hero: Anastasia the Meek** (Cleric, Temple) starts with Masterful Arina's Touch as her personal specialization ("Hymn to Arina"). Her effective Spellpower for this spell increases by +1 for every 2 hero levels — at hero level 10, +5 effective Spellpower stacked on top of her stat line.

Why you'd cast it: A stat-stacking buff for a priority stack — best on whichever unit's turn order matters most.

Best heroes: Heroes already committed to Daylight; Anastasia specifically.

When it's weak: Competes with Taunt and Blessing for the same mana budget.

Common mistakes: Taking this before Taunt, when Taunt's control value usually outweighs this spell's stat buff.

Campaign Verdict: (3/5) — solid but usually third choice among the Tier 3 Daylight options.

Riposte

Mana cost: 15

3/5 · Skill Ceiling: 3/5 · Early 1/5 · Mid 3/5 · Late 3/5

Plain English: Makes a friendly stack counterattack *before* the enemy's attack lands, rather than after.

The Math: No Spellpower scaling on the core effect; duration = 1 + 1 round per 3 Spellpower (~4 rounds at Spellpower 10).

Level	Effect
L1	Counterattack lands before enemy attack
L2	+ 15% counterattack damage
L3	+ 1 bonus counterattack per round
L4	Affects all friendly creatures

In battle: A defending stack with Dancer-like output (~120 damage counters) normally counterattacks *after* being hit — so if the enemy's attack kills 7 of its 20 units first, the counter comes from only 13 survivors: ~78 damage instead of 120. Riposte flips the order: the full 20-unit counter (~120) lands **before** any of them die — **+42 damage on the counter**, purely from sequencing. Add L2's +15% and it's ~138. That's the entire trick of this spell in one number: it doesn't buff anything, it just makes sure your counterattacks come from a full-strength stack instead of a bleeding one.

All four levels: - **L1:** Target's counterattack lands before the enemy's attack does. - **L2:** While affected, target also deals +15% counterattack damage. - **L3:** Target gains +1 bonus counterattack per round. - **L4:** Now affects all friendly creatures at once.

Masterful version: None documented in current sourcing.

Why you'd cast it: On a defensive frontline stack you expect to be attacked repeatedly.

Best heroes: Defense-oriented Might heroes.

When it's weak: Useless on units that don't counterattack.

Common mistakes: Pairing with an already-fragile stack — Riposte punishes attackers harder but doesn't help the target survive the initial hit.

Campaign Verdict: (3/5) — a strong niche pick for defense-first compositions.

Song of Power

Mana cost: 12

3/5 · Skill Ceiling: 3/5 · Early 1/5 · Mid 3/5 · Late 4/5

Plain English: Resets a friendly creature's ability cooldowns.

The Math: No Spellpower scaling and no numeric formula — each level unlocks a categorically new effect.

Level	Unlocks
L1	Resets ability cooldowns on target
L2	+ dispels attack/ability-blocking effects
L3	+ reuse limited-use abilities
L4	Affects all friendly creatures

In battle: No damage formula here — the value equals *whatever the reset ability is worth*. Concrete framing: if the target's cooldown ability deals or prevents ~150 damage per use (typical for a strong mid-tier active), resetting it buys a second use this fight — 150 damage of value for 12 mana, better cost-per-damage than most direct nukes at this tier. The corollary is just as important: cast on a creature whose ability is worth ~30 damage, and you paid 12 mana for 30 damage. This spell has no floor and no ceiling of its own; it inherits both from the ability you reset.

All four levels: - **L1:** Resets the cooldowns of the target's abilities. - **L2:** Also dispels effects blocking that creature's attacks or abilities. - **L3:** The creature may reuse limited-use abilities again. - **L4:** Now affects all friendly creatures at once.

Masterful version: None documented in current sourcing.

Why you'd cast it: Immediately after a creature uses a strong cooldown-gated ability, to get another use in the same fight.

Best heroes: Heroes running creatures with powerful cooldown or once-per-battle abilities.

When it's weak: Wasted on creatures with no meaningful cooldowns.

Common mistakes: Casting too early, before the target has used its ability once.

Campaign Verdict: (4/5) — build-defining in the right creature/roster combination, low value otherwise.

Tier 4 (requires Advanced Daylight Magic)

Radiant Armour

Mana cost: 20

4/5 · Skill Ceiling: 2/5 · Early 1/5 · Mid 2/5 · Late 4/5

Plain English: Cuts how much damage a friendly stack takes from any source.

The Math: Flat percentage reduction, no Spellpower scaling — but because it's a percentage of incoming damage, it automatically scales with however big enemy hits get later in the game.

Level	Damage reduction
L1	20%
L2	25%
L3	25% (now whole army)
L4	35%

In battle: An enemy attack that would deal 120 damage to your 20-Dancer stack normally kills ~6–7 of them (18 HP each). Under Radiant Armour L1 (20% reduction), the same hit deals 96 — killing ~5 instead: **1–2 dancers saved per enemy attack**. At L4 (35%), the hit deals 78, saving 2–3 per attack. Multiply across a 4-round fight with several enemy stacks attacking, and L4 routinely saves 8–10+ units from a single 20-mana cast — units that keep dealing their share of your ~120 damage volley every round they stay alive. The compounding is the point: every unit this spell saves keeps fighting, which saves more units.

All four levels: - **L1:** Target takes 20% less damage from any source. - **L2:** Reduction rises to 25%. - **L3:** Now affects all friendly creatures at once. - **L4:** Reduction rises to 35%.

Masterful version: None documented in current sourcing.

Why you'd cast it: Flat damage reduction applies regardless of damage type — cast before a fight you expect to be a close damage race.

Best heroes: Any hero in a genuinely hard fight.

When it's weak: Overkill in fights you're already winning easily.

Common mistakes: Under-using it late-game, exactly when big hits make 20-35% reduction matter most.

Campaign Verdict: (4/5) — a top-tier defensive spell whose relative value only grows as the game progresses.

Clear Fog

Mana cost: 14

2/5 · Skill Ceiling: 1/5 · Early 2/5 · Mid 2/5 · Late 1/5

Plain English: A targeted scouting spell — reveals a patch of the map around a point you choose, without sending a hero there.

The Math: Casting range is capped at (range multiplier × your hero's Sight stat). Worked with a hero at Sight 5:

Level	Range multiplier	Max range at Sight 5	Squares revealed
L1	2×	10 squares	5
L2	3×	15 squares	5
L3	3×	15 squares	8
L4	uncapped	unlimited	8

All four levels: - **L1:** Reveals 5 squares around a selected point, no farther than $2 \times$ Sight away. Usable once per day. - **L2:** Range multiplier rises from $2 \times$ to $3 \times$ Sight. - **L3:** Squares revealed per cast rises from 5 to 8. - **L4:** Removes the range cap entirely.

Masterful version: None documented in current sourcing.

Why you'd cast it: Scouting a specific area without physically traveling there.

Best heroes: Secondary/scouting heroes.

When it's weak: Low priority relative to combat Tier 4 spells for an actively-fighting hero.

Common mistakes: Prioritizing this over combat spells on a war hero.

Campaign Verdict: (2/5) — nice utility, rarely worth the Tier 4 opportunity cost.

Vengeance

Mana cost: 15

3/5 · Skill Ceiling: 3/5 · Early 1/5 · Mid 3/5 · Late 3/5

Plain English: Makes attacking a friendly stack dangerous for the enemy — whoever hits the protected target takes damage back automatically.

The Math: Damage = base + (per-SP rate $\times$ Spellpower). Worked at Spellpower 10:

Level	Formula	Result at SP 10
L1	$100 + 15 \times \text{SP}$	$100 + 150 = \mathbf{250 \text{ damage}}$ per triggered attack
L2	Same formula, base duration 1→2 rounds	250 damage, longer uptime
L3	$100 + \mathbf{20} \times \text{SP}$	$100 + 200 = \mathbf{300 \text{ damage}}$
L4	Same rate, now triggers on all attacks, not just the first	300 damage per attack, every attack

In battle: Put L1 Vengeance (250 retaliation damage at Spellpower 10) on your Minotaur screen, and every enemy stack that attacks it eats 250 damage back automatically — against 18-HP Dancer-class attackers, that's **~13 units dead per attack they make**, before your units have even taken a turn. At L4, where it triggers on *every* attack instead of the first, three enemy attacks into your tank = 900 retaliation damage = **~50 Dancer-class units destroyed** from one 15-mana cast. This is why the Taunt pairing is so strong: Taunt forces them to attack the protected unit, Vengeance makes each of those forced attacks a self-inflicted wound.

All four levels: - **L1:** Whenever an enemy attacks the target, they take $100 + (15 \times \text{Spellpower})$ damage. - **L2:** Base duration improves from 1 to 2 rounds. - **L3:** Damage-per-Spellpower rises from 15 to 20. - **L4:** The effect now triggers on all basic attacks against the target, not just the first one.

Masterful version: None documented in current sourcing.

Why you'd cast it: On a tanky frontline stack you expect to absorb repeated attacks.

Best heroes: Defense-first Might heroes.

When it's weak: Low value if your frontline isn't actually being targeted much.

Common mistakes: Confusing with Riposte — Vengeance punishes any attacker automatically; Riposte specifically empowers the target's own counterattack. They stack well together.

Campaign Verdict: (3/5) — strong defensive tool, best paired with other defensive Daylight picks.

Heavenly Blades

Mana cost: 23

4/5 · Skill Ceiling: 3/5 · Early 1/5 · Mid 2/5 · Late 4/5

Plain English: A two-for-one spell — the target hits harder with a flat bonus, and heals itself for that same amount every time it lands a hit. Doesn't work on undead, spirit-type ("embodiment"), or construct units.

The Math: Bonus damage (and matching heal) is a flat number that doubles at L2 — no Spellpower scaling.

Level	Bonus damage & heal per hit
L1	+50
L2	+100
L3	+100 (now whole army)
L4	+100, and bonus damage now destroys summoned units outright

In battle: The flat bonus makes this spell's value depend heavily on what it's cast on. On our 20-Dancer stack (~120 damage per volley), L2's +100 is a **+83% damage increase** — plus 100 HP healed back per attack, which is over 5 dancers' worth of health recovered every single volley. On a huge late-game stack dealing 1,000+, the same +100 is only +10%. The rule of thumb the math gives you: flat bonuses favor *frequent attackers over heavy hitters* — this spell is at its best on fast, repeated-attack stacks, where the +100-and-heal triggers again and again per round, not on one slow giant swing.

All four levels: - **L1:** Target deals +50 pure bonus damage per hit and heals for the same amount. Doesn't revive fallen units; doesn't heal undead, embodiments, or constructs. - **L2:** Bonus damage (and matching heal) doubles from 50 to 100. - **L3:** Now affects all friendly creatures at once. - **L4:** The bonus damage now instantly destroys summoned or temporary enemy units it hits.

Masterful version: None documented in current sourcing.

Why you'd cast it: A damage-and-sustain combo in one cast; especially strong against summoner-style opponents at L4.

Best heroes: Late-game main heroes with meaningful Daylight investment.

Best factions: Anti-synergy warning — the healing half doesn't work on undead-type armies, so Necropolis players get the damage bonus but not the sustain from their own creatures.

When it's weak: Early game, where 23 mana is a large investment.

Common mistakes: Assuming the healing applies universally — it explicitly excludes undead, embodiments, and constructs.

Campaign Verdict: (4/5) — excellent late-game pick, with an important exception worth knowing before you rely on the heal.

Tier 5 (requires Expert Daylight Magic)

Judgement

Mana cost: 35

5/5 · Skill Ceiling: 3/5 · Early 1/5 · Mid 1/5 · Late 5/5

Plain English: A straight damage nuke — hits one enemy stack four times in a row for heavy total damage.

The Math: Total damage = base + (per-SP rate × Spellpower). Worked at Spellpower 10 across every level:

Level	Formula	Result at SP 10
L1	$200 + 30 \times \text{SP}$	$200 + 300 = \mathbf{500 \text{ damage}}$
L2	$\mathbf{300} + 30 \times \text{SP}$	$300 + 300 = \mathbf{600 \text{ damage}}$
L3	$300 + \mathbf{40} \times \text{SP}$	$300 + 400 = \mathbf{700 \text{ damage}}$
L4	$300 + \mathbf{60} \times \text{SP}$	$300 + 600 = \mathbf{900 \text{ damage}}$

That's nearly double the total damage from L1 to L4 at the same Spellpower — almost all of the spell's late-game power comes from leveling it up, not from raw Spellpower growth alone.

In battle: Against a 20-stack of 18-HP Dancer-class units (360 total HP), Judgement L1 at Spellpower 10 (500 damage) doesn't just hurt the stack — it **annihilates it outright with 140 damage to spare**. At L4 (900 damage), it deletes a 50-unit stack of the same creature. For comparison, your own 20 Onyx Dancers need **four full rounds of attacking** (~120/round) to deal what one L1 Judgement does instantly. That's the correct way to price a 35-mana nuke: not “is the mana expensive,” but “what would it cost my army in rounds and casualties to deal 500 damage the ordinary way.”

All four levels: - **L1:** Strikes an enemy 4 times for a total of $200 + (30 \times \text{Spellpower})$ damage. - **L2:** Base damage portion rises from 200 to 300. - **L3:** Damage-per-Spellpower rises from 30 to 40. - **L4:** Damage-per-Spellpower rises again, from 40 to 60.

Masterful version: None documented in current sourcing.

Why you'd cast it: Against a single high-value enemy stack where raw burst matters more than sustain.

Best heroes: High-Spellpower Daylight specialists in the late game.

When it's weak: Early-to-mid game, where 35 mana is prohibitively expensive.

Common mistakes: Undervaluing this spell because it doesn't fit Daylight's "buff school" reputation.

Campaign Verdict: (5/5) — the standout Tier 5 pick in this school.

Arina's Chosen

Mana cost: 21

4/5 · Skill Ceiling: 4/5 · Early 1/5 · Mid 2/5 · Late 5/5

Plain English: A "death ward" — guarantees a friendly stack can't be wiped below a certain percentage of its size, no matter how much damage it takes, for a couple of rounds.

The Math: Floor = percentage of the stack's *current* size (not its original size). Base duration is flat, no Spellpower scaling on the core effect.

Level	Protected floor	Base duration
L1	20%	2 rounds
L2	35%	2 rounds
L3	35%	4 rounds
L4	50%	4 rounds

Worked example: your 20-Dancer stack is protected at L1 (20% floor) when the enemy lands a wipe-level attack — instead of losing all 20, you keep **4 dancers**, who still shoot for ~24 damage a volley and, more importantly, still exist to be healed or reinforced after the fight. At L4 (50% floor), the same attack leaves **10 dancers standing** — half your damage output preserved through a hit that should have zeroed it. The comparison that sells the spell: without it, a wiped stack contributes nothing for the rest of the fight *and* costs full replacement gold afterward (Onyx Dancers run 160 gold each — a wiped 20-stack is 3,200 gold of rebuying).

All four levels: - **L1:** Target cannot drop below 20% of its current unit count. Taking damage reduces the effect's remaining duration by 1 round. Base duration: 2 rounds. - **L2:** Protected floor rises from 20% to 35%. - **L3:** Base duration rises from 2 to 4 rounds. - **L4:** Protected floor rises again, from 35% to 50%.

Masterful version: Target also gains **+1 action point** (an extra action that round), and the duration formula switches to 1 + 1 round per 6 Spellpower, with base duration also rising from 1 to 3 rounds once the spell reaches Level 3. **Hero: Sister Deira** (Warlock, Dungeon) starts with Masterful Arina's Chosen as her personal specialization ("Mask of the Sun"). Her effective Spellpower for this spell increases by +1 for every **3** hero levels (note: her scaling rate differs from the other four Masterful-spell heroes above, who get +1 per 2 levels) — at hero level 12, that's +4 effective Spellpower on top of her stat line.

Why you'd cast it: A "death ward" for your single most valuable stack in a make-or-break fight.

Best heroes: Main heroes protecting an irreplaceable elite stack; Sister Deira specifically for the built-in action-point bonus.

Best factions: Most valuable for factions whose top-tier units are especially expensive or slow to regrow (e.g. Dungeon’s Gem-gated Black Dragons — fittingly, Sister Deira is herself a Dungeon hero).

When it’s weak: Low-value in fights you’re already winning comfortably.

Common mistakes: Saving it too long — cast after the stack has already dropped below the guaranteed floor, the ward can’t retroactively restore lost units.

Campaign Verdict: (4/5) — genuine insurance for your army’s crown jewel; best value in exactly the highest-stakes fights.

Confirmed Masterful spell / hero pairings (this school)

Spell	Hero	Faction / Class	Effective SP bonus
Blessing	Vesper	Temple, Cleric	+1 per 2 hero levels
Haste	Mila	Hive, Herald	+1 per 2 hero levels
Healing Water	Julius	Temple, Cleric	+1 per 2 hero levels
Arina’s Touch	Anastasia the Meek	Temple, Cleric	+1 per 2 hero levels
Arina’s Chosen	Sister Deira	Dungeon, Warlock	+1 per 3 hero levels

All five sourced directly from the official wiki’s **Heroes** page and each hero’s individual page (retrieved 2026-07-03) — not a secondary source.

Synergy notes

- **Taunt + Vengeance/Riposte:** force enemy attacks onto a tank, then punish those attacks — a complete defensive-turret combo for roughly 31–39 mana depending on levels.
- **Shorten Shadow vs. Nightshade opponents:** the L3 dispel of “Enlarge Shadow” makes this spell specifically strong in Daylight-vs-Nightshade matchups.
- **Heavenly Blades vs. summoner factions:** the L4 “destroys summoned units” clause is a hard counter worth holding in reserve.
- **Four of the five Masterful Daylight heroes are Temple Clerics** (Vesper, Julius, Anastasia the Meek, plus Nadir who owns a Nightshade Masterful spell) — Temple is disproportionately the “Daylight specialist” faction at the hero level, worth knowing when picking a main hero for a Daylight-focused build.

Common beginner mistakes (school-wide)

- Treating Daylight purely as “the buff school” and overlooking Judgement — it’s the highest-ceiling damage spell in the whole kit.
- Spreading mana thin across many small buffs instead of concentrating Blessing/Favorable Wind on the one stack that swings the fight.

- Ignoring the undead-healing exception on Heavenly Blades when playing or fighting Necropolis.

Sourcing note: exact mana costs, formulas, and per-level mechanics from the official wiki's `Module:DaylightSpells` structured data (all 19 spells, retrieved 2026-07-03). Hero-to-Masterful-spell pairings and their effective-Spellpower bonuses sourced directly from the official wiki's **Heroes** page and the individual hero pages for Vesper, Mila, Julius, Anastasia the Meek, and Sister Deira (retrieved 2026-07-03) — this supersedes the previous draft's partial reliance on a secondary fan-maintained source. All worked-math tables, plain-English rewrites, ratings, synergy notes, and campaign verdicts are original analysis, not wiki content.

Neutral Magic

The schoolless school — utility spells every hero can eventually use, belonging to no scholar and no faction. Almost entirely adventure-map tools: teleports, logistics, mana tricks, and two combat exceptions. Nobody builds around Neutral Magic; everybody uses it.

How Neutral spells work (read this first — they're different)

Neutral spells break every rule the other four schools follow:

1. **Unlocked by hero level, not Mage Guilds.** Tiers 1–5 unlock at hero levels **1, 3, 6, 9, and 12** respectively. Every hero gets them on schedule, no buildings required.
2. **Leveled by a points system, not spell scrolls.** Neutral spells upgrade automatically as you accumulate points from normal play: **unlocking a normal spell = 1 point, leveling a normal spell = 1 point, constructing a building = 2 points, building a Mage Guild = 6 points.** In practice: playing the game levels them for you — a developed empire has high-level Neutral spells without ever choosing them.
3. **No Masterful versions exist** for any Neutral spell — no hero specializes in them, so this chapter has no Masterful sections.
4. **Several cost 0 mana**, which is not a typo.

Battle examples (for the two combat spells) use the standard reference army — **20 Onyx Dancers** (18 HP each, ~120 damage/volley) — at **Spellpower 10**. A sourcing honesty note: the wiki's table lists no per-level upgrades for several Tier 1 spells and for Summon Avatar (which instead comes in three named ranks); where per-level data is absent below, that absence is stated rather than invented.

Tier 1 (hero level 1)

Magic Arrow

Mana cost: 0

3/5 · Skill Ceiling: 1/5 · Early 4/5 · Mid 2/5 · Late 1/5

Plain English: A free bolt of damage. Zero mana. Every hero, every battle, from level 1.

The Math: Damage = $25 + (5 \times \text{Spellpower}) \rightarrow$ **75 damage at Spellpower 10** (and a still-useful ~35 at a level-1 hero's typical SP 2). The wiki lists no per-level upgrades for this spell.

In battle: 75 damage kills 4 Dancer-class units — a third of your reference stack’s volley — for *nothing*. That price changes hero design: even the most spell-averse Might hero contributes chip damage every single round of every fight, forever. Early game, versus tiny neutral stacks, Magic Arrow alone can carry fights your Week 1 army couldn’t otherwise take without losses.

Why you’d cast it: It’s free. The question is why you *wouldn’t* — and the answer is only “because a better spell exists this turn.”

When it’s weak: Mid-game onward, 75 damage stops mattering; it becomes the thing you cast when nothing else is worth mana.

Common mistakes: Forgetting it exists on Might heroes — free damage is free.

Campaign Verdict: (3/5) — the floor of every hero’s turn is never “pass,” and that’s worth more than it looks.

Necromancer Will

Mana cost: 0

2/5 (5/5 for Necropolis) · Skill Ceiling: 2/5 · all stages: faction-dependent

Plain English: A toggle switch for Necromancy — turn undead-raising off, and your hero banks Necromantic Energy after victories instead of raising troops.

The Math: No formula; a resource-routing toggle. The wiki lists no per-level upgrades.

Why you’d cast it: Pure Necropolis infrastructure: when your army is full or the available raise is low-value trash units, banking the energy for later (or better) conversion is strictly superior to overflowing. For all other factions it’s a dead page in the spellbook.

When it’s weak: It isn’t weak or strong — it’s a settings menu. Non-Necropolis heroes simply never touch it.

Common mistakes: Necropolis players leaving raising on autopilot and diluting armies with unwanted skeleton-tier units.

Campaign Verdict: (2/5) overall — but effectively a Necropolis faction mechanic wearing a spell’s clothes; rated 5/5 inside that faction chapter.

Back to Town!

Mana cost: 10

3/5 · Skill Ceiling: 2/5 · Early 3/5 · Mid 3/5 · Late 3/5

Plain English: Emergency evacuation — teleports your hero to the nearest owned city within 16 squares. All remaining movement is forfeited. Once per day.

The Math: Fixed 16-square range, 1/day. The wiki lists no per-level upgrades.

Why you’d cast it: Two uses define it: escape (an enemy hero is one day away and your army isn’t ready) and logistics (end the day’s exploring, teleport home, spend the night’s gold on troops,

rehire, and march out re-armed). The movement forfeit prices it honestly — it's an end-of-turn button, so cast it *after* spending the day's moves, never before.

When it's weak: More than 16 squares from home, it's a blank page — deep expeditions travel beyond its reach.

Common mistakes: Casting mid-day and torching half a turn of movement for no reason.

Campaign Verdict: (3/5) — insurance plus a weekly-rhythm logistics tool, free of skill investment.

Mana Rite

Mana cost: 0

3/5 · Skill Ceiling: 3/5 · Early 3/5 · Mid 3/5 · Late 3/5

Plain English: Trades the rest of today's movement for mana — 1% of your maximum mana per 1% of movement remaining.

The Math: Mana restored = (remaining movement %) of max mana. Stand still all day: full mana bar. The wiki lists no per-level upgrades.

Why you'd cast it: Mana is the binding constraint on caster heroes, and this converts a resource you sometimes don't need (movement on a rest day) into the one you always do. The play pattern: the day before a big planned assault, move only as far as the staging square, then Rite the remainder into a full tank.

When it's weak: Every cast costs map tempo — used carelessly it's paying gold-equivalent time for mana you'd regenerate anyway.

Common mistakes: Casting with 10% movement left for 10% mana — the trade only shines when the movement was going spare.

Campaign Verdict: (3/5) — a tempo-for-power exchange that rewards players who plan their assault days.

Relocation

Mana cost: 12

4/5 · Skill Ceiling: 2/5 · Early 3/5 · Mid 4/5 · Late 4/5

Plain English: Remotely opens any city you control and swaps troops with it — reinforcement without the walk. Once per day.

The Math: Any controlled city, map-wide, 1/day. The wiki lists no per-level upgrades.

Why you'd cast it: This is the quiet economy engine of the school. The weekly rhythm of Heroes games is “new troops appear in town; hero marches back to collect them” — Relocation deletes the march. Every week, from anywhere: 12 mana, and this week's growth teleports into

your army. Over a campaign that's *days* of saved movement, which compounds into more fights, more experience, more map.

When it's weak: Single-city, single-hero situations shrink it to a convenience.

Common mistakes: Forgetting the 1/day limit when trying to shuffle troops across multiple cities.

Campaign Verdict: (4/5) — the best logistics spell most players never consciously chose; it levels itself via the points system while you play.

Tier 2 (hero level 3)

Pocket Dimension

Mana cost: 14

2/5 · Skill Ceiling: 4/5 · Early 1/5 · Mid 2/5 · Late 3/5

Plain English: Opens a door to a private stash-space on the map — any allied hero can bank creatures and artifacts inside. The door closes at day's end (and vanishes if an enemy touches it).

The Math:

Level	Effect
L1	Entrance on adjacent hex, lasts to end of day, 1/day
L2	Mana 14 → 10
L3	Entrance placeable within 4 squares
L4	Lasts until end of <i>next</i> day

All four levels: - **L1:** Creates a Remote Foothold entrance on an adjacent space until day's end; allied heroes can store creatures and artifacts. An enemy interacting with it destroys it. Once per day. - **L2:** Mana cost drops from 14 to 10. - **L3:** Entrance can be created within 4 squares. - **L4:** Entrance persists through the next day.

Why you'd cast it: Sophisticated multi-hero plays: parking a reserve army mid-map where a second hero can collect it, or stashing artifacts before a risky fight (a defeated hero drops what they carry — a stash means losing the battle without losing the loadout).

When it's weak: Solo-hero, low-stakes play has nothing to stash and nobody to share with.

Common mistakes: Stashing next to an enemy's path — their touch deletes the door, with your goods behind it.

Campaign Verdict: (2/5) — a genuinely clever tool that most campaigns never quite need.

Second Wind

Mana cost: 17

4/5 · Skill Ceiling: 2/5 · Early 3/5 · Mid 4/5 · Late 4/5

Plain English: Instantly refunds movement points — your hero simply walks further today. The map-tempo spell.

The Math:

Level	Movement restored	Mana	Uses/day
L1	40	17	1
L2	40	13	1
L3	60	13	1
L4	60	13	2

All four levels: - **L1:** Immediately restores 40 Movement points. Once per day. - **L2:** Mana cost drops from 17 to 13. - **L3:** Restoration rises from 40 to 60. - **L4:** Usable twice per day.

Why you'd cast it: Movement is the true currency of the adventure map — every extra square is more resources, earlier fights, faster snowball. L4's two casts of 60 is a daily +120 movement subsidy, which over a week amounts to a free extra day of travel. This is the inverse of Mana Rite: that spell sells movement for mana; this buys it back. Casters with spare mana should almost always be net buyers.

When it's weak: Sieges, garrison duty, any parked hero — movement restored to a hero who isn't moving is nothing.

Common mistakes: Hoarding the daily use “for later” and ending days with it uncast — unused charges are the only way this spell fails.

Campaign Verdict: (4/5) — map tempo in a bottle; one of the most quietly winning spells in the game.

Tier 3 (hero level 6)

Summon Avatar

Mana cost: 0 · comes in three ranks (Basic / Advanced / Expert) rather than four levels

4/5 · Skill Ceiling: 2/5 · Early 3/5 · Mid 4/5 · Late 4/5

Plain English: Summons your hero's Avatar — a free, personal battlefield champion whose strength is built from your hero's own stats. One per side per battle. (This spell is also the subject of its own Magic skill, “Summon Avatar,” which upgrades the rank.)

The Math: The Avatar's statline scales with Spellpower on both HP and damage, plus Attack/Defense equal to your Spellpower and Knowledge. Worked at Spellpower 10:

Rank	HP formula	Damage formula	At SP 10
Basic	$100 + 12 \times \text{SP}$	$5 + 6 \times \text{SP}$	220 HP, 65 dmg
Advanced	$100 + 18 \times \text{SP}$	$5 + 12 \times \text{SP}$	280 HP, 125 dmg
Expert	$100 + 24 \times \text{SP}$	$5 + 18 \times \text{SP}$	340 HP, 185 dmg

In battle: An Expert Avatar at Spellpower 10 walks in with 340 HP — nearly a full 20-Dancer stack’s durability (360) — and swings for 185, *half again more than the entire Dancer volley* — for zero mana, every battle, permanently. It’s a sixth army slot conjured from your hero sheet. And because every stat in its formula is hero-derived, it keeps pace with your hero forever: at SP 20 late-game, the Expert Avatar is a 580-HP, 365-damage monster. The one-per-side cap and its summon-type vulnerability (Anti-Magic deletes it) are the only brakes.

Ranks (in place of the usual four levels): - **Basic:** $100 + (12 \times \text{SP})$ HP; $5 + (6 \times \text{SP})$ base damage; gains Attack and Defense equal to the hero’s Spellpower and Knowledge. - **Advanced:** HP rate $12 \rightarrow 18$; damage rate $6 \rightarrow 12$. - **Expert:** HP rate $18 \rightarrow 24$; damage rate $12 \rightarrow 18$.

Masterful version: None — like all Neutral spells. Rank progression via the Summon Avatar skill fills the same role.

Why you’d cast it: Free stats every fight; the closest thing to a seventh creature slot in the game.

Best heroes: Magic heroes, whose Spellpower and Knowledge feed every line of the formula twice.

When it’s weak: On low-SP Might heroes the Avatar arrives as a speed bump; and anti-summon tech deletes it like any conjured stack.

Common mistakes: Not casting it *every single battle* — a free summon uncast is the purest wasted value in the game.

Campaign Verdict: (4/5) — the best reason the Neutral school exists; on a dedicated Magic hero it borders on 5/5.

Shadowflight

Mana cost: 20

3/5 · Skill Ceiling: 3/5 · Early 1/5 · Mid 4/5 · Late 4/5

Plain English: Your hero flies until the end of the day — over mountains, forests, rivers, and anything else the map put in the way.

The Math:

Level	Effect	Mana
L1	Fly until day’s end; obstacle-crossing costs +30% movement	20
L2	Same	14
L3	Obstacle-crossing costs nothing extra	14
L4	-20% movement cost while flying	14

All four levels: - **L1:** Grants flight until the end of the day; moving above obstacles costs +30% movement. - **L2:** Mana cost drops from 20 to 14. - **L3:** Obstacle-crossing surcharge removed. - **L4:** All movement while flying costs -20%.

Masterful version: None.

Why you'd cast it: Maps are mazes; flight is the answer key. Cutting across a mountain range that would cost three days of walking, skipping a guarded chokepoint entirely, dropping onto an enemy's undefended town from an "impossible" direction — Shadowflight converts map geometry from constraint into suggestion. At L4 it's not just obstacle-proof, it's a net movement *discount* — strictly better travel.

When it's weak: Open flat maps have nothing to fly over; the spell is only as good as the terrain is bad.

Common mistakes: Casting at day's end with 10 movement left — it expires at midnight; cast at dawn, fly all day.

Campaign Verdict: (3/5) — map-dependent, and on the right map it trivializes route-planning entirely.

Town Portal

Mana cost: 24

5/5 · Skill Ceiling: 2/5 · Early 2/5 · Mid 5/5 · Late 5/5

Plain English: Teleports your hero to *any* city you control — your choice, any distance. The most famous logistics spell in the series, and it earns the reputation here too.

The Math:

Level	Effect	Mana	Uses/day
L1	Teleport to any owned city	24	1
L2	Same	18	1
L3	Same	18	2
L4	Same	18	3

All four levels: - **L1:** Teleports the casting hero to a selected controlled city. Once per day. - **L2:** Mana cost drops from 24 to 18. - **L3:** Usable twice per day. - **L4:** Usable three times per day.

Masterful version: None.

Why you'd cast it: Town Portal is why late-game empires are defensible at all. The eternal dilemma — push the offensive or rush home to defend — stops existing when home is 18 mana away: push *and* defend, same hero, same day. At L4's three daily casts, one hero garrisons an entire empire: defend city A in the morning, reinforce at city B midday, and portal back to the front by nightfall. Paired with Relocation (grab fresh troops remotely) and Second Wind (movement after arrival), the Neutral school quietly contains the entire logistics engine of a winning campaign.

When it's weak: One-city starts get a discount escape rope and nothing more — its power scales exactly with your empire.

Common mistakes: Learning it late. The points system levels it passively, but the *moment* it matters is the moment you own a second city — plan around having it by then.

Campaign Verdict: (5/5) — the most important non-combat spell in the game, precisely as veterans of the series would predict.

Tier 4 (hero level 9)

Dimension Door

Mana cost: 22

4/5 · Skill Ceiling: 3/5 · Early 1/5 · Mid 4/5 · Late 4/5

Plain English: Short-range teleport to any visible spot nearby — no city required, no path required. Blink for the adventure map.

The Math:

Level	Range	Mana	Uses/day
L1	8 squares	22	1
L2	8	14	1
L3	11	14	1
L4	11	14	2

All four levels: - **L1:** Teleports the hero to a target location within 8 squares. Once per day. - **L2:** Mana cost drops from 22 to 14. - **L3:** Range rises from 8 to 11 squares. - **L4:** Usable twice per day.

Masterful version: None.

Why you'd cast it: Where Town Portal is strategic, this is tactical: hop the river without the bridge, skip the guard sitting on the only road, land *behind* the enemy hero who thought the mountain protected them. Historically this spell breaks Heroes games — its once-per-day cap and modest range here are the balance leash, and even leashed, “ignore any 11 squares of map, twice a day” wins races that decide campaigns.

When it's weak: Corridors and open plains where the straight walk was fine anyway.

Common mistakes: Spending it to save 3 squares of ordinary walking — it's a key, not a stroll; save it for doors.

Campaign Verdict: (4/5) — the tactical teleport, held one star below its legendary ancestors purely by the daily cap.

Gate of Light

Mana cost: 28

3/5 · Skill Ceiling: 4/5 · Early 1/5 · Mid 3/5 · Late 4/5

Plain English: Opens a portal that *anyone on your side* can walk through until day’s end — not just the caster. A door for your whole roster of heroes.

The Math:

Level	Exit range	Mana	Uses/day
L1	Within 5 squares of caster	28	1
L2	5	20	1
L3	7	20	1
L4	7	20	2

All four levels: - **L1:** Creates a portal lasting until day’s end; any hero may enter from an adjacent space and exit within 5 squares of the caster. Once per day. - **L2:** Mana cost drops from 28 to 20. - **L3:** Exit radius rises from 5 to 7 squares. - **L4:** Usable twice per day.

Masterful version: None.

Why you’d cast it: The multi-hero force multiplier: your main caster opens the gate at the front line, and the slow secondary hero hauling this week’s reinforcements steps through from home territory — whole armies skipping the map. It’s Dimension Door’s answer to the question “but what about everyone else?” The skill ceiling is coordination: the gate’s value equals how well your other heroes were positioned to use it *today*, before it closes at midnight.

When it’s weak: Solo-hero play can’t use a door built for a convoy.

Common mistakes: Opening it with no second hero in position — a 28-mana door nobody walks through.

Campaign Verdict: (3/5) — niche solo, excellent in multi-hero economies; the ceiling belongs to planners.

Reading the school as a whole

The Neutral school is the game’s logistics layer wearing a spellbook’s covers. Its combat contribution is two spells (Magic Arrow’s free chip, Summon Avatar’s free champion) — everything else is about *where your heroes are and what they’re carrying*: three teleports of ascending scale (Back to Town! → Dimension Door/Gate of Light → Town Portal), two resource converters (Mana Rite, Second Wind), remote logistics (Relocation, Pocket Dimension), and one faction toggle. Because the points system levels these passively while you build and learn other spells, a well-developed empire gets an elite logistics suite *for free* — the practical advice is simply to remember it’s there. The players who consciously weave Town Portal + Relocation + Second Wind into their weekly rhythm run functionally faster campaigns than players fielding identical armies who don’t.

Common beginner mistakes (school-wide)

- Never opening the Neutral tab at all — the points system means these spells quietly leveled themselves while you weren't looking.
- Forgetting Summon Avatar exists and fighting every battle a free champion short.
- Casting movement/teleport spells at day's end when they pay at dawn.
- Undervaluing Relocation and Town Portal because “logistics isn't strategy” — in this genre, logistics is most of it.

Sourcing note: all mechanics, mana costs, formulas, per-level effects, the level-gate schedule (1/3/6/9/12), and the points system (1/1/2/6) taken directly from the official wiki's Neutral Spells page (retrieved 2026-07-03). The wiki lists no per-level upgrades for Magic Arrow, Necromancer Will, Back to Town!, Mana Rite, or Relocation, and presents Summon Avatar as three named ranks rather than four levels — this chapter reflects that faithfully rather than inventing data. No Neutral spell has a Masterful version. All worked math, battle examples, ratings, and verdicts are original analysis.

Nightshade Magic

Founded by the scholar Naira. The school of weakening enemies and turning their strength against them — debuffs, disables, and a few nasty surprises that don't fit either label. Where Daylight makes your army better, Nightshade makes theirs worse; the two schools mirror each other so directly that several spells are literal opposites (Enlarge Shadow → Shorten Shadow, Web → Haste).

How to read each entry

Same format as the Daylight chapter: **Plain English** → **The Math (with an In-battle worked example)** → **All four levels** → **Masterful version + hero** → **Strategy layer**. All battle examples use the standard reference army — a stack of **20 Onyx Dancers** (18 HP each, ~120 damage per volley, 360 total stack HP) — and all Spellpower math uses **Spellpower 10**. Attack-vs-Defense stat modifiers are ignored so each spell's own contribution stays visible; relative gains are accurate, absolute in-game numbers will vary.

A Nightshade-specific note on durations: this school's duration formulas are stingier than Daylight's. Where Daylight's Tier 1 buffs run $1 + 1$ round per 2 Spellpower (6 rounds at SP 10), Nightshade's Tier 1 debuffs run $1 + 1$ per 4 Spellpower (3 rounds), and its Tier 5 effects $1 + 1$ per 8 (2 rounds). The design logic: debuffs you inflict are harder to remove than buffs you grant yourself, so they get less uptime. Practical consequence — Nightshade rewards Spellpower investment more than Daylight does, because every extra duration round on a debuff is harder to come by.

Tier 1 (available to every hero, no skill required)

Unnatural Calm

Mana cost: 6

3/5 · Skill Ceiling: 1/5 · Early 4/5 · Mid 3/5 · Late 2/5

Plain English: The mirror-image of Blessing — makes an enemy stack hit *softer* with its regular attacks.

The Math: Flat percentage reduction to the target's basic-attack damage. Duration = $1 + 1$ round per 4 Spellpower → **3 rounds at Spellpower 10**.

Level	Enemy damage reduction
L1	-15%
L2	-20%
L3	-20% (now all enemy creatures)
L4	-30%

In battle: An enemy stack that hits like our 20 Onyx Dancers (~120 damage) deals ~102 under L1 — **~18 damage prevented per attack, one whole dancer saved per swing**. At L4 (-30%), the same attack drops to ~84: two dancers saved per swing, across every enemy stack at once (L3+ hits everything). Over a 3-round fight against three attacking stacks, L4 is quietly preventing 300+ damage for 6 mana. Note the comparison with its Daylight mirror: Blessing L4 adds +25% to *your* damage; Unnatural Calm L4 removes 30% of *theirs* — the debuff version is numerically stronger, at the cost of a shorter duration.

All four levels: - **L1:** Target enemy deals -15% damage with basic attacks. - **L2:** Reduction deepens to -20%. - **L3:** Now affects **all enemy creatures** at once. - **L4:** Reduction deepens to -30%.

Masterful version: The wiki's spell table flags Unnatural Calm as having a Masterful version, but its effect text isn't documented there yet, and no owning hero has been confirmed in available sourcing — logged in the audit file as a gap to fill, not a guess to make.

Why you'd cast it: The single cheapest way to blunt an enemy's strongest attacker — 6 mana to take the edge off every hit they land.

Best heroes: Any early hero; scales into a whole-army debuff by L3.

When it's weak: Against ability-driven enemies whose damage doesn't come from basic attacks.

Common mistakes: Casting it on a low-damage enemy stack — like Blessing in reverse, it belongs on the enemy's *biggest hitter*.

Campaign Verdict: (3/5) — a cheap, honest workhorse that stays relevant slightly longer than Blessing because reducing enemy damage preserves your army (and your gold).

Enlarge Shadow

Mana cost: 7

3/5 · Skill Ceiling: 1/5 · Early 3/5 · Mid 3/5 · Late 2/5

Plain English: The odd one out — a *buff* in the debuff school. Your friendly stack gains Attack and Defense, and the bonus grows over time.

The Math: +2 Attack and +2 Defense; duration = 1 + 1 round per 4 Spellpower → 3 rounds at Spellpower 10. Each Attack/Defense point shifts damage roughly 5%, so the base cast is worth about ±10% on both sides of every exchange.

Level	Effect
L1	+2 Attack, +2 Defense
L2	Bonus increases each round
L3	+ dispels “Shorten Shadow”
L4	Affects all friendly creatures

In battle: On the 20-Dancer stack: +2 Attack turns the ~120 volley into ~132 (+12), while +2 Defense trims incoming 120-damage hits to ~108 (one dancer saved per enemy swing). Both at once, from one 7-mana cast — and at L2 the numbers keep climbing every round the fight drags on, which makes this spell *better in long fights*, the opposite of most buffs. By round 3 of an L2 cast the swing per exchange can exceed ± 30 damage.

All four levels: - **L1:** Target friendly creature gains +2 Attack and +2 Defense. - **L2:** The bonus to Attack and Defense increases each round. - **L3:** Also dispels the enemy Daylight spell “Shorten Shadow.” - **L4:** Now affects all friendly creatures at once.

Masterful version: None — the wiki explicitly lists no Masterful version for this spell.

Why you’d cast it: A compact both-directions stat buff, and Nightshade’s direct answer to Daylight’s Shorten Shadow (each dispels the other at L3 — whoever casts second wins that exchange).

Best heroes: Nightshade-committed heroes who still want one buff in the toolkit without cross-training Daylight.

When it’s weak: Short fights that end before the L2 compounding pays off.

Common mistakes: Treating it as interchangeable with Daylight buffs — its growth-over-time design means it wants long, grinding battles.

Campaign Verdict: **(3/5)** — unspectacular numbers with a sneaky-good growth clause; a fine pick for attrition-style armies.

Despair

Mana cost: 9

4/5 · Skill Ceiling: 2/5 · Early 4/5 · Mid 4/5 · Late 3/5

Plain English: A curse that burns the target every time its turn comes up — damage-over-time that can be stacked onto the same target multiple times.

The Math: Damage per turn = $20 + 10 \times \text{Spellpower}$ → **120 Pure Damage at Spellpower 10**, per turn, per stack of the curse. Duration = 1 + 1 per 4 Spellpower (3 rounds). “Pure Damage” means it ignores defenses.

Level	Formula / effect	Result at SP 10
L1	$20 + 10 \times \text{SP}$ per turn	120/turn
L2	Base duration 1→2 rounds	120/turn, longer uptime
L3	+50% spell damage	180/turn

Level	Formula / effect	Result at SP 10
L4	Also curses enemies adjacent to target	180/turn, multi-target

In battle: One L1 cast on an enemy stack of Dancer-class units kills **~6–7 of them (120 damage vs 18 HP each) every time that stack takes a turn** — and because it’s stackable, casting it twice on the same target doubles that to 13 per turn. At L3 (180/turn), a single cast out-damages your entire 20-Dancer volley (~120) every round, automatically, while your Dancers are free to shoot something else. The stacking clause is what separates this from ordinary damage spells: most debuffs cap at one instance; Despair rewards casting it again.

All four levels: - **L1:** Cursed target takes $20 + (10 \times \text{Spellpower})$ Pure Damage at the start of its turn. Stackable. - **L2:** Base duration rises from 1 to 2 rounds. - **L3:** Spell damage increases by +50%. - **L4:** Also affects enemy creatures adjacent to the target.

Masterful version: This version affects **all types of enemies** — lifting whatever creature-type immunities normally block the curse. **Hero: Laura** (Necromancer, Necropolis) starts with Masterful Despair as her specialization (“Moldering”), +1 effective Spellpower per 2 hero levels — confirmed against the official master hero table.

Why you’d cast it: Efficient, defense-ignoring, stackable damage — the best damage-per-mana ratio in the Tier 1 pool of any school.

Best heroes: Any Spellpower-leaning hero, from the first week onward.

When it’s weak: Against certain creature types immune to curses (exactly the gap the Masterful version closes), and against stacks that die before taking many turns.

Common mistakes: Spreading single casts across many targets instead of stacking onto the one stack you most need dead.

Campaign Verdict: (4/5) — pound-for-pound one of the best Tier 1 spells in the game; the stacking clause gives it a ceiling most Tier 1 picks lack.

Fatal Decay

Mana cost: 4

4/5 · Skill Ceiling: 3/5 · Early 3/5 · Mid 4/5 · Late 4/5

Plain English: Shuts off an enemy stack’s ability to heal — and the effect keeps working even on their dead, blocking resurrection-style recovery too.

The Math: No damage numbers — this spell’s value is measured in *enemy healing denied*. Duration = 1 + 1 per 4 Spellpower (3 rounds at Spellpower 10). At 4 mana it’s the cheapest spell in the school.

Level	Effect
L1	Target cannot restore HP; persists after death
L2	+ reduces maximum HP by 20%
L3	Effect cannot be dispelled

Level	Effect
L4	Max-HP reduction 20% → 30%

In battle: Against a healing-capable enemy (a Healing Water caster, a lifesteal unit, or any faction that raises its dead), every point of healing you prevent is damage you don't have to re-deal. Concrete case: your 20 Dancers spend a round dealing ~120 damage to a stack; if the enemy then heals 125 (one L2 Healing Water), your entire round was erased. One 4-mana Fatal Decay beforehand and that round *sticks*. The L2 max-HP cut adds direct value too: -20% max HP on a 360-HP Dancer-class stack is 72 HP gone — **4 units' worth of durability deleted for 4 mana**, before any attack lands.

All four levels: - **L1:** Target enemy cannot restore HP. Effect remains after the creature's death. - **L2:** Also reduces the target's maximum HP by 20%. - **L3:** The effect can no longer be dispelled. - **L4:** Maximum HP reduction deepens from 20% to 30%.

Masterful version: None — the wiki explicitly lists no Masterful version.

Why you'd cast it: The hard counter to sustain. Against Necropolis reanimation, Hive corpse-eating, Schism resurrection units, or any enemy hero spamming heals, this 4-mana cast invalidates their whole gameplan.

Best heroes: Anyone fighting sustain-heavy factions; near-mandatory tech against Necropolis.

When it's weak: Against armies with no healing at all, the L1 effect does literally nothing — only the L2+ max-HP cut has value there.

Common mistakes: Not learning it because the L1 tooltip looks situational — the matchups where it matters are among the most common frustrating fights in the game.

Campaign Verdict: (4/5) — a scalpel, not a hammer; in the right matchup it's the highest-value 4 mana you will ever spend.

Tier 2 (available to all heroes)

Read Minds

Mana cost: 10

2/5 · Skill Ceiling: 1/5 · Early 3/5 · Mid 2/5 · Late 1/5

Plain English: A map-intelligence spell — tells you exactly how many units are in nearby neutral armies and whether they'll fight or flee, before you commit to anything.

The Math: Range = $3 \times$ your hero's Sight stat. With Sight 5, that's a 15-square radius of revealed neutral-army intel. No combat application.

Level	Effect	Mana
L1	Reveals exact numbers + intentions of neutral squads within 3×Sight	10
L2	Same	7 (discounted)
L3	+ reveals info on enemy heroes	7
L4	+ reveals info on enemy cities	7

All four levels: - **L1:** Reveals the precise number and intentions of all neutral squads within 3 × Sight squares. - **L2:** Mana cost drops from 10 to 7. - **L3:** Also reveals information on enemy heroes. - **L4:** Also reveals information on enemy cities.

Masterful version: None documented.

Why you’d cast it: “Can I take that fight?” is the most expensive question in the game to answer wrong. This answers it for 7–10 mana — exact enemy counts instead of the vague size bands the map normally shows.

Best heroes: Your main fighting hero, early — better fight selection compounds into faster leveling and fewer losses.

When it’s weak: Late game, when your army beats everything nearby anyway and the answer to “can I take it” is always yes.

Common mistakes: Dismissing it as a scout-hero spell — it’s most valuable on the hero actually deciding which fights to take.

Campaign Verdict: (2/5) — genuinely useful information, but information has a shelf life; its rating falls off a cliff once you out-power the map.

Web

Mana cost: 9

4/5 · Skill Ceiling: 2/5 · Early 4/5 · Mid 4/5 · Late 3/5

Plain English: The anti-Haste — slows an enemy stack so it acts later and can’t cross the battlefield to reach you.

The Math: Duration = 1 + 1 per 5 Spellpower → 3 rounds at Spellpower 10. Speed penalty scales by level:

Level	Speed penalty	Extra effect
L1	-2	—
L2	-3	—
L3	-3	dispels Haste on the target
L4	-4	keeps Haste-dispel

In battle: Flip the Haste example around. An enemy melee stack at Speed 4 needs one turn to reach your 20 Dancers; Web L2 drops it to Speed 1, turning that into **three turns of approach** — three full volleys (~360 damage, enough to wipe a 20-stack of Dancer-class units) before it ever swings. Against enemies that must close distance to hurt you, Web doesn't reduce their damage; it multiplies *yours* by handing you extra free rounds. The L3 Haste-dispel also makes this the direct counter-cast in the Web-vs-Haste arms race — whoever casts last wins.

All four levels: - **L1:** Target enemy creature loses 2 Speed. - **L2:** Penalty deepens to -3. - **L3:** Also dispels Haste on the target. - **L4:** Penalty deepens to -4.

Masterful version: This version affects **all enemies** at once — a full-army slow. **Hero: Marl** (Death Knight, Necropolis) is the game's Web specialist per current hero data — his version applies from the start of battle. His exact Masterful ownership is consistent with all sourcing but flagged for one final verification pass in the audit file.

Why you'd cast it: Ranged armies win by keeping distance; Web manufactures distance. It's the single most build-defining Tier 2 pick for shooter-heavy compositions.

Best heroes: Any ranged-core army general; Marl if you want it army-wide and automatic.

When it's weak: Against ranged or flying enemies who don't care about ground speed.

Common mistakes: Webbing the nearest enemy instead of the *fastest* one — the stack that would reach your shooters first is the correct target, wherever it stands.

Campaign Verdict: (4/5) — a cornerstone control spell; arguably the most important single pick for ranged armies in the whole Tier 1–2 pool.

Shade Cloak

Mana cost: 7

3/5 · Skill Ceiling: 4/5 · Early 2/5 · Mid 3/5 · Late 3/5

Plain English: Makes a friendly stack untargetable — enemies simply can't select it — until it acts or the round ends. Higher levels turn it into an ambush tool: the first attack out of the cloak hits harder.

The Math: No duration formula — the effect ends when the unit acts or the round ends, full stop. The scaling is all in the ambush bonus:

Level	Effect	Mana
L1	Untargetable until acting / end of round	7
L2	First attack from cloak deals +25%	7
L3	Same	4 (discounted)
L4	Ambush bonus +25% → +50%	4

In battle: Defensively: cloak your 20 Dancers when a dangerous enemy stack is about to act, and 120+ damage that would have killed 6–7 of them has no legal target — it goes somewhere less valuable or nowhere. Offensively at L4: the Dancers' next volley out of the cloak deals ~180

instead of ~120 (+60 damage), for 4 mana. The skill-ceiling rating comes from the timing puzzle: cast too early and the enemy just waits you out; the spell rewards reading the initiative order well enough to know exactly whose attack you're dodging.

All four levels: - **L1:** Target friendly creature cannot be targeted. Ends when the unit takes any action or at the end of the round. - **L2:** The first attack under this effect deals +25% damage. - **L3:** Mana cost drops from 7 to 4. - **L4:** Ambush damage bonus rises from +25% to +50%.

Masterful version: None documented.

Why you'd cast it: A one-round invulnerability window plus a strike bonus — protection and payoff in the same cast.

Best heroes: Tactically-minded players who track initiative order; wasted on autopilot play.

When it's weak: Against area effects or anything that doesn't "target" — the cloak only blocks targeted actions.

Common mistakes: Cloaking a stack that has already acted this round — the effect expires at round's end, so late-round casts buy almost nothing.

Campaign Verdict: (3/5) — the highest skill-ceiling spell in the tier; average in casual hands, quietly excellent in careful ones.

Umbral Grip

Mana cost: 10

4/5 · Skill Ceiling: 2/5 · Early 4/5 · Mid 4/5 · Late 3/5

Plain English: A direct damage spell that cannot be reduced by anything — no armor, no resistances, no damage-reduction effects. What the formula says is exactly what lands.

The Math: Damage = 40 + (rate × Spellpower). Worked at Spellpower 10:

Level	Formula	Result at SP 10
L1	40 + 10×SP	140 damage
L2	40 + 15×SP	190 damage
L3	40 + 20×SP	240 damage
L4	Same as L3, + kills 1 extra unit (works up to tier 7)	240 + one guaranteed kill

In battle: L1's 140 unmodifiable damage kills **7–8 Dancer-class units (18 HP)** — more than your own 20-Dancer volley manages after the enemy's defenses chew on it. That "cannot be modified" clause is the whole spell: against a target stacked with Radiant Armour (-35% incoming) and high Defense, your Dancers' 120 volley might land as 60, while Umbral Grip's 140 still lands as 140. The L4 bonus-kill clause is aimed at big single units: it deletes one tier-7 creature outright, regardless of its HP — the cheapest guaranteed high-tier kill in the game.

All four levels: - **L1:** Deals $40 + (10 \times \text{Spellpower})$ Pure Damage to the target. This damage cannot be modified in any way. - **L2:** Damage-per-Spellpower rises from 10 to 15. - **L3:** Damage-per-Spellpower rises from 15 to 20. - **L4:** Additionally kills +1 unit; works on creatures up to tier 7.

Masterful version: This version also hits **enemy creatures adjacent to the target** — turning the single-target nuke into a cluster hit. **Hero: Sister Keiri** (Riftspeaker, Schism) is the game's Umbral Grip specialist per current hero data; her Masterful ownership is consistent with all sourcing but flagged for one final verification pass in the audit file.

Why you'd cast it: Reliable, un-mitigatable damage at Tier 2 prices — your answer to heavily-armored or damage-reduced targets that laugh at your army's attacks.

Best heroes: Any Spellpower hero; Sister Keiri for the area version.

When it's weak: Never truly weak, but plain — against soft targets your army kills fine on its own, it's just okay damage.

Common mistakes: Using it on the squishiest enemy instead of the most-mitigated one — its entire identity is ignoring defenses, so aim it where defenses are thickest.

Campaign Verdict: (4/5) — the most reliable damage in the school; the L4 tier-7 execution clause keeps it relevant all game.

Tier 3 (requires Basic Nightshade Magic)

Silence

Mana cost: 5

4/5 · Skill Ceiling: 3/5 · Early 2/5 · Mid 4/5 · Late 4/5

Plain English: Gags an enemy stack — it can't use its special abilities or build up the Focus Points that power them. Its basic attacks still work; everything interesting about it doesn't.

The Math: Duration = $1 + 1 \text{ per } 6 \text{ Spellpower}$ → ~2 rounds at Spellpower 10. The scaling is all in coverage:

Level	Coverage	Base duration
L1	One target	1 round
L2	One target	2 rounds
L3	+ adjacent enemies	2 rounds
L4	All enemy creatures	2 rounds

In battle: The value isn't in a damage number — it's in whatever ability you switched off. Concrete case: a Schism unit whose once-per-battle resurrection would return ~200 HP of dead units to the fight, or a Hydra whose all-adjacent sweep would hit three of your stacks at once. Silencing either for the two rounds when it mattered is worth 150–300+ damage swung, for 5 mana. At L4, an entire ability-driven army (Hive with its Focus-hungry actives, Schism with its resurrections) is reduced to basic attacks — often a bigger swing than any damage spell at this tier could buy.

All four levels: - **L1:** Target enemy creature cannot use abilities or generate Focus Points. - **L2:** Base duration rises from 1 to 2 rounds. - **L3:** Also affects enemy creatures adjacent to the target. - **L4:** Now affects all enemy creatures.

Masterful version: None documented.

Why you'd cast it: Modern Olden Era combat runs on creature abilities and Focus; Silence is the off-switch, at an absurd 5 mana.

Best heroes: Anyone fighting ability-centric factions — this spell's value tracks the enemy roster, not yours.

When it's weak: Against plain melee/ranged armies with no abilities worth silencing.

Common mistakes: Silencing on autopilot at fight start rather than timing it against the specific ability activation you fear.

Campaign Verdict: (4/5) — one of the best mana-to-impact ratios in the game against the right rosters; know your matchups.

Naira's Veil

Mana cost: 16

2/5 · Skill Ceiling: 3/5 · Early 1/5 · Mid 2/5 · Late 2/5

Plain English: A map spell that re-fogs the area around your hero, hiding them from enemy players until the fog is scouted away again — stealth mode for the adventure map.

The Math: No Spellpower scaling; levels grow the fog radius and discount the cost. Once per day.

Level	Fog radius	Mana
L1	8 squares	16
L2	8 squares	12
L3	10 squares	12
L4	14 squares	12

All four levels: - **L1:** Renews fog of war in an 8-square radius around the hero, concealing them until re-scouted. Once per day. - **L2:** Mana cost drops from 16 to 12. - **L3:** Radius grows from 8 to 10 squares. - **L4:** Radius grows from 10 to 14 squares.

Masterful version: None documented.

Why you'd cast it: Hiding your main army's position before a strike, or masking a weakened hero's retreat path. Almost entirely a multiplayer/anti-human tool.

Best heroes: Aggressive main heroes in PvP-style scenarios.

When it's weak: Against AI opponents that don't scout the way humans do, its value collapses — which is most of a single-player campaign.

Common mistakes: Learning it for campaign play, where the AI rarely punishes visible positioning enough to justify the pick.

Campaign Verdict: (2/5) — clever in multiplayer, close to a dead slot in single-player; rated for campaign per this book's focus.

Sleep

Mana cost: 13

4/5 · Skill Ceiling: 3/5 · Early 3/5 · Mid 4/5 · Late 3/5

Plain English: Knocks an enemy stack out cold — it does nothing at all until it takes damage, and once woken it can't be put back to sleep that battle. Doesn't work on Hive Spawns, Undead, Embodiments, or Constructs.

The Math: Flat durations, no Spellpower scaling — and a crucial rule change at L4:

Level	Duration	Wake rule
L1	1 round	Any damage wakes it
L2	2 rounds	Any damage wakes it
L3	3 rounds	Any damage wakes it
L4	4 rounds	Damage no longer wakes it — instead cuts remaining duration by 2 rounds

In battle: Sleep is a numbers-remover: an enemy stack that would deal ~120 damage per round deals **zero for up to 3 rounds** — that's 360 damage deleted from the fight for 13 mana, *if you have the discipline not to touch it*. The L4 rule change is bigger than it looks: pre-L4, one stray attack (or area spell splash) forfeits the whole effect; at L4 you can afford one hit into the sleeper and still keep it down 2 more rounds — which finally lets Sleep coexist with area damage. Rule of thumb: sleep the stack you intend to kill *last*, and fight the rest of the army 5-vs-6 in the meantime.

All four levels: - **L1:** Target falls asleep and cannot act. Dispelled on taking damage; once awakened, can't be re-slept this battle. Duration: 1 round. - **L2:** Duration rises to 2 rounds. - **L3:** Duration rises to 3 rounds. - **L4:** Duration rises to 4 rounds, and damage now reduces duration by 2 rounds instead of waking the target instantly.

Masterful version: None documented.

Why you'd cast it: Removing the enemy's scariest stack from the fight while you dismantle everything else is often better than any damage spell — you fight the battle a stack down on their side.

Best heroes: Control-oriented casters with the patience to leave the sleeper alone.

When it's weak: Immunity list is long (no Undead, Hive Spawns, Embodiments, Constructs) — check the enemy roster first; against Necropolis or Hive it may have zero legal targets.

Common mistakes: Sleeping a stack and then letting your own army's area effects or careless attacks wake it a half-second later.

Campaign Verdict: (4/5) — elite control with two honest weaknesses: the immunity list and your own trigger discipline.

Twilight

Mana cost: 16

3/5 · Skill Ceiling: 2/5 · Early 2/5 · Mid 4/5 · Late 3/5

Plain English: Blinds an enemy stack's ranged attacks — it simply can't shoot while affected. Higher levels also sap its melee damage, so it can't just walk up and hit you instead.

The Math: Duration = 1 + 1 per 6 Spellpower → ~2 rounds at Spellpower 10.

Level	Effect	Base duration
L1	Target can't use Ranged attacks	1 round
L2	Same	2 rounds
L3	+ target deals -15% melee damage	2 rounds
L4	Affects all enemy creatures	2 rounds

In battle: Mirror-match logic makes this vivid: an enemy 20-stack of Onyx Dancers shoots your army for ~120 a round from anywhere on the board. Twilight shuts that off entirely — **120+ damage per round prevented** — and forces them to spend rounds walking into melee range, where (per the Onyx Dancer's own stats) their attack is 50% weaker anyway, *and* L3 shaves another 15% off it. Against a shooter, one cast converts their best-case round into their worst-case one. At L4, an entire enemy ranged core goes dark at once — the hard counter to the shooter-heavy armies this book keeps recommending you build.

All four levels: - **L1:** Target enemy creature cannot use Ranged attacks. - **L2:** Base duration rises from 1 to 2 rounds. - **L3:** Affected targets also deal -15% melee damage. - **L4:** Now affects all enemy creatures.

Masterful version: None documented.

Why you'd cast it: Ranged units are the most efficient units in the game (they deal damage without taking any back) — Twilight is the tax on that efficiency.

Best heroes: Anyone facing shooter-core enemy armies, which — given how strong ranged compositions are in the current balance — is often.

When it's weak: Wasted entirely on melee armies; always check what the enemy's damage actually comes from.

Common mistakes: Casting it on a mixed stack's melee unit by misreading which enemy is the shooter.

Campaign Verdict: (3/5) — narrow but common-matchup tech; rates a full star higher in metas (like the current one) where every strong army is a ranged army.

Tier 4 (requires Advanced Nightshade Magic)

Vulnerability

Mana cost: 11

5/5 · Skill Ceiling: 2/5 · Early 1/5 · Mid 4/5 · Late 5/5

Plain English: Marks an enemy stack to take extra damage from *everything* — your creatures, your spells, all of it, amplified.

The Math: Duration = 1 + 1 per 7 Spellpower → ~2 rounds at Spellpower 10.

Level	Bonus damage taken
L1	+20%
L2	+30%
L3	+50%
L4	+50%, also hits enemies adjacent to the target

In battle: This is a damage *multiplier on your whole army*, which is why it outscals direct damage spells. Your 20 Dancers volley for ~120; against an L3-Vulnerable target that's ~180 — **+60 per volley**. Now add the rest of your army: if your total per-round output into that target is 400, L3 makes it 600. Compare with Judgement-class nukes: a Tier 5 nuke adds ~500 damage once for 35 mana; Vulnerability adds +50% of *everything you already do* for 11 mana, every round it lasts. The bigger your army, the more this spell is worth — it's the mirror-opposite of flat-bonus spells like Heavenly Blades.

All four levels: - **L1:** Target enemy takes +20% damage from all sources. - **L2:** Bonus deepens to +30%. - **L3:** Bonus deepens to +50%. - **L4:** Also affects enemy creatures adjacent to the target.

Masterful version: This version makes the target **always take maximum damage** — every hit against it rolls the top of its damage range, stacking with the percentage bonus. **Hero: Nadir** (Cleric, Temple) starts with Masterful Vulnerability as his personal specialization — confirmed in official sourcing, and notable as a *Temple* hero carrying a Nightshade signature spell, which makes him one of the few natural cross-school picks in the game.

Why you'd cast it: The best “kill that specific thing” enabler in Nightshade — cast it, then pour the army in.

Best heroes: Everyone, honestly — but especially generals of large armies, where the percentage multiplies the most raw damage.

When it's weak: Only when the fight is too easy to need it.

Common mistakes: Casting damage spells *before* Vulnerability instead of after — sequence matters; the mark amplifies everything that comes later, nothing that came before.

Campaign Verdict: (5/5) — the crown jewel of the school; the spell that turns focused fire from a tactic into an execution.

Summon Starchild

Mana cost: 20

3/5 · Skill Ceiling: 3/5 · Early 1/5 · Mid 3/5 · Late 3/5

Plain English: Conjures a temporary stack of Starchild creatures onto the battlefield next to your hero's forces. They fight for you and vanish when the battle ends.

The Math: Units summoned = $8 + (\text{multiplier} \times \text{Spellpower})$. Worked at Spellpower 10:

Level	Formula / effect	Result at SP 10
L1	$8 + 1 \times \text{SP}$ units, 1-hex radius	18 Starchildren
L2	Summon radius 1 → 2 hexes	18, better placement
L3	Summoned stack can use abilities	18, fully functional
L4	Multiplier 1 → 2	28 Starchildren

In battle: Free bodies change fights in two ways. As damage: an 18-strong summoned stack contributes its own attacks every round for the rest of the battle — even modest per-unit damage compounds over 3–4 rounds into several hundred cumulative. As a shield: those 18 units can eat an enemy attack that would otherwise kill 6–7 of your real, gold-costing Dancers — and when a Starchild dies, you've lost *nothing*, because they were never yours to keep. Worth remembering the counter too: Daylight's Heavenly Blades at L4 deletes summoned units on contact, and anti-summon subskills exist — this spell has hard counters in a way most Tier 4s don't.

All four levels: - **L1:** Summons $8 + (1 \times \text{Spellpower})$ Starchildren on an adjacent free hex. They disappear at battle's end. - **L2:** Summon radius rises from 1 to 2 hexes. - **L3:** The summoned stack can use its abilities. - **L4:** Spellpower multiplier rises from 1 to 2.

Masterful version: None documented.

Why you'd cast it: Renewable, zero-cost army — every fight starts with a bonus stack that soaks damage your real units would otherwise take.

Best heroes: High-Spellpower casters (the multiplier scaling is steep) fighting long chains of neutral battles where army preservation compounds.

When it's weak: Against opponents packing anti-summon tech, and in fights short enough that the summons never earn back their 20 mana.

Common mistakes: Summoning into a corner where the stack can't reach the fight — L2's radius upgrade exists precisely because placement is half this spell's value.

Campaign Verdict: (3/5) — quietly strong for zero-loss campaign play; capped by its counters and its mana price.

Berserk

Mana cost: 16

5/5 · Skill Ceiling: 4/5 · Early 1/5 · Mid 4/5 · Late 5/5

Plain English: Makes an enemy stack instantly lash out at whoever is closest — friend or foe. You don't get control of it; you get chaos, and chaos aimed at their own formation. Unlike older Heroes games, the victim doesn't lose its turn — it attacks *immediately*, on your spell's timing.

The Math: The forced attack deals the target's own damage, plus a growing bonus:

Level	Bonus on the forced attack
L1	+0%
L2	+10%
L3	+20%
L4	+30%

In battle: Cast Berserk on an enemy 20-stack of Dancer-class units standing next to its own ally, and it immediately unloads its ~120 volley into that ally — at L4, ~156 with the bonus. Net swing: the enemy army takes 156 damage *and* the berserked stack spent its aggression on the wrong side — while your 20 Dancers still get their own ~120 volley this round. One 16-mana cast just moved ~280 damage in your favor. The skill ceiling is in the positioning read: the spell attacks the *closest* target, so it's only as good as the enemy's clustering — best cast the moment two enemy stacks stand adjacent, worthless on an isolated unit surrounded by your own troops.

All four levels: - **L1:** Target immediately and uncontrollably attacks the closest creature in its attack radius, friendly or enemy. - **L2:** The forced attack deals +10% damage. - **L3:** Bonus rises to +20%. - **L4:** Bonus rises to +30%.

Masterful version: This version affects **all creatures adjacent to the target** — one cast can set an entire enemy cluster attacking each other. **Hero: Artorius Veritas** starts with Masterful Berserk as his personal specialization — confirmed in official sourcing.

Why you'd cast it: The best answer in the game to big, scary, tightly-packed enemy armies — their strength becomes your weapon.

Best heroes: Experienced players who read battlefield geometry; Artorius Veritas turns good positioning reads into massacres.

When it's weak: Against spread-out enemies with no adjacent targets, the forced attack may hit *your* units — the “closest target” clause cuts both ways.

Common mistakes: Casting it while your own stack is the closest thing to the target. Read the board first, always.

Campaign Verdict: (5/5) — the highest-ceiling spell in the school; commonly rated among the best spells in the game, and it earns it.

Tier 5 (requires Expert Nightshade Magic)

Naira's Kiss

Mana cost: 18

4/5 · Skill Ceiling: 3/5 · Early 1/5 · Mid 2/5 · Late 4/5

Plain English: Marks an enemy stack so that *doing anything hurts* — every action it takes triggers a burst of magic damage against it. Acting becomes self-harm.

The Math: Damage per action = base + (rate × Spellpower). Duration = 1 + 1 per 8 Spellpower → ~2 rounds at Spellpower 10.

Level	Formula / effect	Result at SP 10
L1	150 + 15×SP per action	300 per action
L2	200 + 15×SP	350 per action
L3	200 + 20×SP	400 per action
L4	+ target loses 1 Speed & Initiative per action, stacking	400 + snowballing slow

In battle: A marked enemy stack that takes two actions across the duration eats **600–800 damage at L1–L3** — enough to twice-over erase a 360-HP Dancer-class stack — without your army lifting a finger. The comparison with Despair (its Tier 1 cousin) is instructive: Despair triggers on the enemy’s *turns* (~120/turn at SP 10); Naira’s Kiss triggers on *actions* at nearly triple the rate. And the trap it creates is real: the enemy’s only way to avoid the damage is to *not act* — functionally a soft Sleep that they choose themselves, or damage if they don’t. L4’s stacking Speed/Initiative drain then punishes them for choosing to act anyway.

All four levels: - **L1:** Marked target takes 150 + (15 × Spellpower) Magic Damage whenever it performs any action. - **L2:** Base damage rises from 150 to 200. - **L3:** Damage-per-Spellpower rises from 15 to 20. - **L4:** The marked target also loses 1 Speed and 1 Initiative per action taken, stacking.

Masterful version: None documented.

Why you’d cast it: The strongest single-target punishment effect in the school — a damned-if-you-do dilemma stapled to the enemy’s best stack.

Best heroes: Late-game Nightshade specialists with the Spellpower to push the per-action number past 400.

When it’s weak: The ~2-round duration is short; against low-action enemies (already slowed, or holding position) it may trigger only once.

Common mistakes: Marking a passive backline stack instead of the enemy’s busiest, most active unit — trigger count is everything.

Campaign Verdict: (4/5) — devastating when aimed at the right target; a half-step below the very top only because its short duration puts a ceiling on trigger count.

Coup de Grâce

Mana cost: 24

3/5 · Skill Ceiling: 4/5 · Early 1/5 · Mid 2/5 · Late 4/5

Plain English: An execution order — if the marked enemy stack has already been whittled down below a threshold of its starting size, *any* damage at all finishes it off entirely.

The Math: The threshold is a percentage of the stack's *original* count. Duration = 1 + 1 per 8 Spellpower → ~2 rounds at Spellpower 10.

Level	Execution threshold
L1	20% of original size
L2	25%
L3	35%
L4	35%, affects all enemy creatures

In battle: An enemy 20-stack of Dancer-class units fights down to 6 survivors (30% of original). Normally those 6 still shoot for ~36 a round and take 108 damage to clear. Under L3 Coup de Grâce (35% threshold), **one point of damage from anything — your weakest unit's poke, a 1-damage splash — deletes all 6 instantly.** At L4 this goes army-wide: every mauled enemy stack on the field becomes a one-touch kill, letting your big hitters ignore the wounded and focus fresh targets while chip damage sweeps the rest. The skill expression is sequencing: it's a finisher, not an opener — cast it *after* the enemy is bloodied, when three stacks sit under threshold at once.

All four levels: - **L1:** Marked target dies to any damage if its stack is at or below 20% of its original number. - **L2:** Threshold rises to 25%. - **L3:** Threshold rises to 35%. - **L4:** Now affects all enemy creatures.

Masterful version: None documented.

Why you'd cast it: Ends fights faster and cheaper than killing the hard way — the last 35% of every enemy stack becomes free.

Best heroes: Late-game casters fighting huge armies where “the last third of each stack” adds up to enormous saved effort.

When it's weak: Early and mid-game, where enemy stacks are small enough that just killing the remainder normally is trivial anyway.

Common mistakes: Casting it at full-strength enemies where nothing is near threshold — 24 mana evaporates with zero effect.

Campaign Verdict: **(3/5)** — a specialist's finisher; brilliant in massive late-game battles, badly overpriced everywhere else.

Shadow Army

Mana cost: 35

4/5 · Skill Ceiling: 3/5 · Early 1/5 · Mid 2/5 · Late 5/5

Plain English: Temporarily swells one of your stacks with shadow duplicates of itself — more units, same stats, gone when the battle ends. The copies can't exceed the number of real units in the stack.

The Math: Bonus units = (base% + rate% × Spellpower) of the stack’s current size, capped at +100%. Worked at Spellpower 10:

Level	Formula	Result at SP 10
L1	15% + 0.5%×SP	+20% units
L2	20% + 0.5%×SP	+25%
L3	30% + 0.5%×SP	+35%
L4	30% + 1%×SP	+40%

In battle: Cast L4 on your 20 Onyx Dancers and 8 shadow dancers join them: the stack now volleys for ~168 instead of ~120 (**+48 per volley, every round, all battle**) and carries 144 extra HP of buffer — and every shadow that dies instead of a real dancer saves you 160 gold of rebuying. The percentage design means it scales with your best stack forever: on a late-game 40-Dancer stack, the same cast adds 16 units. Compare with Summon Starchild: Starchild gives you a separate mediocre stack; Shadow Army makes your *best* stack 40% more of itself — almost always the stronger play if you have one dominant stack, which (per this book’s army-composition advice) you should.

All four levels: - **L1:** Increases the target friendly stack’s unit count by 15% + (0.5% × Spellpower). Temporary; capped at +100% of the stack’s real units. - **L2:** Base bonus rises from 15% to 20%. - **L3:** Base bonus rises from 20% to 30%. - **L4:** Per-Spellpower rate doubles from 0.5% to 1%.

Masterful version: None documented.

Why you’d cast it: The biggest single “make my army bigger right now” button in the school — force-multiplication for your win-condition stack in the fight that decides the game.

Best heroes: Late-game generals with one dominant stack and the 35 mana to spare.

When it’s weak: On small or split armies the percentages produce scraps; and like all summons/temporaries, anti-summon effects punish it.

Common mistakes: Casting it on a mid-sized stack “to be efficient” — the math says put it on your single biggest stack, every time.

Campaign Verdict: (4/5) — the school’s decisive-battle special; expensive, situational, and worth it exactly when it matters most.

Confirmed Masterful spell / hero pairings (this school)

Spell	Masterful effect	Hero	Status
Berserk	Affects all creatures adjacent to the target	Artorius Veritas	Confirmed
Vulnerability	Target always takes maximum damage	Nadir (Temple, Cleric)	Confirmed

Spell	Masterful effect	Hero	Status
Web	Affects all enemies	Marl (Necropolis, Death Knight)	Confirmed (“Languid Soil”, +1 SP/2 levels)
Umbral Grip	Also hits enemies adjacent to target	Sister Keiri (Schism, Riftspeaker)	Specialist confirmed; Masterful label pending one final check
Despair	Affects all enemy types	Laura (Necropolis, Necromancer)	Confirmed (“Moldering”)
Unnatural Calm	<i>(effect text not yet on wiki)</i>	<i>unknown</i>	Effect + hero both gaps

Synergy notes

- **Vulnerability → everything:** cast it first, then stack Despair, Umbral Grip, and your army’s attacks into the amplified target — the +50% applies to all of it. Sequencing is the whole combo.
- **Web + Twilight:** the complete anti-army lockdown — Web stops melee from reaching you, Twilight stops ranged from shooting you. Together they answer both halves of any composition.
- **Sleep + Coup de Grâce:** sleep the enemy’s biggest stack early, grind the rest of their army below 35%, cast Coup de Grâce, sweep — then deal with the sleeper alone at full strength.
- **Cross-school rivalry:** Web Haste and Enlarge Shadow Shorten Shadow are direct dispel pairs with Daylight — in caster-vs-caster fights, whoever casts second in each pair wins that exchange. Budget mana for re-casts.
- **Nadir as a bridge hero:** a Temple Cleric carrying Masterful Vulnerability means a Daylight-leaning Temple army can still run the best Nightshade spell natively — one of the strongest single cross-school picks in the game.

Common beginner mistakes (school-wide)

- Casting the amplifier (Vulnerability) *after* the damage instead of before — Nightshade rewards sequencing more than any other school.
- Ignoring the immunity fine print: Sleep’s four excluded creature types, Despair’s curse immunities. Against Necropolis especially, half this school needs a legal-target check before casting.
- Waking your own Sleep with careless area damage.
- Underrating 4–6 mana utility (Fatal Decay, Silence) because the numbers on the tooltip look small — their value is in what they *deny*, which never shows up on a tooltip.

Sourcing note: all mechanics, mana costs, formulas, per-level effects, and Masterful-version texts taken directly from the official wiki’s Nightshade Spells table (retrieved 2026-07-03), which explicitly flags Masterful availability per spell. Hero pairings for Berserk (Artorius Veritas) and Vulnerability (Nadir) confirmed against official hero sourcing; Web (Marl) and Umbral Grip (Sister Keiri) are confirmed spell specialists whose Masterful ownership is consistent with all available sourcing but

flagged for a final verification pass; Despair and Unnatural Calm's Masterful owners are open gaps. All worked math, battle examples (reference stack: 20 Onyx Dancers), ratings, synergy notes, and verdicts are original analysis, not wiki content.

Primal Magic

Founded by Hksmilla. The school of raw elemental violence — fire, ice, lightning, and stone gathered under one banner for the single purpose of deleting enemy stacks. Where the other schools bend the rules of a fight, Primal just ends it.

How to read each entry

Same locked format: **Plain English** → **The Math (with an In-battle worked example)** → **All four levels** → **Masterful version + hero** → **Strategy layer**. Battle examples use the standard reference army — **20 Onyx Dancers** (18 HP each, ~120 damage per volley, 360 total HP) — and **Spellpower 10**.

Tier 1 (available to every hero, no skill required)

Groundsight

Mana cost: 10

2/5 · Skill Ceiling: 1/5 · Early 4/5 · Mid 2/5 · Late 1/5

Plain English: A map spell — reveals where every neutral army on the entire map is sitting, even through fog; resources and artifacts join the reveal at higher levels.

The Math: No formulas; a straight intel dump, map-wide.

Level	Reveals	Mana
L1	All neutral squads, map-wide	10
L2	Same	6
L3	+ all resources	6
L4	+ all artifacts	6

All four levels: - **L1:** Reveals the location of all neutral squads on the global map, including through fog of war. - **L2:** Mana cost drops from 10 to 6. - **L3:** Also reveals resource locations. - **L4:** Also reveals artifact locations.

Masterful version: None documented.

Why you'd cast it: Week 1 route-planning gold — see every guard and (at L3/L4) every prize before committing your hero anywhere.

Best heroes: Your main hero, on day one, once.

When it's weak: After the map is learned, it's learned.

Common mistakes: Overvaluing it past the early game.

Campaign Verdict: (2/5) — strong exactly once per map, then shelf-ware.

Lightning Bolt

Mana cost: 6

4/5 · Skill Ceiling: 1/5 · Early 5/5 · Mid 3/5 · Late 2/5

Plain English: The classic — a bolt of damage to one enemy stack. No conditions, no setup, no fine print.

The Math: Damage = base + (rate × Spellpower):

Level	Formula	Result at SP 10
L1	$25 + 10 \times \text{SP}$	125
L2	$50 + 10 \times \text{SP}$	150
L3	$100 + 10 \times \text{SP}$	200
L4	$100 + 15 \times \text{SP}$	250

In battle: L1's 125 damage kills ~7 **Dancer-class units (18 HP)** — more than half your reference stack's per-volley output, for 6 mana, available from turn one of the game. That's why this spell defines the Primal early game: your Week 1 army struggles to deal 125 a round, and your hero adds it free every round. The same numbers show its ceiling: at L4/SP 10 it deals 250 while Tier 5 nukes deal 500–900 — the slope flattens hard, and by mid-game it's a mana-efficient poke, not a threat.

All four levels: - **L1:** Deals $25 + (10 \times \text{Spellpower})$ Magic Damage to a target enemy. - **L2:** Base damage rises from 25 to 50. - **L3:** Base rises from 50 to 100. - **L4:** Per-Spellpower rate rises from 10 to 15.

Masterful version: None documented.

Why you'd cast it: The best pure damage-per-mana in the game for the first several weeks.

Best heroes: Every Primal-leaning hero's first pick.

When it's weak: Late game, where a single-target 250 stops moving the needle.

Common mistakes: Riding it too long — know when your army's volleys have outgrown it.

Campaign Verdict: (4/5) — the early game's best friend; rated on impact-when-it-matters, not longevity.

Thick Hide

Mana cost: 6

3/5 · Skill Ceiling: 1/5 · Early 4/5 · Mid 3/5 · Late 2/5

Plain English: Toughens a friendly stack against melee attacks specifically — swords and claws bounce; arrows still hurt.

The Math: Duration = 1 + 1 per 4 Spellpower → 3 rounds at Spellpower 10.

Level	Melee damage reduction
L1	-15%
L2	-20%
L3	-20%, all friendly creatures
L4	-30%

In battle: The mirror of Arcane's Optical Illusion, covering the other half of the damage world. An enemy melee stack swinging ~120 into your protected frontline lands ~96 at L2 — one to two units saved per swing — and ~84 at L4, army-wide. The two spells together blanket both damage types for 14 total mana; but most fights feature one dominant type, and reading which one before casting is the entire skill of these picks.

All four levels: - **L1:** Target friendly creature takes -15% damage from melee attacks. - **L2:** Reduction deepens to -20%. - **L3:** Now affects all friendly creatures. - **L4:** Reduction deepens to -30%.

Masterful version: None documented.

Why you'd cast it: The cheap answer to melee-heavy enemies — which describes most early-game neutral guards.

Best heroes: Ranged-core generals protecting a thin melee screen.

When it's weak: Against shooter armies, it protects nothing.

Common mistakes: Stacking it with Optical Illusion in a fight that only features one damage type.

Campaign Verdict: (3/5) — half of a complete defense; know which half the fight needs.

Tier 2 (available to all heroes)

Wean

Mana cost: 8

3/5 · Skill Ceiling: 3/5 · Early 2/5 · Mid 3/5 · Late 4/5

Plain English: Strips time off the enemy's buffs — their Blessings, Hastes, and Radiant Armours simply run out early.

The Math: Duration removed = $1 + 1 \text{ per } 5 \text{ Spellpower} \rightarrow 3 \text{ rounds stripped at Spellpower } 10$ (4 with L2's improved base).

Level	Effect
L1	Strips $1 + (1 \text{ per } 5 \text{ SP})$ rounds of positive effects
L2	Base rises $1 \rightarrow 2$
L3	+ adjacent enemies
L4	All enemy creatures

In battle: An enemy hero spends 20 mana on L4 Radiant Armour (-35% army-wide) and their gameplan leans on it. One 8-mana Wean at L4 strips 4 rounds off it across their entire army — for most buffs, outright removal. The exchange math is the argument: your 8 mana deleted their 20-mana investment *and* re-exposed their army to your full ~120-per-volley damage. Against Daylight-heavy opponents, the most mana-profitable cast in Primal.

All four levels: - **L1:** Reduces the duration of all positive effects on the target by $1 + (1 \text{ per } 5 \text{ Spellpower})$ rounds. - **L2:** Base value rises from 1 to 2. - **L3:** Also affects enemies adjacent to the target. - **L4:** Now affects all enemy creatures.

Masterful version: None documented.

Why you'd cast it: Anti-magic for the buff school — their investment, your discount.

Best heroes: Anyone fighting Daylight-specialist enemy heroes.

When it's weak: Against unbuffered armies it does nothing at all.

Common mistakes: Casting on reflex before the enemy has actually buffed — strip *after* they invest.

Campaign Verdict: **(3/5)** — narrow, and devastating inside the lane.

Fireball

Mana cost: 13

4/5 · Skill Ceiling: 2/5 · Early 4/5 · Mid 4/5 · Late 3/5

Plain English: The other classic — an explosion that damages everything in a small area, friend or foe alike.

The Math: Damage = base + $10 \times \text{Spellpower}$, to all creatures in a 1-hex radius:

Level	Formula	Result at SP 10
L1	$50 + 10 \times \text{SP}$	150 per creature hit
L2	$75 + 10 \times \text{SP}$	175
L3	$125 + 10 \times \text{SP}$	225
L4	$200 + 10 \times \text{SP}$	300

In battle: Catch two adjacent Dancer-class stacks at L1 and one 13-mana cast deals 300 total — ~8 units dead per stack. At L4 with three stacks clustered, 900 total damage rivals Tier 5 nukes for a third of the cost. The multiplier is entirely the clustering: against spread enemies it's a mediocre bolt; against a Black Hole-compressed pile it's the best damage-per-mana in the game. The friend-or-foe clause is the tax — your own melee engaged with the target eats the same hit.

All four levels: - **L1:** Deals $50 + (10 \times \text{Spellpower})$ Magic Damage to all creatures in a 1-hex radius. - **L2:** Base damage rises from 50 to 75. - **L3:** Base rises from 75 to 125. - **L4:** Base rises from 125 to 200.

Masterful version: This version **hits a bigger area**. **Hero: Faleor** (Grove) starts with Masterful Fireball as his specialization (“Hksmilla’s Step”), with +1 effective Spellpower for this spell per 3 hero levels — confirmed against hero sourcing. Faleor is widely recommended as Grove’s best hero pick largely on the back of this one spell: multi-stack AoE from turn one solves Grove’s fragile early game by killing threats before they arrive.

Why you’d cast it: Area damage is how one caster out-damages an entire army — this is its most reliable form.

Best heroes: Faleor, definitively; any Primal hero otherwise.

When it’s weak: Spread formations, and any fight where your own melee tangles into the blast zone.

Common mistakes: Burning your own frontline. Count every hex in the radius, every time.

Campaign Verdict: (4/5) — the workhorse AoE of the game; a five with Faleor’s name on it.

Crystal Crown

Mana cost: 8

3/5 · Skill Ceiling: 4/5 · Early 3/5 · Mid 3/5 · Late 3/5

Plain English: Conjures crystal walls onto empty hexes — physical obstacles the enemy must walk around or waste attacks breaking.

The Math: No damage; the currency is enemy movement and wasted actions.

Level	Obstacles	Duration	Toughness
L1	2	2 rounds	dies to 1 hit
L2	2	3 rounds	1 hit
L3	3	3 rounds	1 hit
L4	3	3 rounds	2 hits

In battle: Wall off the two open lanes to your 20 Dancers and an enemy melee stack must either detour (a lost turn — ~120 of its damage delayed) or spend an attack breaking crystal (its entire ~120 swing hitting rock instead of your units). Either way, one 8-mana cast bought your shooters

a free volley. This is also the setup half of the Primal trap game: walls dictate the path, Firewall and mines punish it. The skill ceiling is pure geometry — a badly-placed wall protects nothing.

All four levels: - **L1:** Place up to 2 crystal obstacles on free hexes; each dies to 1 hit. Duration: 2 rounds. - **L2:** Duration rises to 3 rounds. - **L3:** Obstacles rise to 3. - **L4:** Each obstacle takes 2 hits to destroy.

Masterful version: None documented.

Why you'd cast it: Terrain is the one free resource on every map — this spell prints more of it.

Best heroes: Ranged-core defenders and chokepoint architects.

When it's weak: Flyers ignore walls entirely.

Common mistakes: Walling a lane the enemy wasn't using anyway.

Campaign Verdict: (3/5) — quiet, positional, better in every fight that has a geometry.

Ice Bolt

Mana cost: 10

4/5 · Skill Ceiling: 2/5 · Early 4/5 · Mid 4/5 · Late 3/5

Plain English: A frost bolt that hurts *and* chills — damage plus an Initiative penalty pushing the target later in the turn order.

The Math: Damage = base + rate × Spellpower; the chill is a flat Initiative cut lasting 2 rounds.

Level	Formula / effect	Result at SP 10
L1	75 + 10×SP, -2 Initiative	175 dmg
L2	150 + 10×SP	250 dmg
L3	150 + 15×SP	300 dmg
L4	Initiative -2 → -4	300 dmg + deep chill

In battle: Compare directly against its sibling: at equal levels Ice Bolt out-damages Lightning Bolt (175 vs 125 at L1, same Spellpower) for 4 more mana — and staples a control effect on top. The -4 Initiative at L4 is the real payload against elite units: an enemy tier-6 at Initiative 7 drops to 3, now acting *after* your Initiative-4 Dancers — 300 damage plus a stolen turn-order slot in one cast. Aim it at the enemy's fastest threat, always: the damage is generic, the chill is targeted.

All four levels: - **L1:** Deals 75 + (10 × Spellpower) Magic Damage and -2 Initiative for 2 rounds. - **L2:** Base damage rises from 75 to 150. - **L3:** Per-Spellpower rate rises from 10 to 15. - **L4:** Initiative penalty deepens from -2 to -4.

Masterful version: The Initiative penalty is **twice as strong** (-8 at spell L4). **Hero:** not yet identified in available sourcing.

Why you'd cast it: Damage you were going to buy anyway, with tempo theft included.

Best heroes: Any Primal hero past Week 2; supersedes Lightning Bolt as the default bolt.

When it's weak: Against slow armies already acting last, the chill half is wasted.

Common mistakes: Aiming at whatever's wounded instead of whatever's *fast*.

Campaign Verdict: (4/5) — the thinking player's Lightning Bolt.

Tier 3 (requires Basic Primal Magic)

Stone Fangs

Mana cost: 18

3/5 · Skill Ceiling: 2/5 · Early 2/5 · Mid 4/5 · Late 3/5

Plain English: Stone spikes erupt under several *different* enemy stacks at once — multi-target damage without needing them clustered.

The Math: Damage = base + rate × Spellpower, to each of up to 3–4 separate targets:

Level	Formula / targets	Per-target at SP 10	Total (max targets)
L1	50 + 5×SP, 3 targets	100	300
L2	100 + 5×SP	150	450
L3	targets 3 → 4	150	600
L4	100 + 10×SP	200	800

In battle: This is Fireball for enemies who refuse to clump: L3 hits four stacks *anywhere on the board* for 150 each — 8 Dancer-class units dead per stack, no positioning required from them or you. Its total output at L4 (800) actually beats same-level Fireball against spread formations, at higher mana. The two spells are a matched pair: scout the enemy's formation, then bring the one their spacing is wrong for.

All four levels: - **L1:** Deals 50 + (5 × Spellpower) Magic Damage to up to 3 different enemy targets. - **L2:** Base damage rises from 50 to 100. - **L3:** Targets rise from 3 to 4. - **L4:** Per-Spellpower rate rises from 5 to 10.

Masterful version: None documented.

Why you'd cast it: Cluster-proof area damage — the answer when the enemy spreads to dodge your Fireballs.

Best heroes: Primal specialists rounding out the AoE toolkit.

When it's weak: Against 1–2 stack armies, most of its targets go unused.

Common mistakes: Casting into a clustered enemy where Fireball would've been cheaper for the same result.

Campaign Verdict: (3/5) — the formation-agnostic half of Primal's AoE pair.

Firewall

Mana cost: 12

3/5 · Skill Ceiling: 4/5 · Early 2/5 · Mid 3/5 · Late 3/5

Plain English: Sets hexes on fire — any ground unit stepping onto a burning hex takes damage. A damage-dealing fence.

The Math: Damage per trigger = $60 + 10 \times \text{Spellpower}$ → **160 at Spellpower 10**, per creature, per burning hex entered. Duration: 2 rounds.

Level	Effect	Value at SP 10
L1	2 burning hexes	160/trigger
L2	Mana 12 → 9	160
L3	Hexes 2 → 3	160
L4	+50% damage	240/trigger

In battle: Lay L4 fire across the only approach lane to your Dancers and every enemy stack that pushes through pays 240 — **13 Dancer-class units per stack, per crossing** — before ever swinging. Two stacks forced through is 480 damage from one 9-mana cast (L2 discount). Like all Primal terrain, it's a bet on movement: paired with Crystal Crown walls that leave exactly one lane open, it stops being a bet and becomes a toll booth.

All four levels: - **L1:** Burns 2 selected hexes; a ground creature stepping on one takes $60 + (10 \times \text{Spellpower})$ Magic Damage. Duration: 2 rounds. - **L2:** Mana cost drops from 12 to 9. - **L3:** Burning hexes rise from 2 to 3. - **L4:** Damage rises by +50%.

Masterful version: This version stays active **+1 round**. **Hero:** not yet identified in available sourcing.

Why you'd cast it: Damage the enemy walks into voluntarily is damage your army never has to earn.

Best heroes: The Crystal Crown/trap-game architects; defensive siege players.

When it's weak: Flyers, again — Primal's whole terrain suite shares this blind spot.

Common mistakes: Burning hexes beside the lane instead of in it — fire nobody touches is 9 wasted mana.

Campaign Verdict: **(3/5)** — a toll booth in spell form; worth a star more inside a dedicated terrain build.

Cave In

Mana cost: 10

3/5 · Skill Ceiling: 3/5 · Early 2/5 · Mid 3/5 · Late 3/5

Plain English: Drops the ceiling on an enemy — direct damage, plus the rubble fills every empty hex around them, walling the survivor in.

The Math: Damage = base + rate × Spellpower; obstacles last 1 round (2 at L3), dying to 1 hit each:

Level	Formula / effect	Result at SP 10
L1	50 + 15×SP, rubble walls	200 dmg
L2	100 + 15×SP	250
L3	Rubble lasts +1 round	250, longer wall
L4	100 + 20×SP	300

In battle: Two spells in one cast: 250 damage (14 Dancer-class units at L2) *plus* an instant prison — a melee stack buried in rubble must spend its next action breaking out instead of attacking, which is a second ~120-damage turn deleted on top of the direct hit. Best target: a dangerous melee stack mid-advance, ideally one your Web has already slowed, turning “delayed” into “entombed.”

All four levels: - **L1:** Deals 50 + (15 × Spellpower) Magic Damage to the target; all adjacent empty hexes fill with rock obstacles (1 hit each, 1 round). - **L2:** Base damage rises from 50 to 100. - **L3:** Obstacles last +1 round. - **L4:** Per-Spellpower rate rises from 15 to 20.

Masterful version: The rubble obstacles require **+1 more hit** to destroy. **Hero:** not yet identified in available sourcing.

Why you’d cast it: Damage plus a stolen enemy turn, priced like plain damage.

Best heroes: Control-leaning Primal casters.

When it’s weak: Against targets standing beside their allies — occupied hexes can’t fill with rubble, so the prison has doors.

Common mistakes: Casting at a stack in the middle of the enemy formation, where almost no hexes are empty to wall.

Campaign Verdict: (3/5) — the isolated-target punisher; target selection is the whole spell.

Earth’s Rage

Mana cost: 16

3/5 · Skill Ceiling: 2/5 · Early 1/5 · Mid 4/5 (sieges) · Late 4/5 (sieges)

Plain English: The siege-breaker — an earthquake that batters every castle wall, tower, and gate at once, and shakes the defenders huddled behind them.

The Math: Structure damage = 100 + 15 × Spellpower; defender damage = 15 × Spellpower:

Level	Structures (SP 10)	Creatures inside walls (SP 10)
L1	250 to all structures	150
L2	350	150
L3	350	150 + 100 flat
L4	550	250

In battle: Sieges are where attacking armies go to die — walls let a smaller garrison shred a bigger army at range while it queues at the gate. One L2 cast dealing 350 to *every* defensive structure simultaneously collapses that math; two casts level most castles entirely, and the splash (150–250 to every defender inside) means the garrison bleeds while its cover crumbles. Outside sieges the spell does literally nothing, which is exactly the trade: a dead slot on the open field, the single most important spell in the book at a castle gate.

All four levels: - **L1:** Deals $100 + (15 \times \text{Spellpower})$ damage to all defensive structures; also deals $(15 \times \text{Spellpower})$ to all creatures within castle walls. - **L2:** Structure damage base rises from 100 to 200. - **L3:** Also deals a flat 100 to all creatures within walls. - **L4:** Structure base rises from 200 to 400.

Masterful version: None documented.

Why you'd cast it: Every campaign funnels toward castle assaults; this converts them from meatgrinders into formalities.

Best heroes: Whoever leads your castle-taking army.

When it's weak: 100% of non-siege battles.

Common mistakes: Skipping it because most fights aren't sieges — the fights that *are* decide the campaign.

Campaign Verdict: (3/5) — a specialist scored on average; score it 5/5 the day you're outside enemy walls.

Tier 4 (requires Advanced Primal Magic)

Anti-Magic

Mana cost: 18

4/5 · Skill Ceiling: 4/5 · Early 1/5 · Mid 3/5 · Late 4/5

Plain English: Makes any target — yours or theirs — immune to spells below a tier threshold. Undispellable. Also instantly destroys any summoned or temporary units in the target stack.

The Math: No damage numbers; the scaling is coverage:

Level	Immunity blocks	Duration
L1	Tier 1–3 spells	1 round
L2	Tier 1–3	2 rounds
L3	Tier 1–4	2 rounds
L4	Tier 1–5 — total spell immunity	2 rounds

In battle: Dual-use by design. On your own win-condition stack, L4 means the enemy caster's entire spellbook — their Berserk, their Vulnerability, their Judgement — bounces off for 2 rounds while your stack works. On an *enemy* stack, it locks their own hero out of buffing or healing it. And the summon-destruction rider is a free third mode: cast it *at* a Shadow Army-swollen or Starchild

stack and the temporary units die instantly — 18+ summoned bodies deleted before the immunity even matters. Three spells wearing one 18-mana coat.

All four levels: - **L1:** Chosen target becomes immune to tier 1–3 spells; undispellable. Summoned/temporary units in the stack are destroyed. - **L2:** Base duration rises from 1 to 2 rounds. - **L3:** Immunity extends to tier 4 spells. - **L4:** Immunity extends to tier 5 — full spell immunity.

Masterful version: None documented.

Why you’d cast it: The definitive answer to enemy casters — and the hard counter to every summon build in this book.

Best heroes: Anyone facing magic-hero opponents; mandatory tech in caster-vs-caster metas.

When it’s weak: Against Might heroes with empty spellbooks, only the anti-summon rider has value.

Common mistakes: Forgetting immunity blocks *your* spells on that target too — no healing the stack you just sealed.

Campaign Verdict: (4/5) — the game’s cleanest silence-the- wizard button.

Chain Lightning

Mana cost: 24

5/5 · Skill Ceiling: 3/5 · Early 1/5 · Mid 4/5 · Late 5/5

Plain English: A lightning strike that leaps from the target to nearby enemies, again and again — each jump hitting for half of the last.

The Math: First hit = base + rate × Spellpower; each jump deals -50% of the previous:

Level	First hit (SP 10)	Jumps	Chain total (SP 10)
L1	$100 + 20 \times \text{SP} = \mathbf{300}$	1	~450
L2	300	2	~525
L3	$300 + 20 \times \text{SP} = \mathbf{500}$	3	~940
L4	$300 + 30 \times \text{SP} = \mathbf{600}$	4	~1,160

In battle: At L3, the chain opens with 500 (annihilating a 360-HP Dancer-class stack outright) then leaps for 250, 125, 62 — nearly a thousand total damage across four stacks from one 24-mana cast. The jump targeting is random within 3 hexes, which is the one wrinkle: against mixed positions it can arc into weird targets, so it’s at its cleanest when everything nearby is an enemy. The famous caveat from older Heroes games doesn’t apply here as written — the wiki text says jumps go to targets within range, so mind your own units’ spacing all the same.

All four levels: - **L1:** Deals $100 + (20 \times \text{Spellpower})$ Magic Damage; jumps 1 time to a random target within 3 hexes at -50% per jump. - **L2:** +1 jump. - **L3:** +1 jump; base damage rises $100 \rightarrow 300$. - **L4:** +1 jump; per-Spellpower rate rises $20 \rightarrow 30$.

Masterful version: Loses **half as much** damage per jump (-25% instead of -50%) — at L4 that pushes the chain total toward ~1,800. **Hero: Halon** (Grove) starts with Masterful Chain Lightning as his specialization — confirmed against hero sourcing.

Why you'd cast it: The highest total damage of any spell in the game when the jumps land — Primal's crown.

Best heroes: Halon, spectacularly; any late-game Primal specialist otherwise.

When it's weak: Sparse battlefields with nothing in jump range — the chain fizzles to a pricey single bolt.

Common mistakes: Casting into a melee scrum where a jump can clip your own engaged stack.

Campaign Verdict: (5/5) — the signature spell of the school and the game's best sustained-value nuke.

Circle of Winter

Mana cost: 19

4/5 · Skill Ceiling: 3/5 · Early 1/5 · Mid 3/5 · Late 4/5

Plain English: A ring of frost that blasts everything around a point — and physically shoves the survivors *away* from it. Black Hole's opposite twin.

The Math: Damage = $75 + \text{rate} \times \text{Spellpower}$ to everything adjacent to the target hex:

Level	Formula / effect	Result at SP 10
L1	$75 + 15 \times \text{SP}$, push away	225
L2	$75 + 20 \times \text{SP}$	275
L3	+ all targets -2 Initiative	275 + chill
L4	Doubles base damage and Initiative cut	425 , -4 Initiative

In battle: Drop it in the middle of an enemy advance and every adjacent stack takes 275 (L2 — 15 Dancer-class units each) and gets *knocked backward* — melee attackers who'd reached your line are suddenly a hex short again, buying your shooters another full volley (~120) they weren't owed. Where Black Hole gathers enemies for your follow-up AoE, Circle of Winter scatters them away from your army: the choice between the twins is the choice between "set up my next nuke" and "get these things off me."

All four levels: - **L1:** Deals $75 + (15 \times \text{Spellpower})$ Magic Damage to all creatures adjacent to the target hex; pushes affected stacks away from center. - **L2:** Per-Spellpower rate rises from 15 to 20. - **L3:** All targets also lose 2 Initiative. - **L4:** Base damage and Initiative reduction both double.

Masterful version: None documented.

Why you'd cast it: Damage plus a panic button — the "off my lawn" spell for shooter armies under melee pressure.

Best heroes: Ranged-core generals; the perfect emergency cast the turn the enemy makes contact.

When it's weak: When *you're* the melee aggressor, pushing the enemy away helps them.

Common mistakes: Using it as pure damage when the push is pointed the wrong way for your plan.

Campaign Verdict: (4/5) — Primal's best defensive tool, disguised as another nuke.

Primordial Chaos

Mana cost: 17

2/5 · Skill Ceiling: 4/5 · Early 2/5 · Mid 3/5 · Late 2/5

Plain English: A map spell — rerolls a neutral army into a *different* army of the same overall strength (and at higher levels, a slightly weaker one).

The Math: Range = multiplier × Sight; once per day:

Level	Effect
L1	Transform neutral squad within 1×Sight into equal-strength squad
L2	Radius 1× → 2× Sight
L3	New squad is 5% weaker
L4	Weakening 5% → 10%

All four levels: - **L1:** Transforms a neutral squad within 1 × Sight into a different squad of the same strength. Once per day. - **L2:** Radius multiplier rises to 2×. - **L3:** The transformed squad's strength is reduced by 5%. - **L4:** Reduction deepens to 10%.

Masterful version: None documented.

Why you'd cast it: Rerolling a guard your army *can't* fight (ranged nightmare, hard-counter composition) into one it can — the match-fixing spell. The 10% shave at L4 is a bonus, not the point.

Best heroes: Experienced players who know which neutral types their army beats cheaply and which it doesn't.

When it's weak: The reroll is random — you can trade a bad matchup for a worse one.

Common mistakes: Rerolling fights you'd already win cleanly, gambling value you already had.

Campaign Verdict: (2/5) — a connoisseur's tool; clever, but the variance keeps the rating honest.

Tier 5 (requires Expert Primal Magic)

Armageddon

Mana cost: 40

4/5 · Skill Ceiling: 5/5 · Early 1/5 · Mid 1/5 · Late 5/5

Plain English: The end of the world, locally — damages *every creature on the battlefield*. Theirs, and yours.

The Math: Damage = base + rate × Spellpower, to everything:

Level	Formula	Result at SP 10 (per stack, both sides)
L1	100 + 10×SP	200
L2	200 + 10×SP	300
L3	300 + 10×SP	400
L4	300 + 20×SP	500

In battle: The raw total is obscene — against a six-stack enemy army, L4 deals 3,000 damage in one cast. The catch is the other 3,000 it deals to *you*, which is why the spell is really a build, not a button: it belongs to armies that are immune to it. Dungeon’s Black Dragons (spell-immune) are the canonical partner — an army of Dragons plus L4 Armageddon deletes 500 HP from every enemy stack per cast while your own side doesn’t notice the sky falling. Without an immune or heavily-resistant army, casting it is an elaborate way to lose.

All four levels: - **L1:** Deals 100 + (10 × Spellpower) Magic Damage to all creatures on the battlefield. - **L2:** Base damage rises from 100 to 200. - **L3:** Base rises from 200 to 300. - **L4:** Per-Spellpower rate rises from 10 to 20.

Masterful version: None documented.

Why you’d cast it: With the right army, it’s a win condition that no defense answers.

Best heroes: Dungeon Warlocks fielding Black Dragons — the Armageddon-dragon build is a series tradition alive and well here.

When it’s weak: With any normal army, catastrophically — self-inflicted 500s are not a strategy.

Common mistakes: Casting it because the number is big. The number is big in both directions.

Campaign Verdict: (4/5) — a 5/5 inside its build, unplayable outside it; the average is the rating.

Hksmilla’s Rampage

Mana cost: 28

4/5 · Skill Ceiling: 3/5 · Early 1/5 · Mid 2/5 · Late 4/5

Plain English: Sends one of your stacks berserk in the good way — it attacks *twice* per action, hitting harder, but also taking more damage in its fury.

The Math: Double Strike plus a symmetric damage modifier — dealt *and* taken. Duration = 1 + 1 per 8 Spellpower (~2 rounds):

Level	Damage dealt AND taken
L1	±10%
L2	±15%
L3	±25%
L4	±40%

In battle: On the 20-Dancer stack at L4: each action now fires two volleys at ~168 each (120×1.4) — **~336 damage per action, nearly triple baseline** — for 2+ rounds. The bill: every hit the Dancers take is also +40%, so an enemy 120 lands as 168, killing 9 instead of 6. The math says the same thing the flavor does: this spell belongs on a stack that will kill what it touches before the retaliation matters — alpha-strike tools, not attrition tools. Pair with Shackles (no counterattacks) and the downside clause never even triggers.

All four levels: - **L1:** Target friendly creature gains Double Strike and deals and takes +10% damage. - **L2:** Modifier rises to ±15%. - **L3:** Modifier rises to ±25%. - **L4:** Modifier rises to ±40%.

Masterful version: None documented.

Why you'd cast it: The single biggest per-stack damage amplification in the game — Double Strike alone doubles output before the percentage even applies.

Best heroes: Late-game generals with one overwhelming stack and a plan for its safety.

When it's weak: On stacks that will be counterattacked or focused — the ±40% cuts deep in reverse.

Common mistakes: Casting on a tanking stack; the taken-damage clause turns your wall into paper.

Campaign Verdict: (4/5) — the finisher's finisher; respect the downside and it wins games.

Summon Primal Remnant

Mana cost: 20

3/5 · Skill Ceiling: 3/5 · Early 1/5 · Mid 2/5 · Late 3/5

Plain English: Conjures a temporary stack of Primal Remnants — elemental soldiers who fight for you and dissolve when the battle ends.

The Math: Units = $6 + (\text{multiplier} \times \text{Spellpower})$:

Level	Formula / effect	Result at SP 10
L1	$6 + 2 \times \text{SP}$, 1-hex radius	26 Remnants
L2	Radius 1 → 2	26, better placement

Level	Formula / effect	Result at SP 10
L3	Can use abilities	26, fully armed
L4	Multiplier $2 \rightarrow 3$	36 Remnants

In battle: The direct comparison is Nightshade’s Summon Starchild ($8 + 1-2 \times \text{SP}$): Primal’s version starts bigger and scales harder — 26 vs 18 at L1, 36 vs 28 at L4 — for the same 20 mana, at two tiers higher unlock. Same core value proposition too: free bodies that soak attacks meant for your gold-costing units (every Remnant that dies in a Dancer’s place saves 160 gold) and add their own damage every round. Same counters as well — Anti-Magic and Heavenly Blades L4 delete the whole stack on contact.

All four levels: - **L1:** Summons $6 + (2 \times \text{Spellpower})$ Primal Remnants; they vanish at battle’s end. - **L2:** Summon radius rises from 1 to 2 hexes. - **L3:** The summoned stack can use its active abilities. - **L4:** Spellpower multiplier rises from 2 to 3.

Masterful version: None documented.

Why you’d cast it: The biggest free stack in the game, every fight, for heroes who went deep on Primal anyway.

Best heroes: High-Spellpower Primal mains grinding long neutral chains.

When it’s weak: Anti-summon tech turns 20 mana into nothing; short fights never repay the cast.

Common mistakes: Summoning behind your line where the Remnants tank nothing and reach nothing.

Campaign Verdict: **(3/5)** — solid summon value at a tier where its rivals (Chain Lightning, Armageddon) are simply louder.

Confirmed Masterful spell / hero pairings (this school)

Spell	Masterful effect	Hero	Status
Fireball	Hits a bigger area	Faleor (Grove)	Confirmed
Chain Lightning	Loses half as much damage per jump	Halon (Grove)	Confirmed
Ice Bolt	Initiative penalty twice as strong	<i>unknown</i>	Hero not identified
Firewall	Active +1 round	<i>unknown</i>	Hero not identified
Cave In	Rubble takes +1 hit to destroy	<i>unknown</i>	Hero not identified

(Notable: both confirmed Primal Masterful heroes are Grove — the “nature” faction is quietly the elemental-damage specialist faction at the hero level, the way Temple is for Daylight.)

Synergy notes

- **Black Hole (Arcane) → Fireball:** the definitive cross-school combo — compress, then incinerate the pile.
- **Crystal Crown → Firewall → Temporal Spheres (Arcane):** the full toll-road: walls force the lane, fire and mines tax it.
- **Shackles (Arcane) → Hksmilla's Rampage:** Double Strike with the retaliation clause switched off.
- **Black Dragons → Armageddon:** the build that makes a 40-mana self-harm spell into a win condition.
- **Web (Nightshade) → Cave In:** slow the stack, then bury it — the slowed target can't clear the rubble radius before it triggers again.

Common beginner mistakes (school-wide)

- Fireballing your own engaged melee. The radius does not care whose units fill it.
- Clinging to Lightning Bolt past its early-game prime.
- Casting Armageddon without an immunity plan.
- Building the terrain suite (Crown/Firewall) against flying armies that stroll over all of it.
- Aiming Ice Bolt's chill at slow targets — the control half is the point; spend it on speed.

Sourcing note: all mechanics, mana costs, formulas, per-level effects, and Masterful texts taken directly from the official wiki's Primal Spells table (retrieved 2026-07-03). Faleor→Fireball and Halon→Chain Lightning confirmed against hero sourcing (specialization texts match the wiki's Masterful descriptions verbatim); Ice Bolt, Firewall, and Cave In's Masterful owners are open gaps, logged in the audit. All worked math, battle examples (reference stack: 20 Onyx Dancers), ratings, synergies, and verdicts are original analysis.

Hero Skills — the complete tree, every option

This chapter documents **all 30 skills at every rank with every subskill option**, verified in full from the official Skills Overview. Format per skill: the core Basic → Advanced → Expert progression, then the **Advanced picks** (choose one when reaching Advanced) and **Expert picks** (choose one at Expert). “×2 w/ X” marks a synergy clause: *that subskill’s bonus doubles if the hero also knows skill X* — the full synergy web is mapped after the trees.

How the system works

Level-up = one random attribute point + a choice of three options (new skill or rank-up). Every skill: **Basic** → **Advanced (pick 1 of 3 subskills)** → **Expert (pick 1 of 3 stronger subskills)**. Picks are permanent — except via Relic artifacts, which grant *all* unlearned subskills of specific trees (see the artifacts section below). **Combat** is Might-hero exclusive; **Thaumaturgy** is Magic-hero exclusive; the six faction skills auto-belong to their factions.

Might Skills

Offense — *the damage multiplier*

Basic **+10%** → Advanced **+15%** → Expert **+20%** damage on all friendly basic attacks. - **Advanced picks:** Archery (+15% Ranged/Long Reach damage) · Battle March (+1 Focus Point per attack, ×2 w/ Luck) · Battle Frenzy (+2 Attack per point of Morale) - **Expert picks:** Shadow Blades (+1 flat damage — best on swarm/multi-attack armies, worst on giants) · Reality Wardens (+50% damage vs. summoned creatures, ×2 w/ Nightshade — the anti-Schism/anti-summon capstone) · Firmness (−15% enemy Defense) - **Play it:** the default first Might pick for every faction. Archery for shooter cores (Temple, Grove, Dungeon); Battle Frenzy for morale builds; Battle March for Focus economies (Hive, Grove).

Defense — *the damage divider*

Basic **−10%** → Advanced **−15%** → Expert **−20%** damage taken from basic attacks. - **Advanced picks:** Cover (−20% from Ranged/Long Reach) · Hymn to the Martyrs (+1 Focus Point when a creature takes damage, ×2 w/ Recruitment — the tank-battery) · As Luck Would Have It (+2 Defense per point of Luck) - **Expert picks:** Shields and Shells (enemy −1 flat damage —

mirrors Shadow Blades: crushing vs. swarms) · Wizard Contract (−10% Magic Damage, ×2 w/ Diplomacy) · Unstoppable Force (−15% enemy Attack) - **Play it:** Temple's and Grove's wall builds; Cover is the counter-pick when the enemy is the shooter faction.

Leadership — *the morale engine*

Hero gains +1 → +2 → +3 **Morale** (army-wide via the hero). - **Advanced picks:** Resolve (+1% extra-turn chance per Morale point, ×2 w/ Battlecraft — the core of the morale-stack ceiling) · Where the Sun Never Sets (+2 Atk/Def/SP/sight in areas you *don't* control, ×2 w/ Daylight — the invader's pick) · Hero of Legends (enemy −1 Morale) - **Expert picks:** Inspiring Strike (5% per Morale point to instantly reset Heroic Strike on use) · March! (all friendly creatures +1 Initiative) · Enthusiasm (any morale-granted turn → whole army +1 Morale until next round — morale that compounds itself) - **Play it:** useless for Undead/Construct armies (Morale locked at 0 — see combat appendix); build-defining for Temple, Hive, Grove. Aeos the Exalted is this tree as a hero.

Luck — *the crit engine*

Hero gains +1 → +2 → +3 **Luck**. - **Advanced picks:** Beastly Confidence (+1% Lucky Strike chance per Luck point, ×2 w/ Primal Magic) · Always Heads (+25% gold/resources from map piles, ×2 w/ Economy) · Mearea's Chosen (enemy −1 Luck) - **Expert picks:** Lucky Hit (Lucky Strikes provoke **no counterattack**) · Lightning Strikes Twice (**spells** can Lucky Strike for 200% damage, +5% chance per Luck — casters, read that twice) · Lucky Day (a Lucky Strike gives the whole army +1 Luck until next round) - **Play it:** Grove's Qilins (native Luck 3) and hero Octavia make this a faction signature; Lightning Strikes Twice quietly makes Luck a *caster* skill.

Resistance — *the anti-mage wall*

Friendly creatures take −15% → −25% → −35% **Magic Damage**. - **Advanced picks:** Obstruction (enemy spells +20% mana; +20% more for a school you know) · Hindrance Aura (enemy loses 1 Focus Charge per round after the first) · Fast Metabolism (debuffs on you last −2 rounds) - **Expert picks:** Magic Suppression (granted ability: heavy Magic Damage to a summoned creature, scaling with level) · Time Shift (+1 round to all enemy spell cooldowns) · Draining (enemy −1 level on all **Magic School spells**) - **Play it:** the caster-matchup sideboard. Draining vs. enemy school-masters; Magic Suppression as the third anti-summon tool.

Tactics — *the deployment war*

Placement zone 3 → 4 → 5 **lines**; enemy Tactics-knowers lose 1 → 2 → 3 **lines** of their own zone. - **Advanced picks:** One for All (+2 Attack per adjacent enemy, ×2 w/ Offense) · Easy Prey (once/round, enemy waits → your army +2 Initiative) · Energizing Mana (+1 Focus Charge when the enemy casts) - **Expert picks:** All for One (+2 Defense per adjacent ally, ×2 w/ Defense — phalanx formations) · Riposte Mastery (a counterattack kill refreshes that stack's counterattacks) · Spellcaster Tactics (Focus spends grant the hero 4 temporary mana) - **Play it:** the only directly adversarial skill — in hero-vs-hero metas it's near-mandatory; Kel'Ghul starts with it.

Battlecraft — *the wait/skip economy*

Waiting grants **+20% → +30% → +40% Attack** until round's end; skipping grants the same in **Defense**. - **Advanced picks:** Melee Mastery ($\pm 10\%$ melee dealt/taken) · Ranged Mastery ($\pm 10\%$ ranged dealt/taken) · Overwatch (waiting units counterattack enemies entering melee range) - **Expert picks:** Battle Focus (+1 Focus Charge per round after the first, $\times 2$ w/ Battle Magic) · Preemptive Strike (skipping units counter *before* the enemy's blow) · Manacraft (+2 max mana per point of hero Attack+Defense, $\times 2$ w/ Recruitment — the Might-caster bridge) - **Play it:** the skill that makes Wait a weapon; doubles Resolve via the synergy clause, so morale builds want it twice over.

Siegecraft — *the gate-breaker*

Catapult **+50 → +100 → +150 damage**. - **Advanced picks:** Relentless Assault (+1 Speed/Initiative while besieging) · Forward Observers (walls don't reduce your ranged damage) · Barrage (new siege ability: hit a hex and all adjacent, 1/round) - **Expert picks:** Phalanx (-50% damage from defender towers) · Tunnelling (teleport a friendly unit 3 hexes, 1/round) · Sabotage (**the enemy gate is always open**) - **Play it:** pairs with Earth's Rage (Primal) for the complete siege kit; Sabotage + fast melee is a castle-cracking build unto itself.

Recruitment — *the growth skill*

+4 T1 → +3 T2 → +2 T3 weekly growth in all cities (cumulative). - **Advanced picks:** Direct Supervision (hero in a city at week start → that city +50% growth) · Elite Guards (T1–3 creatures gain 25% of hero Atk/Def, $\times 2$ w/ Tactics) · Veterans (+2 T4 growth, $\times 2$ w/ Diplomacy) - **Expert picks:** Relocation (grants the map spell — see Neutral Magic chapter) · Strenuous Training (all friendlies +2 HP) · Mentors (**upgrade creatures outside cities** if the army holds an upgraded copy, at a premium) - **Play it:** the swarm factions' economy (Onkos + this = skeleton tsunami; Hive Progenitor chasers pass through here); Mentors removes the march-home-to-upgrade tax entirely.

Combat (*Might-hero exclusive*) — *the Heroic Strike tree*

Heroic Strike **+10 → +15 → +20 base damage**. - **Advanced picks:** Effortless Strike (-1 Focus Charge cost) · Revenge (once/round, a friendly stack's death → extra Heroic Strike) · Mighty Strike (+10% damage per hero level) - **Expert picks:** Swordcraft (+2 Attack and Defense) · Battle Thrill (a Heroic Strike **kill** → use it again) · Confusing Strike (Heroic Strike strips 1 counterattack) - **Play it:** Old Lord Mandall's tree; Battle Thrill chains executions across wounded stacks — pair with Coup de Grâce logic.

Magic Skills

Battle Magic — *stats from Spellpower*

Friendly Atk/Def gain **15% → 25% → 35%** of the hero's Spellpower and Knowledge respectively. - **Advanced picks:** Aura of Destruction / Protection / Wizardry (each cast in battle → hero +1 Attack / Defense / Spellpower until battle's end — pick your snowball stat) - **Expert picks:** Battle Mage's Authority (+20% of SP as army Attack, $\times 2$ w/ Sorcery) · Mage Protector's Authority (+20% of Knowledge as army Defense, $\times 2$ w/ Resistance) · Magic Time (all battle-spell cooldowns

−1 round) - **Play it:** the skill that makes a caster's stats feed the army — Vesper starts with it; the Righteousness interaction is filthy (every stack of +SP also buffs the army through this).

Sorcery — *raw magic damage*

+10% → +20% → +30% **Magic Damage dealt.** - **Advanced picks:** Summoning Sorcery (all your battle summons +25% HP and damage) · Magic Arrow (grants the free, no-cooldown nuke as a subskill) · Raw Energy (+10% more, ×2 w/ Offense) - **Expert picks:** Piercing Spells (ignore 25% of magic resistance) · High Mage (+1 level to all spells of schools you know) · Sticky Magic (your effects last +2 rounds, ×2 w/ Wisdom) - **Play it:** the universal caster multiplier — every damage number in the magic chapters rises 30% at Expert. Laura starts with it.

Summon Avatar — *the free champion*

Grants the Avatar summon; it survives **2 → 3 → 4 hits**; its Attack/Damage scale with Spellpower. (Full formulas: Neutral Magic chapter.) - **Advanced picks:** Avatar of Fury (+25% damage, ×2 w/ Leadership) · Avatar of Toughness (+1 hit, ×2 w/ Defense) · Avatar of Celerity (+1 Speed/Initiative, ×2 w/ Insight) - **Expert picks:** Stabilization (**your summons become immune to summon-dispel effects** — the answer to Anti-Magic/Heavenly Blades) · Their Name is Legion (+30% to all your summon counts) · Fields of Mana (summon onto *any* free hex) - **Play it:** Funerella starts with it; Stabilization single-handedly rehabilitates every summon build this book warned about — Schism players, this is your tech.

Wisdom — *the school-skipper*

Learn spells up to **T3 → T4 → T5** *without* the school skill. - **Advanced picks:** Rite of Magic (convert current Movement into mana) · Between the Lines (learn high Neutral magic regardless of hero level) · Seeing Through (Heroic Strike kills all temporary units in the target) - **Expert picks:** Rhythmic Cadence (+30% max mana, ×2 w/ Sorcery) · Eagle Eye (**at battle start, learn all learnable enemy spells**) · Stargazer (+250 Astrology Points/day, ×2 w/ Scouting) - **Play it:** the generalist-caster spine — cherry-pick the best spell from every school (Vulnerability, Rewind Life, Web) without four school skills. Zenith starts with it.

The four School skills (Daylight / Nightshade / Arcane / Primal)

Shared shape — Basic: learn that school to T5 · Advanced: **school spells +1 level** · Expert: **+1 more level**, and T5 spells learnable without a Mage Guild (via the Observatory). - **Shared picks:** [School] Time (−1 round on that school's cooldowns, Advanced) · Brightest Sun / Darkest Night / Purest Thought / Sharpest Teeth (**−1 level to all enemy spells of that school**, Advanced) · [School] Teachings (+1 further level, Expert) · **Scholar Synergy:** Arina/Naira/Doreath/Hksmilla (+6 Spellpower for that school, **+3 more per other school known**, Expert) - **Unique picks:** Daylight — Luminous Focus (+1 Focus Charge at battle start) and Speed of Light (+10 Movement, ×2 w/ Logistics). Nightshade — Chronic Weakness (enemy max HP −1, ×2 w/ Resistance) and Hour of the Wolf (enemy −10% Atk/Def). Arcane — All Life is Endless (+30% healing/revival, ×2 w/ Summon Avatar — Rewind Life's best friend) and Mana Flex (spells −2 mana). Primal — Primal Force (your effects +1 round) and Chaos Reigns (+50% Lucky Strike damage, ×2 w/ Battle Magic). - **Play it: spell levels stack** — Advanced (+1) + Expert (+1) + Teachings (+1) reaches L4 on the whole school from the skill tree alone; add High

Mage/Archmage/Fine Wand and even fresh scrolls cast at max. The Scholar Synergy capstone is the multi-school payoff: a four-school hero casts each school at +15 effective Spellpower.

Thaumaturgy (*Magic-hero exclusive*) — *the double-cast*

Cast a **second spell each round** from a school unused that round; extra casts cost **+100% → +75% → +50%** mana. - **Advanced picks:** Antimage (enemy spells +4 mana) · Ancient Scrolls (all Tier-1 spells added to the book) · Practical Incantations (Heroic Strike +10) - **Expert picks:** Thaumaturge Brilliance (+2 Spellpower and Knowledge) · Vast Soul (+10% mana each morning) · Archmage (**+1 level to all known-school spells**) - **Play it:** the reason to be multi-school — Vulnerability + Fireball in the same round is a different game. Anastasia starts with it; Lord Rufus's Thaumaturgy start means Masterful Rewind Life *plus* a second cast.

General Skills

Diplomacy — *armies for gold*

Neutral squads may **offer to join for gold**; Persuasion **+0% → +25% → +50%**. - **Advanced picks:** Larger Than Life (army looks +25% stronger to neutrals, ×2 w/ Battlecraft) · Eloquence (−75% surrender cost) · Folk Hero (+50% Persuasion vs. same-faction neutrals) - **Expert picks:** Art of the Deal (−15% joining cost, ×2 w/ Economy) · Vagrant Army (neutral-affinity units gain +100% of hero Atk/Def) · Negotiator (+20% joiners) - **Play it:** Grove's gold-cost escape hatch (Alluring Sh'a's tree); King-of-Kings starts with it. Vagrant Army turns recruited neutrals from filler into elites.

Logistics — *the movement skill*

+10% → +15% → +20% Movement. - **Advanced picks:** Leaps and Bounds (+5 Movement per battle victory) · Strong Mounts (Neutral map spells −4 mana, ×2 w/ Scouting) · Careful Planning (bank 50 unused Movement daily, ×2 w/ Arcane) - **Expert picks:** Secret Passages (terrain penalties −50%) · Back to Town! (grants the map spell) · Battle Logistics (+1 Speed on Native Terrain) - **Play it:** the Foundations chapter's "time is the real currency" as a skill. Ister and Marl start with it.

Scouting — *the intel skill*

Hero sight **+1 → +2 → +3** (and sight multiplies half the map-spell ranges in this book). - **Advanced picks:** Long-Sight (+1 more, ×2 w/ Luck) · Familiar Paths (+10 Movement starting in controlled territory, ×2 w/ Wisdom) · Pathfinding (terrain penalties −50%) - **Expert picks:** Reconnaissance (defog 150% of sight each morning) · Visions (**exact enemy army compositions** within 300% of sight — Read Minds as a passive) · Counterespionage (enemies see *fake* info about your army) - **Play it:** Visions makes fight selection free forever; Counterespionage is the PvP mind-game pick.

Insight — *the compounding skill*

+20% → +30% → +40% XP. - **Advanced picks:** Enlightenment (+10% more XP) · Civic Innovation (**+30% Law points**, ×2 w/ Leadership — the town-Laws accelerator) · Sagacity

(neutral intentions within 300% sight) - **Expert picks:** Scholar of Magic (**heroes teach each other spells** when they meet on the map) · Endless Charisma (+1 to all four attributes, ×2 w/ Tactics) · Perception (see enemy hero details in battle) - **Play it:** Pip's tree, and the multi-hero economy's secret weapon — one Scholar of Magic hero turns every spell any hero learns into a spell *every* hero learns.

Economy — *gold as a skill*

+500 → +750 → +1,000 gold daily. - **Advanced picks:** Tax Collector (+250 more, ×2 w/ Logistics) · Smuggler (+1 of your faction's rare resource daily) · Master Builder (+1 Wood and Ore daily) - **Expert picks:** Experimenter (+5 **Alchemical Dust** daily, ×2 w/ Insight — the artifact-upgrade economy) · Merchant (hero counts as an extra Marketplace for trade rates) · Antiquarian (sell artifacts +25%, buy −25%) - **Play it:** the second-hero skill par excellence (Clarissa, Milossa); Smuggler answers the T7 rare-resource gate from inside the skill tree.

Faction Skills (complete trees)

Righteousness (Temple)

Per friendly death **or** kill: hero +1 to all four attributes for **2 → 3 → 4 rounds**, stackable. - **Advanced picks:** Fields of Serenity (native-terrain ±10%) · Righteous Sacrifice (each trigger → 3 temporary mana) · Purging Touch (granted ability: dispel all debuffs from a target) - **Expert picks:** Guardian (**a friendly creature that kills fully restores its HP**) · The Chosen One (granted ability: buff a creature by 50% of hero Atk+SP / Def+Knowledge) · Strong Faith (each trigger → +1 more to everything until round's end) - **Read:** Guardian on a lifedrain-less faction is enormous — Temple's melee stops attritting the moment it starts winning.

Necromancy (Necropolis)

Converts **10% → 15% → 20%** of the strongest enemy stack into same-tier Undead; Energy caps **1,000 → 1,250 → 1,500**. (*Corrects the flat-20% figure in this book's earlier draft — 20% is the Expert rank.*) - **Advanced picks:** Gravesoil (terrain) · Soul Harvest (+4 mana per victory) · Death Herald (+500 max Energy) - **Expert picks:** Soul Reaper (enemy −1 Morale **and** Luck) · Eternal Service (granted ability: heal/revive a friendly Undead stack) · Fields of the Dead (+50% Energy gain when you lack the tier) - **Read:** Eternal Service is Rewind Life as an ability — Rufus players get both.

Murmuring (Grove)

1 → 2 → 3 Focus Charges at every battle's start. - **Advanced picks:** Mycelium Grounds (terrain) · Life Essence (+1 Focus cap) · Child of the Woods (+20 max mana) - **Expert picks:** Just One More Time (Focus spends cut hero spell cooldowns −2 rounds) · Burst of Energy (Focus spends → Heroic Strike +15% per hero level) · Strong Connection (Focus spends → hero +2 all attributes)

Summon Swarm (Hive)

Eggs → Fire Larvae at **8% → 12% → 16%** of army Hive-Spawn HP; scales with hero level; eggs die to 2 hits. - **Advanced picks:** Warmth of the Nest (terrain) · Thy Children (+1 Larva per hero level) · Ravage (Larvae +1 damage) - **Expert picks:** Hive Power (hero +1 Luck and Morale) · Hardened Shells (eggs +1 hit) · Hive Flame (Larvae last +1 round)

Abyssal Communion (Schism)

Victory → Communion +1 (cap **4 → 5 → 6**); each level = **+3% friendly Schism units** for that battle; **halves every morning**. - **Advanced picks:** Our True Home (terrain) · Comprehensible Depths (+1 max level) · Call of the Void (each morning, 3 mana per level *before* halving) - **Expert picks:** Black Ice (enemy spells +1 mana per active level) · **Abyssopelagial (+1 extra Communion per victory — doubles the climb rate)** · Celestial Abyss (+1% units per level) - **Read:** Abyssopelagial is the faction's most important subskill, full stop — it halves the streak-building the whole gameplan depends on.

Triumvirate's Strength (Dungeon)

Once/round, activate a Stance: hero **+2 → +4 → +6** to that attribute. - **Advanced picks:** Underground Passages (terrain) · Alvarian Expertise (active Stance also *reduces* the enemy hero's matching attribute) · Underground Mana Pools (3 temporary mana per Stance pick) - **Expert picks:** Jack of All Trades (each selection → +5% to that attribute until battle's end, compounding) · Flow (+1 Focus Charge per Stance pick) · Opportunists (all friendlies +1 Initiative)

The synergy web — every “doubled if” pairing (verified, complete)

Thirty-six doubling clauses exist; they are the skill system's real currency. The full map, grouped by what they build:

Build theme	Pairings (subskill ← needs skill)
Morale engine	Resolve ← Battlecraft · Battle Frenzy (uses Morale) · Enthusiasm (self-feeds)
Luck engine	Beastly Confidence ← Primal Magic · Long-Sight ← Luck · Battle March ← Luck · As Luck Would Have It (uses Luck) · Chaos Reigns ← Battle Magic
Focus economy	Hymn to the Martyrs ← Recruitment · Battle Focus ← Battle Magic · Energizing Mana / Spellcaster Tactics (Tactics tree) · Luminous Focus (Daylight)
Caster stats	Battle Mage's Authority ← Sorcery · Mage Protector's Authority ← Resistance · Raw Energy ← Offense · Rhythmic Cadence ← Sorcery · Sticky Magic ← Wisdom · Manacraft ← Recruitment

Build theme	Pairings (subskill $\leftarrow$ needs skill)
Anti-magic	Wizard Contract $\leftarrow$ Diplomacy · Chronic Weakness $\leftarrow$ Resistance · Obstruction (self-scaling) · Draining/Time Shift (Resistance tree)
Anti-summon	Reality Wardens $\leftarrow$ Nightshade Magic · Magic Suppression (Resistance) · Seeing Through (Wisdom) — vs. Stabilization (Summon Avatar), which counters all three
Summoner	Avatar of Fury $\leftarrow$ Leadership · Avatar of Toughness $\leftarrow$ Defense · Avatar of Celerity $\leftarrow$ Insight · All Life is Endless $\leftarrow$ Summon Avatar · Summoning Sorcery
Map tempo	Careful Planning $\leftarrow$ Arcane Magic · Familiar Paths $\leftarrow$ Wisdom · Strong Mounts $\leftarrow$ Scouting · Speed of Light $\leftarrow$ Logistics
Economy	Always Heads $\leftarrow$ Economy · Art of the Deal $\leftarrow$ Economy · Tax Collector $\leftarrow$ Logistics · Experimenter $\leftarrow$ Insight · Veterans $\leftarrow$ Diplomacy
Formation	One for All $\leftarrow$ Offense · All for One $\leftarrow$ Defense · Elite Guards $\leftarrow$ Tactics · Larger Than Life $\leftarrow$ Battlecraft
Growth/Laws	Civic Innovation $\leftarrow$ Leadership · Endless Charisma $\leftarrow$ Tactics · Stargazer $\leftarrow$ Scouting · Where the Sun Never Sets $\leftarrow$ Daylight

Three verified premier stacks: 1. **The Morale Ceiling** (from the combat appendix, now fully sourced): Expert Leadership (+3) + Resolve×Battlecraft (+2%/pt) + Knight's Honor set (+5%) + Encouragement law (+2%) + Aeos = ~20% extra-turn chance per point, ~100% at Morale 5. 2. **The Multi-School Archmage:** two+ school skills at Expert with Scholar Synergies (+6 +3 each) + Thaumaturgy double-cast + High Mage/Archmage (+1 level each) — every spell at max level, cast twice a round, at +12–15 effective Spellpower. 3. **The Unkillable Summoner:** Summon Avatar w/ Stabilization + Summoning Sorcery + Their Name is Legion + All Life is Endless — +30% bigger summons, +25% stronger, dispel-immune, and healed 30% harder. Schism's answer to its own counter.

Artifact effects on the skill system (verified)

- **Relics = skill-tree cheat codes:** each Relic grants *all unlearned subskills* of specific trees — the Holy Sigil of Roph covers all six faction skills at once, deleting every pick-one-of-three decision above for those trees.
- **Spell-level stacking:** Fine Wand (+1 level to all spells) stacks with Advanced/Expert school ranks, Teachings, High Mage, and Archmage — the route to casting everything at L4 without ever finding an upgrade scroll.
- **Skill-mimics:** Fancy Mask (+2–3 battle-start Focus) is Murmuring in a hat · Warlord Boots

(+2 army Initiative) doubles March! · Ukh Signet/Tabar Signet feed Leadership/Luck scaling subskills · Legion's Leg (+50% growth) multiplies Recruitment · Skull of Milos out-earns Basic Economy · Caduceus/Two-faced Mask extend the Combat tree's Heroic Strike engine.

- **Alchemical Dust loop:** Experimenter (+5 Dust/day) feeds artifact upgrading, which feeds the artifacts feeding your skills — the one closed economic loop between the two systems.
- **Spellbinder's Hat / Spells in Bottles** (all T5/T4 spells) do Wisdom's job as items — a Might hero with the Hat skips the entire magic-skill investment for access purposes.

Master table — every skill at a glance

Legend: **B/A/E** = the core Basic/Advanced/Expert effect · *Adv/Exp picks* abbreviated · Best-fit column names factions (chapter verdicts) and verified starting heroes.

Skill	B → A → E core	Advanced picks	Expert picks	Best factions / heroes
Offense	+10/15/20% dmg	Archery · Battle March · Battle Frenzy	Shadow Blades · Reality Wardens · Firmness	All; shooters (Tem- ple/Grove/Dungeon); Kestrel, Onkos, Gorel Spearhead
Defense	−10/15/20% taken	Cover · Hymn to Martyrs · Luck→Def	Shields&Shells · Wizard Contract · Unstoppable Force	Temple, Grove walls; Bulwark, John Johnson
Leadership	+1/2/3 Morale	Resolve · Sun Never Sets · Hero of Legends	Inspiring Strike · March! · Enthusiasm	Temple/Hive/Grove (never Undead); Aeos
Luck	+1/2/3 Luck	Beastly Confidence · Always Heads · Mearea's Chosen	Lucky Hit · Lightning Strikes Twice · Lucky Day	Grove (Qilins), Hive Reavers; Octavia, Klastor
Resistance	−15/25/35% magic	Obstruction · Hindrance Aura · Fast Metabolism	Magic Suppression · Time Shift · Draining	vs. casters; Julius, Artorius Veritas
Tactics	3/4/5 lines, −enemy	One for All · Easy Prey · Energizing Mana	All for One · Riposte Mastery · Spellcaster Tactics	PvP-style play; Kel'Ghul
Battlecraft	Wait/skip +20/30/40%	Melee/Ranged Mastery · Overwatch	Battle Focus · Preemptive Strike · Manacraft	Morale builds (doubles Resolve); Keandra, Adahn
Siegecraft	Catapult +50/100/150	Relentless · Forward Observers · Barrage	Phalanx · Tunnelling · Sabotage	The castle-taker army, any faction

Skill	B → A → E core	Advanced picks	Expert picks	Best factions / heroes
Recruitment	+4/3/2 T1-3 growth	Supervision · Elite Guards · Veterans	Relocation · +2 HP · Mentors	Necropolis/Hive swarms; Heretic Avis, Zam
Combat (Might)	Heroic Strike +10/15/20	Effortless · Revenge · Mighty Strike	Swordcraft · Battle Thrill · Confusing Strike	Might mains; Old Lord Mandall, Mreowa
Battle Magic	Army stats from SP/Know 15/25/35%	Aura of De- str./Prot./Wizardry	BM Authority · MP Authority · Magic Time	Temple Clerics (Righteousness combo); Vesper, Milossa
Sorcery	+10/20/30% magic dmg	Summoning Sorc. · Magic Arrow · Raw Energy	Piercing · High Mage · Sticky Magic	Every caster; Laura, Grove trio
Summon Avatar	Avatar 2/3/4 hits	Fury · Toughness · Celerity	Stabilization · Legion · Fields of Mana	Schism (Stabilization!), casters; Funerella
Wisdom	Learn T3/4/5 school-free	Rite of Magic · Between the Lines · Seeing Through	Rhythmic Cadence · Eagle Eye · Stargazer	Cherry-pick casters; Zenith, Ethric
Daylight Magic	School +0/1/2 levels	Time · Luminous Focus · Brightest Sun	Teachings · Speed of Light · Scholar: Arina	Temple; Lia (master), the Cleric trio
Nightshade Magic	School +0/1/2 levels	Time · Chronic Weakness · Darkest Night	Teachings · Hour of the Wolf · Scholar: Naira	Necropolis/Schism; Oona (master), Nadir, Keiri
Arcane Magic	School +0/1/2 levels	Time · All Life is Endless · Purest Thought	Teachings · Mana Flex · Scholar: Doreath	Everyone (Rewind Life); Mag (master), Rufus
Primal Magic	School +0/1/2 levels	Time · Primal Force · Sharpest Teeth	Teachings · Chaos Reigns · Scholar: Hksmilla	Grove/Dungeon; Faleor, Halon
Thaumaturgy (Magic)	2nd cast +100/75/50% mana	Antimage · Ancient Scrolls · Practical Inc.	Brilliance · Vast Soul · Archmage	Multi-school casters; Anastasia, Lord Rufus
Diplomacy	Neutrals join; +0/25/50%	Larger Than Life · Eloquence · Folk Hero	Art of Deal · Vagrant Army · Negotiator	Grove economy; Sh'a, King-of-Kings, Merry Elias
Logistics	+10/15/20% move	Leaps&Bounds · Strong Mounts · Careful Planning	Secret Passages · Back to Town! · Battle Logistics	Every main hero; Ister, Marl

Skill	B → A → E core	Advanced picks	Expert picks	Best factions / heroes
Scouting	+1/2/3 sight	Long-Sight · Familiar Paths · Pathfinding	Reconnaissance · Visions · Counterespionage	Fight-selectors; Leon, Eith, Natalida
Insight	+20/30/40% XP	Enlightenment · Civic Innovation · Sagacity	Scholar of Magic · Endless Charisma · Perception	Long campaigns; Pip, Aunt Daliar
Economy	+500/750/1000 gold	Tax Collector · Smuggler · Master Builder	Experimenter · Merchant · Antiquarian	Second heroes; Clarissa, Milossa, Avis
Righteousness	+1 all, 2/3/4 rds, stack	Terrain · Sacrifice · Purging Touch	Guardian · Chosen One · Strong Faith	Temple (all heroes)
Necromancy	10/15/20% raise	Terrain · Soul Harvest · Death Herald	Soul Reaper · Eternal Service · Fields of Dead	Necropolis (all); Tarius +power
Murmuring	1/2/3 Focus at start	Terrain · Life Essence · Child of Woods	One More Time · Burst · Strong Connection	Grove (all)
Summon Swarm	Larvae 8/12/16% HP	Terrain · Thy Children · Ravage	Hive Power · Hardened Shells · Hive Flame	Hive (all); Mila
Abyssal Communion	+1/win, cap 4/5/6, +3%/lvl	Terrain · Depths · Call of Void	Black Ice · Abyssopelagial · Celestial Abyss	Schism (all); Eye Collective
Triumvirate's Strength	Stance +2/4/6	Terrain · Alvarian Expertise · Mana Pools	Jack of All Trades · Flow · Opportunists	Dungeon (all); Sister Deira

Sourcing note: every rank effect and subskill text above is verbatim-verified from the official wiki's complete Skills Overview (retrieved 2026-07-03) — this supersedes the previous draft's partial trees and corrects Necromancy's rank percentages. The synergy web, premier stacks, artifact interactions, play-it guidance, and the best-fit column are original analysis; hero fits reference the verified starting skills in the Heroes chapter.

Artifacts — the 14-slot game

How the system works (verified)

- Heroes carry **14 equipment slots** (head, neck, torso, hands, main hand, waist, legs, feet, rings, and multiple misc-item slots — misc allows four at once). Bonuses apply only **while equipped**.
- **Four rarity categories**; higher rarity = rarer and stronger. **Relics** sit at the top with unique effects — their signature pattern is *granting every unlearned subskill of specific skill trees* (bypassing the pick-one-of-three system entirely).
- Artifacts can be **upgraded with alchemical dust**, improving their main bonus.
- **Sets**: each artifact may belong to one. Minimal sets (2 pieces) add a bonus when both are worn; expanded sets (up to 8 pieces) unlock staged bonuses — typically at 3, 5, and 8 pieces.
- Sources: found on the map, won from guards, or bought from an artifact merchant built in your city.

Why sets matter (verified design intent)

Past hero level ~20, level-ups slow to a crawl — sets are the documented late-game growth axis, with full-set bonuses described as playstyle-transforming rather than incremental. Two verified flagships:

- **Knight's Honor** (Plate Armor, Lance, Misericorde, Armet, Drum of War): +5% morale-trigger chance per point — a core piece of the 20%-per-morale-point stack documented in the combat appendix.
- **Power of the Dragon Father** (8 pieces): full-set grants **magic immunity** — Armageddon-build enablement for factions *without* Black Dragons or Abyssal Envoys. Partial bonuses at 3/5 are modest; this set is all-or-nothing.
- **Tabar Signet-Ring + Ukh Signet** (2-piece): Luck + Morale rings whose pairing adds a strong experience bonus — the cheapest set payoff in the game.

The verified standouts, by slot

Head: Spellbinder's Hat (adds *all Tier-5 spells* to the spellbook — an Expert-school shortcut in an item) · Fancy Mask (+2→3 Focus Points at battle start — Murmuring in a hat) · Two-faced Mask (kill with Heroic Strike → use it again that round).

Main hand: Shroomwood Bow (removes the ranged penalty for nearby units, +10% ranged damage upgraded — a Marksman-line effect for the whole army) · Shaman Staff (+6→9 Spellpower

— the biggest raw caster stat documented) · Caduceus (+4 mana per Heroic Strike use).

Torso: Vortex Robe (restores a large share of mana per spell cast — reported as 50% of cost, with an enemy-cast variant at 40→60%; the premier sustain item for casters either way).

Waist: Skull of Milos (+1,000 gold *per day*, Legendary — the earlier found, the more it prints) · Spells in Bottles (all Tier-4 spells).

Feet: Warlord Boots (+2 Initiative to all friendly units — turn order as an item) · Legion’s Leg (+50% **unit growth in all cities** — the single biggest economy artifact documented; note the overlap with the Herald’s Progenitor subclass for a truly absurd Hive stack).

Back/misc: Light-and-Shade Cloak (ranged attacks usable at close range — deletes the shooter’s one weakness) · Fallen Angel Wings (flight over obstacles — Shadowflight, permanently) · Tranquil Glass (fully restores the hero’s mana every day) · Quivering Quiver (ranged-army staple) · mana-pool misc items (+30 combined from the two standard picks).

Relics: the **Holy Sigil of Roph** is the documented archetype — all unlearned subskills of every *faction* skill (Righteousness, Necromancy, Murmuring, Triumvirate’s Strength, Abyssal Communion, Summon Swarm). There is no “best relic” in general; each maps to a skill package, so the right one is whichever completes *your* build.

Build packages (original analysis)

- **The Caster Engine:** Shaman Staff + Vortex Robe + Tranquil Glass
 - Fine Wand (+1 level to all spells) — Spellpower, sustain, and a free spell-level; every magic chapter’s numbers scale up a bracket.
- **The Ranged Army Kit:** Shroomwood Bow + Light-and-Shade Cloak + Quivering Quiver + Warlord Boots — removes every structural weakness this book’s shooter-core advice carries.
- **The Economy Snowball:** Skull of Milos + Legion’s Leg — gold and growth; strongest in the earliest weeks you can assemble it.
- **The Morale Stack:** Knight’s Honor set + Ukh Signet + Resolve subskill + Encouragement law — the combat appendix’s 20%-per-point ceiling, itemized.

Open gaps (tracked)

The full artifact list with exact stats per rarity tier lives across the wiki’s Artifacts page and the first-party database; this chapter documents the verified system rules, both flagship sets, and the cross-source consensus standouts. A complete item-by-item table is queued in the audit — and note two sources report Vortex Robe’s trigger differently (own-cast 50% vs. enemy-cast 40→60%), flagged rather than resolved.

Sourcing note: system rules from the official wiki and first-party artifact database; item effects cross-checked across three contemporary guides (retrieved 2026-07-03). Build packages are original analysis.

Neutral Creatures — the map’s own army

How neutrals work (verified)

Faction units come in 7 tiers with dual upgrades; neutral creatures break both rules: they span **8 tiers**, and **cannot be upgraded** — one version each. They don’t belong to any town. Four documented ways to get them into *your* army:

1. **Specialized hiring buildings** on the adventure map.
2. **Guard rewards** — some defeated object-guards join you.
3. **The Chimerologist’s Hut** — rerolls native troops with a chance of neutral results (note: T8s don’t drop from it).
4. **Summoning spells** — temporary battle stacks (Starchild, Primal Remnant, and the Avatar are all technically neutral creatures; see their entries in the Nightshade, Primal, and Neutral Magic chapters).

Tier 8 is the headline: an elite band above every faction’s ceiling, guarding the map’s richest treasures. The documented example is the **Lich Dragon**, whose *Bone Armageddon* ability deals Pure Damage to **all other creatures** equal to its unit count — a 333-strong guard hits everything on the field for 333 unmodifiable damage. T8 fights are the game’s raid bosses: bring answers, not armies.

The verified roster (21 creatures)

Grouped by the role their identity and sourcing indicate; per-unit stat rows are the queued fetch noted in the audit.

Fodder & early-map guards: Pixie · Gnat · Peasant · Ghoul · Halfling — the week-1 XP diet. (Peasant is the series’ traditional floor; Halfling its traditional ranged nuisance.)

Mid-map muscle: Animated Armor (Construct — morale/luck locked at 0, immune to those swings, and *doesn’t* feed Necromancy) · Groll · Kittenhorn · Giant Toad · Unicorn.

Summon-only stacks: Starchild (Nightshade’s Summon Starchild) · Primal Remnant (Primal’s summon) · Avatar (the hero-scaled champion — the one neutral documented with full formulas, in the Neutral Magic chapter).

Elite guards & prizes: Faerie Dragon · Couatl · Dragonslayer · Worldwatcher · Sentinel of Glory.

The dragon tier: Obsidian Dragon · Red Dragon · **Lich Dragon (T8)** — the treasure-guard class, with the Lich Dragon’s Bone Armageddon as the documented apex threat.

Fighting neutrals well (original analysis)

- **Read the type line before the stat line.** The combat appendix’s type table decides these fights: Constructs ignore your morale debuffs and feed Necromancy nothing; Undead neutrals (Ghoul, Lich Dragon) can’t be Slept; Living/Magic Creature guards are Necromancy’s richest harvest.
- **Percentage damage beats dragon guards.** Guillotine (Arcane, 7 mana, % of max HP, stacking recasts) exists for exactly the high-HP single-stack guards this chapter describes — often cheaper than the army losses of fighting fair.
- **Bone Armageddon math:** unmodifiable damage to *everything* means the counter isn’t armor, it’s **stack count and body doubles** — summons eat the same 333 as your real units, for free. A Starchild/Remnant screen turns the T8’s signature move into wasted violence. (Reality Distortion’s damage-deferral is the expert-tier alternative.)
- **Read Minds / Groundsight first.** The intel spells (Nightshade T2, Primal T1) exist for neutral-fight selection; against 8 tiers of guards, knowing exact counts is worth more than any single combat spell.
- **Chimerologist gambling** pairs with Primordial Chaos logic: reroll what you can’t fight into what you can — but variance cuts both ways; don’t reroll solved fights.

Open gaps (tracked)

Per-unit stat rows for all 21 neutrals (the wiki’s Neutral Units page uses the same table format as the faction pages — one fetch), plus tier assignments for the mid-list. The roster itself, the 8-tier structure, acquisition rules, and the Lich Dragon’s ability are verified.

Sourcing note: roster, tier system, acquisition methods, and Bone Armageddon from the official wiki’s Units navigation and the first-party unit database (retrieved 2026-07-03). Role groupings and tactical guidance are original analysis.

Town Development — the other half of every turn

Armies win battles; towns win campaigns. This chapter covers the verified building categories, the Laws system, and the build-order principles the faction chapters apply — plus the two faction-specific Week 1 plans this book has verified sourcing for.

What a town builds (verified categories)

- **Creature dwellings** — one per tier, each unlocking that unit’s weekly growth (the verified rates run from Skeletons’ 30/week to T7s’ 1–2/week). Upgraded dwellings unlock the dual upgrade paths documented in every faction’s stat tables. External map dwellings supplement town growth (and are what Reinforcements/Relocation interact with remotely).
- **Mage Guild** — unlocks spells for visiting heroes, and each guild built is worth **6 points** toward your Neutral-spell auto-leveling (the single biggest points item in that system; see the Neutral Magic chapter). Ordinary buildings are worth 2 points each — every construction day quietly levels your logistics suite.
- **Marketplace** — resource conversion at a loss; the verified framing from the Schism sourcing is “conversion fallback” for rare-resource bottlenecks, not a plan.
- **Artifact merchant** — buyable artifacts (verified in the Artifacts chapter’s acquisition list).
- **Fortifications** — walls/towers/gate, the siege math from the Foundations chapter; the defender’s half of “campaigns are decided at gates.”
- **Faction-unique structures** — e.g. Schism’s Eerie Summoning Rite (the T7 Envoy building, verified on the Envoy’s page).

The Laws system (verified)

Each faction has **Laws** — a parallel investment track upgraded with **seals**, separate from gold construction. Verified mechanics from the official Laws pages: each Law has **3 levels**, each level improving only the numeric values of the same effect; in-game tooltips show your current benefit and the post-upgrade cumulative one. Laws are faction-flavored passives that reach outside the town — the one verified by name in this book is **Encouragement** (+2% morale-trigger chance per point), a required piece of the combat appendix’s 20%-per-morale-point ceiling; and the Abyssal Envoy’s page notes it is “specifically affected by” certain Schism Laws — Laws tune units, not just economy. Full per-faction Law tables: tracked as an open gap (six pages, same merged-tooltip format).

Build-order principles (original analysis, anchored to verified plans)

The two verified Week 1 plans in this book:

Dungeon (from the pilot chapter): Day 1 Amphitheater → Days 2–3 Byzantine Palace (T2/T3 access) → Day 4 Labyrinth → Days 5–7 flex to map circumstances. The shape: **income first, then the cheapest real-army tiers, then commit.**

Schism (verified third-party build order): early army from T1–T2 dwellings with Cultist ranged damage → Days 3–4 split Mage Guild + Marketplace → **Arbitrators (T6) dwelling accessible by the start of Week 2** → explicitly do *not* rush the T7 building (“puts too much pressure on the economy”), and when forced to choose between a building and recruiting, **recruit.**

The principles those two plans share — apply to any faction:

1. **Never skip a build day.** Towns build one structure per day; a skipped day is unrecoverable. Even a “wrong” cheap building beats nothing (and pays 2 Neutral points).
2. **Dwellings before upgrades, breadth before height.** Weekly growth starts accruing the day the dwelling exists — a dwelling built Day 2 instead of Day 5 is permanent extra army. Dual upgrades can wait; missed growth can’t.
3. **Target a named Week 2 milestone.** Every strong verified plan has one (Dungeon’s Labyrinth line, Schism’s Arbitrators, the Necropolis sourcing’s “Dread Knight building by early Week 2,” Temple’s Lightweavers — or Zenith, who *is* the milestone, starting with them). Pick the faction chapter’s flagged core unit and build the shortest path to it.
4. **The T7 building is a trap on schedule.** Every faction’s T7 is rare-resource gated (Foundations chapter); the building without the Gems/Mercury/Crystal to recruit from it is dead gold. Rush it only when the resource pipeline exists — which is what the economy-specialist second heroes are for.
5. **Recruit > build when the map is hot.** Buildings compound but armies act; the verified Schism guidance generalizes — an unrecruited growth pool is the one town resource that *doesn’t* carry forward safely (enemy heroes exist).
6. **Growth multipliers outrank everything late.** The verified stack: Legion’s Leg artifact (+50% growth, all cities) and the Herald’s Progenitor subclass (+200%) turn each additional town into multiples — which is why the mid-game priority shifts from building your first town tall to taking your second and third.

Multi-town play (original analysis)

Once you hold two-plus towns, the verified logistics suite becomes the actual build order: Town Portal (garrison anywhere), Relocation (collect growth remotely), Assemble!/Gate of Light (feed the front). The town-development decision stops being “what do I build” and becomes “which town builds army, which builds economy” — army towns want dwellings and fortifications; economy towns want the Mage Guild (points + spells), Marketplace, and merchant. Your capital should usually be the army town: it’s the one you’ll defend.

Open gaps (tracked)

Per-faction building trees with costs/prerequisites (six pages); full Law tables per faction (six pages); town-hall income tiers; weekly event effects on growth. The principles above are anchored

to verified plans; the exact numbers behind them are the queued fetches.

Sourcing note: building categories, Neutral-points values, Laws mechanics, and both Week 1 plans from the verified sources cited in the faction and magic chapters (retrieved 2026-07-03). The six principles and multi-town framing are original analysis.

Decision Trees — the book, compressed into flowcharts

Every tree here is a compression of chapters you’ve already read (or can skip to). They’re built for the moment of decision, not for study — the prose after each one tells you which chapter to open when the compressed answer isn’t enough. All diagrams are original to this book.

Tree 1: Which faction should I play?

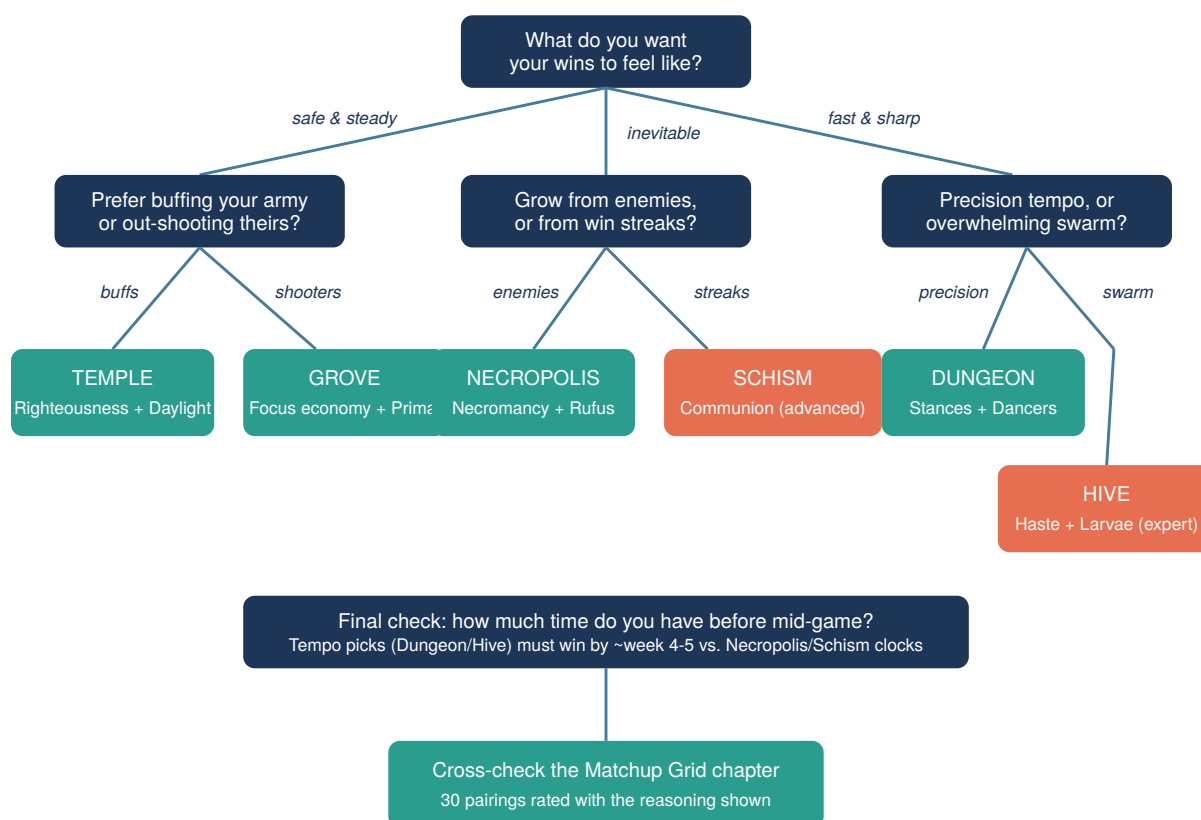


Figure 3: Faction picker decision tree

The tree’s first question — *what do you want wins to feel like?* — is doing real work: the six factions genuinely divide into three temperaments. **Safe & steady** (Temple’s buffed line, Grove’s penalty-free shooters), **inevitable** (Necropolis’s harvest, Schism’s streaks), **fast & sharp** (Dungeon’s precision, Hive’s swarm). The two orange boxes are honest warnings, not insults: Schism and Hive carry the book’s 2/5 beginner-friendliness scores, and both chapters explain exactly why. The bottom check is the Matchup Grid’s clock rule — tempo picks are on a timer against the inevitability picks. Full reasoning: the six faction chapters’ verdicts.

Tree 2: Should I take this fight?

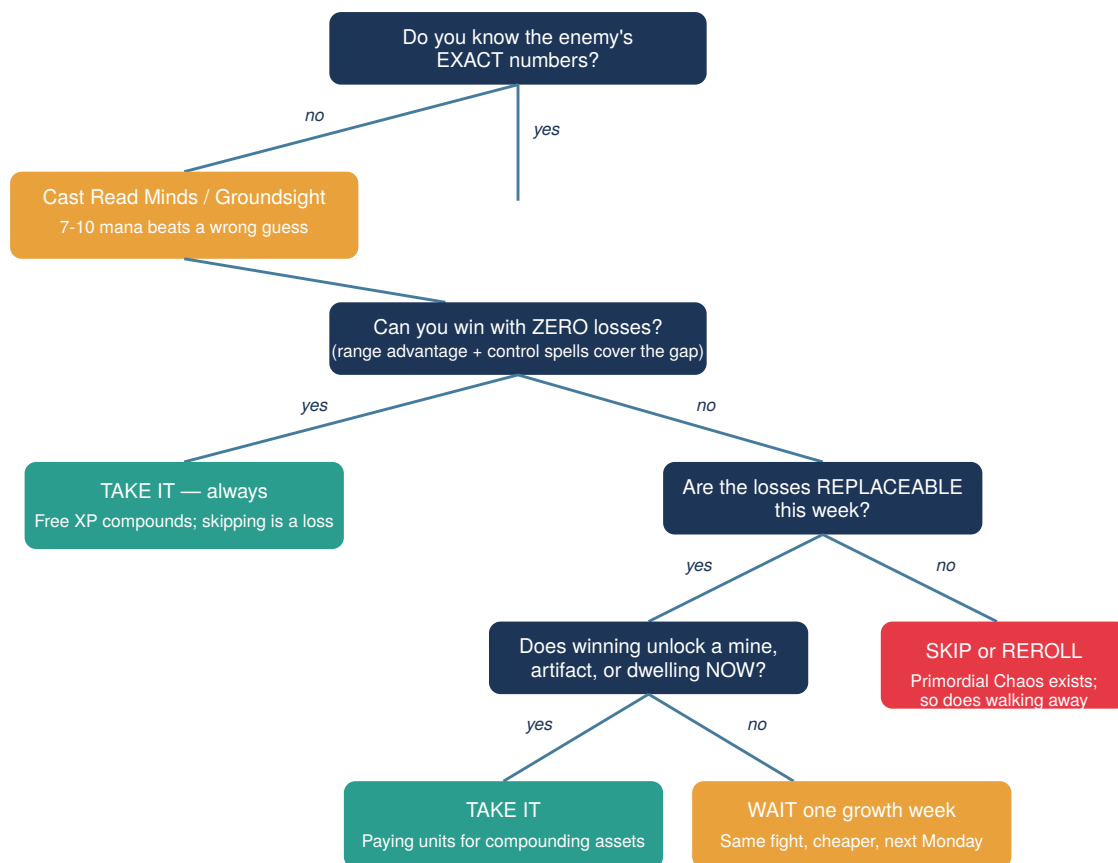


Figure 4: Fight selection decision tree

The most expensive mistakes in a campaign are fights you shouldn’t have taken — and fights you shouldn’t have *skipped*. The tree encodes the Foundations chapter’s Week 1 doctrine: intel first (Read Minds costs 7 mana; a wrong guess costs stacks), zero-loss fights are always taken (XP compounds), and losses are only acceptable when they buy compounding assets — a mine, an artifact, a dwelling — *and* the army regrows this week. The “wait one growth week” box is the most under-used button in the genre: the same fight is cheaper next Monday. Necropolis players: your tree tilts hard toward “take it” — fights are your economy (faction chapter).

Tree 3: What should my hero cast this round?

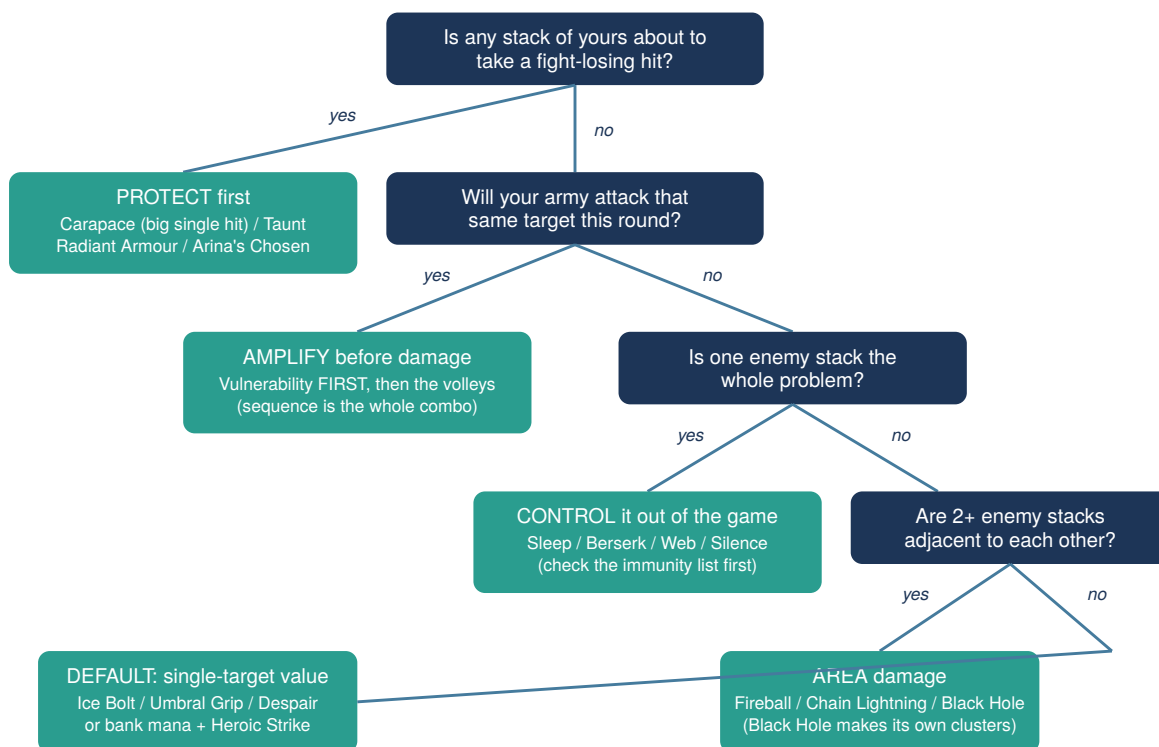


Figure 5: Round-by-round casting decision tree

Eighty-three spells reduce to five questions, in strict priority order: **protect** (a fight-losing hit outranks everything — Carapace for one big hit, Taunt/Radiant Armour for many), **amplify** (if the army attacks a target this round, Vulnerability comes *first* — the sequencing lesson the Nightshade chapter repeats), **control** (one problem stack → remove it from the game, after checking the immunity lists), **area** (2+ adjacent stacks → the AoE suite; Black Hole manufactures its own clusters), and only then **default single-target value**. “Bank mana + Heroic Strike” is a legitimate answer — the Foundations chapter’s free-spell framing.

Tree 4 & 5: the Dungeon pilot’s originals

The project’s first two diagrams, from the Dungeon pilot chapter — kept here so all the book’s trees live in one place. Their faction-agnostic lessons graduated into the Town Development chapter’s six principles (income → cheap tiers → milestone → flex) and the faction chapters’ army-composition advice (one dominant stack, screened).

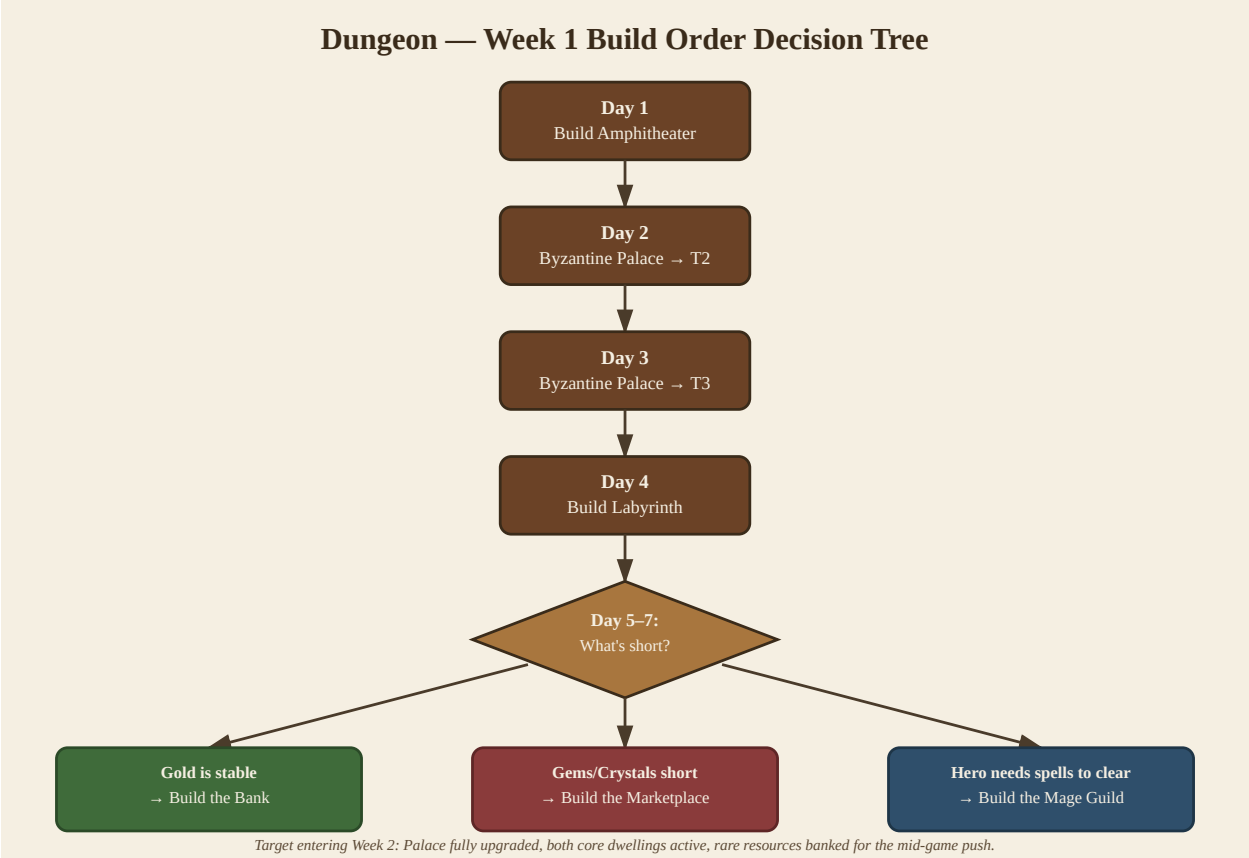


Figure 6: Dungeon week 1 build order

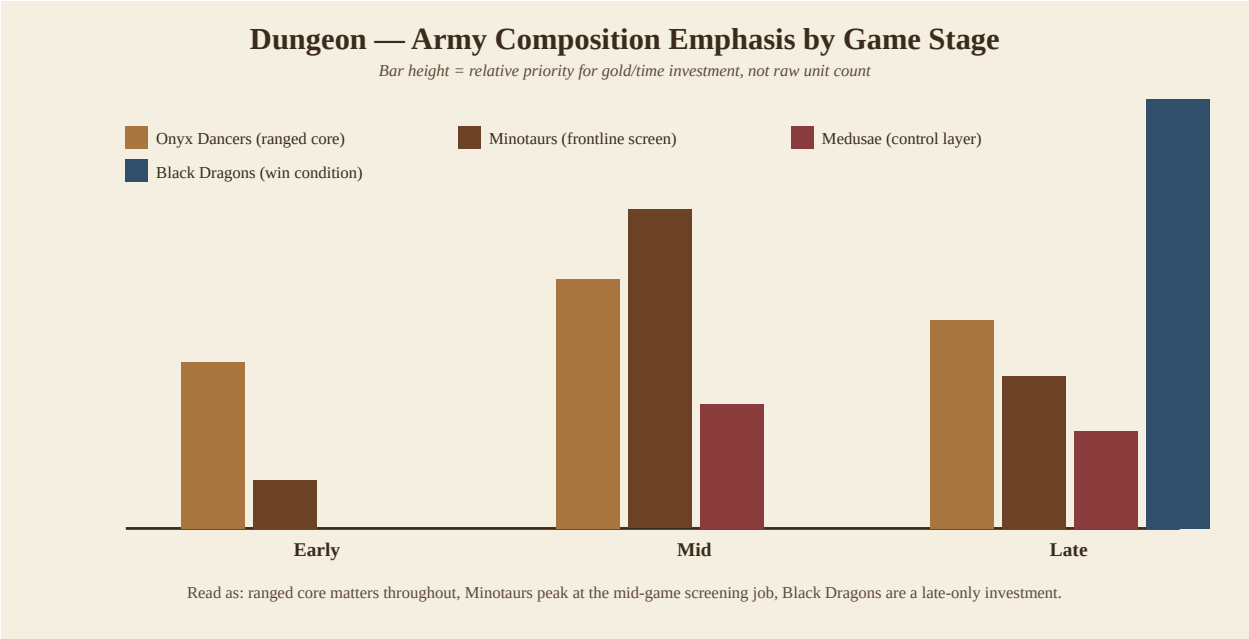


Figure 7: Dungeon army composition by stage

How to read any tree in this book

1. Trees encode *priority order*, not exhaustive options — when two boxes both apply, the higher one wins.
2. Every leaf has a chapter behind it; the tree is the index, the chapter is the argument.
3. Trees are the most patch-fragile content in the book: they compress verdicts, and verdicts move. Check the chapter's `patch_verified` date before trusting a leaf in a tournament.

Sourcing note: all five diagrams are original SVGs created for this book (no game assets used); the decision logic compresses the verified analysis of the chapters referenced above.

Campaign Play — the long game

This book rates everything for campaign because campaign is where the game’s systems compound longest. This chapter collects the campaign-specific doctrine the other chapters built, plus what’s verified about the setting. What it deliberately doesn’t contain: mission-by-mission walkthroughs — the Early Access campaign is still growing, no reliable mission sourcing meets this book’s standard yet, and inventing walkthroughs is exactly what the audits exist to prevent. Tracked as the category’s open gap.

The world you’re fighting over (verified lore)

The setting is **Jadame**, and the six factions’ verified blurbs sketch the war: the Church of the Sun’s High Inquisition (Temple) in renewed conflict with its old enemy **Shadowspire**, home of the Necromancers’ Guild (Necropolis); the **Triumvirate of Alvar** — “formerly underground, currently backstage rulers of Jadame” (Dungeon); a splinter cult of Alvari elves in the Frozen Vast who tore open a Rift after **Lyssara’s** failed expedition (Schism — and she “insists they are under her control,” per the Envoy’s own page, unconvincingly); **Beelzebub’s Order of the Fly** under the Dragonfly King, “bent on conquering Jadame” (Hive); and the Murmurwoods, whose governing body is officially *Unknown* (Grove). Two verified character threads worth watching for: the twinned sisters **Deira** (Dungeon) and **Keiri** (Schism), and campaign-obtainable artifacts — the **Fine Wand** (+1 level to all spells) is confirmed as a campaign mission reward.

The five doctrines (the book’s campaign advice, consolidated)

1. Zero-loss is the win condition inside the win condition. Campaigns are sequences; losses in mission N are weakness in mission N+1. The verified toolkit, in escalating order: fight selection (Tree 2), range + control (Web/Twilight), summons as ammunition (Starchild, Larvae, Communion units — free deaths), healing (Healing Water at 6 mana), and the crown — **Rewind Life**, the book’s only 5/5 campaign spell, because it makes losses *reversible*.

2. Compounding picks beat peak picks. A campaign hero levels for dozens of hours: Pip’s +1 attribute per 2 levels, school-masters’ per-10-level scaling, specialists’ per-2-level spell bonuses, and economy artifacts found early (Skull of Milos) all out-earn flashier immediate power. The heroes chapter’s archetype guidance doubles in weight here.

3. The weekly rhythm is the real difficulty setting. Never skip a build day, never leave growth unrecruited before a hot border, never end a week without spending the logistics suite (Town Portal / Relocation are rated 5/5 and 4/5 *for this mode*). Campaign difficulty is mostly self-inflicted tempo loss.

4. Learn the counter-tech before you need it. The matchup grid's recurring swing cards — Fatal Decay (4 mana, switches off entire sustain factions), anti-summon effects (Heavenly Blades L4, Anti-Magic), Wean against buff-stackers — are cheap to carry and mission-deciding when the campaign throws the matching enemy at you. Campaign enemies telegraph their faction; read the grid's row before the mission, not during.

5. Bank flexibility for the unknown. Early Access campaigns change under your feet (Schism's post-Patch-8 re-tuning is the verified example). Favor heroes and builds this book rates for breadth — school-masters, the four-currency conversion framing from Foundations — over single-trick builds a patch can delete.

Difficulty & mode notes (original analysis, flagged as such)

Where a campaign offers hero carryover between missions, doctrine 2 becomes doctrine zero — every level and artifact is permanent infrastructure, and slow-rolling a won mission to over-level is legitimate play. Where it doesn't, doctrine 3 dominates: fresh starts reward the players with the cleanest Week 1s. The book's faction scores already assume campaign context; for a first campaign, the introduction's reading order stands — Temple, then branch out.

Open gaps (tracked)

Mission-by-mission walkthroughs and scripted-event documentation (awaiting stable sourcing as the Early Access campaign expands); carryover rules per campaign; difficulty-modifier specifics.

Sourcing note: all lore and named details verified against the official pages cited in Parts I–III; the five doctrines consolidate this book's own verified analysis; the difficulty section is original analysis and labeled as such.

Appendix: The Combat Math Under Everything

The formulas this book's battle examples simplify away, verified from first-party stat documentation. This is the page to consult when you want your *exact* numbers instead of the reference-stack approximations.

The damage pipeline

- **Base damage:** the unit's damage roll $\times$ stack size.
- **Attack multiplier:** damage $\times (1 + 5\% \times \text{attacker's Attack})$.
- **Defense reduction:** result $\div (1 + 5\% \times \text{defender's Defense})$.
- Practical shorthand (used throughout this book): each point of Attack-over-Defense shifts the exchange $\sim 5\%$.

Attack types

- **Melee:** adjacent targets only; provokes counterattacks.
- **Ranged:** any distance; -10% damage per hex beyond 3 (floor -50%); forced into a -50% melee swing when adjacent. Units flagged “no range penalty” ignore the falloff; “no melee penalty” keep full damage adjacent; “no penalties” ignore both.
- **Long Reach:** hits the hex behind an adjacent hex — no counterattack provoked, no movement onto the target.

Turn economy

- **Initiative:** turn order within the round (Wait shifts the queue).
- **Speed:** movement range in hexes.
- **Morale:** $+4\%$ chance per point of an extra turn (negative: chance to skip). **Luck:** $+6\%$ chance per point of a Lucky Strike (bonus damage).
- **Native terrain:** $+1$ Initiative for every faction on home ground (Temple: Grass · Necropolis: Deathland · Grove: Autumn · Hive: Lava · Schism: Snow · Dungeon: Dirt); each faction skill's terrain subskill adds $+10\%$ dealt / -10% taken.

Morale/Luck caps by creature type

Each unit type carries its own range — and its Necromancy interaction:

Type	Morale range	Luck range	Feeds Necromancy?
Living	−5...5	−3...3	Yes
Hive Spawn	−5...5	−5...5	Yes
Magic Creature	−3...3	−5...5	Yes
Dragon	0...5	0...3	Yes
Embodiment	−3...3	−3...3	No
Undead	always 0	−5...5	No
Construct	always 0	always 0	No

Two campaign-shaping consequences: **Necromancy harvests almost everything except mirror-Necropolis, Angels-and-spirits, and constructs** — and morale/luck investment is wasted on Undead and Construct armies (their caps are locked at zero).

Stacking morale — the documented ceiling

The per-point trigger chance itself can be boosted: hero specialists (Aeos the Exalted reaches +7% at level 20), the Knight’s Honor artifact set (+5%), the Resolve subskill (+2%, itself doubled by knowing Battlecraft), and the Encouragement law (+2%) stack to **20% per morale point** — at which a morale-5 Living stack triggers extra turns *every single round*. The deepest documented “build-around” in the game’s math.

Focus economy

Creatures earn **Focus Points** by attacking and being attacked; banked points power their active abilities. Levers documented in this book: Murmuring (Grove: 1–3 free charges at battle start), Energize/Energy Explosion (Arcane), Battle March and kin (Offense-tree subskills), Silence (Nightshade: the off-switch).

Sourcing note: formulas and type tables from first-party stat documentation (olden-era.com unit database, retrieved 2026-07-03), cross-consistent with official wiki unit pages. Consequences and shorthand are original analysis.